Dragon Raja I

The Blazing Dawn

Jiang Nan

English Translation Working Draft

This working draft contains the complete prologue and Acts One through Four. The rest of Volume I and the other four books remain in progress.

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Prologue White Emperor City

Act One The Gate to Cassell

Act Two Golden Eyes

Act Three The Dictator

Act Four The Bronze City

When you are at your loneliest and most hopeless, a door will open beside you.

Lu Mingfei waited eighteen years. At the lowest, most pathetic moment of his life, the door opened.

This book is dedicated to every hapless kid with a dream.

Jiang Nan

Prologue

White Emperor City

The fate of the forsaken is to cross the wilderness, raise their battle banners once more, and return to their homeland.

Death is nothing to fear. It is only a long sleep.

Until I can devour this world, I would rather sleep in peace than wander alone.

We will wake again.

"Brother…" Someone was calling softly in the dark.

How annoying. Whose kid had gotten lost?

"Brother," the child called again.

Annoying, annoying, annoying! Brother? No brothers here!

"Brother… I'm going now…" the child murmured, his voice fading into the distance.

Suddenly, he felt a little bad. There was a loneliness in that receding voice. He could almost see the child walking away, like an abandoned little hound.

"All right, all right, all right! What street do you live on? What number? Which door? What's your useless brother's name? I'll take you home!" He rolled over and sat up.

He was sitting on the floor in the sunlight, dressed in white as luminous as the moon. Before him, a white camellia bloomed in a coarse porcelain vase. On the other side of the flower, the child, also in white, bent over a desk with an ink brush in his hand, carefully writing one stroke at a time.

Hey, you haven't left? Were you messing with me? He wanted to say it, but didn't.

Instead, he did something that felt perfectly natural. There was a plate of glistening green grapes on the table. He picked off a small cluster and passed it across to the child.

The child looked up, alarm flickering in his eyes like a startled young animal's. "Brother, there are a lot of people outside."

Bullshit. It's so quiet, he thought.

But just as naturally, something else came out of his mouth. "We may die, I suppose. But don't be afraid, Constantine."

"I'm not afraid. As long as I'm with you, I'm not afraid… But why… won't you eat me? If you ate me, there's no prison you couldn't break out of." The child was completely serious.

Eat… you? Sure, you're all pale and tender-looking, but that doesn't mean you'd taste better than a hamburger. I had one for lunch. I'm not hungry at all, he thought.

"You would make fine food. But then I would be too lonely. For thousands of years, you've been the only one with me." Once again, his words were nothing like his thoughts.

"But dying really is so sad. It's like being sealed inside a black box, forever and ever, pitch-black… Like feeling your way through the night, but no matter how far you reach, your hands never touch a thing…"

“The fate of the forsaken is to cross the wilderness, raise their battle banners once more, and return to their homeland. Death is nothing to fear. It is only a long sleep. Until I can devour this world, I would rather sleep in peace than wander alone. We will wake again.” He could hardly believe such outrageously cool lines were coming out of his mouth.

“Brother… when you raise the battle banners and devour the world, will you eat me?” The child looked at him, something flickering in those clear eyes… anticipation.

What the hell? Was this a scene from We’re One Big Happy Cannibal Family? Your family values are seriously weird!

“Yes. And then you and I will reign over the world together!” Yet he nodded gently, his voice carrying a cold, unyielding authority.

The child poured a cup of water from a pitcher and handed it to him. He drank it in a daze.

“I’m leaving now, Brother. Goodbye.” The child stood up.

He wanted to say, I’m not your brother. You’ve got the wrong person. Instead, he merely said, “Goodbye. Take care of yourself. Humans… cannot be trusted.”

Another strange line, completely out of nowhere.

The child went outside and closed the door behind him. He listened as the footsteps grew fainter and fainter, until they disappeared altogether.

Suddenly, he was a little frightened. What had he been thinking, letting a child that small walk out into the streets alone? What if someone snatched him? Who knew how far he would have to go to find his brother? He grew restless. At last, unable to bear it any longer, he got up and ran for the door.

He pushed it open. Fierce light fell across his white clothes—not sunlight, but firelight. Beneath flames that scorched the sky, the city was screaming. Charred human figures ran through the fire. Thousands upon thousands of arrows rained down. A huge burning signboard tumbled from above, the words WHITE EMPEROR written across it. It was hell itself.

At the very center of the city stood a tall pole. The child hung at its top, his eyes closed, and all the flames in the city were burning him.

It was like some grand sacrifice.

His heart hurt so much, as though a knife were cutting into it. Someone precious had been lost, because he had made a mistake.

Then, suddenly, he remembered. Yes. He really was that child’s brother.

“Constan… tine.” He called the name.

He jerked upright, opening his eyes in the afternoon sunlight, gasping for breath and drenched in cold sweat. Outside came the rumble of a train passing on the elevated tracks.

All at once, that noise sounded wonderful. It reminded him that everything in the dream had been false. He was here, in the ordinary human world.

Act One

The Gate to Cassell

A few times in every life, you feel as though you have seen the gates of heaven swing open. Lu Mingfei had waited eighteen years. At the lowest, most pathetic moment of his life, the gates finally opened.

The angel who walked in swept her gaze around the room, her eyes sharp as knives.

Lu Mingfei typed "GG"—"Good Game," a compliment to your opponent in competitive gaming, and also an admission of defeat—and exited the game.

The last image on the screen was of twelve Terran battlecruisers concentrating their Yamato cannon fire on his Hatchery, turning it into a pool of blood.

He had lost his sixth match of the day. Zero wins, six losses. He had held out for twenty-two minutes and twenty-three seconds in the last one, but had gone down in the end. His opponent had excellent micro, and he played Terran. Marines were an absurdly overpowered unit in StarCraft: no delay before firing, just raise the gun and shoot, lower it and run. Lu Mingfei's Zerglings couldn't catch them, and got picked off one after another along the way.

His opponent was crowing in the chat. "You don't necessarily need tanks when you play Terran against Zerg. The Korean pros don't even build tanks. You just pump out units right from the start, send in a ton of Marines mixed with Medics, keep wearing them down while you push…"

Lu Mingfei could picture the guy's smug, animated face.

He said nothing and switched to QQ. The avatar of the girl in a baseball cap was still gray and motionless. She hadn't come online. Another pointless wait. He scratched his head, a little disappointed. A different avatar began bouncing instead: a panda with an eminently punchable face. The screen name was "Old Tang."

"You're pretty good with Zerg, bro. Let's go again sometime!" Old Tang was the guy who had beaten him. "It's just your micro that needs work. Your strategy's solid."

"Sure," Lu Mingfei said.

Old Tang logged off, full of himself. Lu Mingfei stuck his tongue out at the screen.

If Old Tang had seen how Lu Mingfei was actually playing, he probably wouldn't have felt so pleased. He would have called him a freak and never played him again. Lu Mingfei was using an old IBM laptop with no mouse attached, controlling everything with the little red pointing stick. Only a lunatic would play StarCraft on a pointing stick. It was like cleaning your ears with a rolling pin. If he plugged in a mouse, Old Tang probably wouldn't make it to the eight-minute mark. But then how would he kill the time?

Besides, Lu Mingfei couldn't be bothered to explain that he was only making things harder for himself out of boredom. He had a lot of time to kill. What if Old Tang refused to play next time?

But however much time he killed, she still didn't come online.

Why bother? Sometimes he asked himself that. Waiting and waiting like an idiot, four hours for two or three lines of conversation. It hardly seemed worth it.

But who could calculate what something like that was worth?

“A case of that milk in bags that’s on sale, half a jin of Cantonese sausage, and the new issue of Fiction Illustrated for Mingze. Come straight back when you’re done, and trim the celery on the table! And check the gatehouse for letters from America! Still playing games? You don’t care about your own future at all! If nobody admits you, do you think you can get into a first-tier university on your exam scores? All that money we’ve spent on you—what good has it done?” His aunt’s voice thundered from the next room.

His head buzzing, Lu Mingfei rattled off a string of yeses and scurried out. The hallway was quiet. Afternoon sunlight came through the window at the end of the stairwell, spilling warm across him. Pure white sheets hung along the corridor. Outside, the wind stirred glossy green leaves with a rustling sound. He leaned against the door, listening to his aunt’s endless complaints inside. With the door between them, it seemed to belong to another world.

Spring again. Lu Mingfei, senior in high school, nearly eighteen.

He lived with his uncle and aunt and had a younger cousin named Lu Mingze. He attended the most prestigious private high school in the city: steep tuition, stern teachers, luxury cars streaming past, beautiful girls drifting by like clouds. In three months and four days, he would have to sit the national college entrance exam. These days, everyone he met earnestly informed him that doomsday was approaching and he ought to get fired up.

But the more pressure there was, the lazier Lu Mingfei became. When he wasn’t playing StarCraft, he lay on his bed staring at the ceiling.

For someone whose presence barely registered, his laziness was easy enough to understand.

Lu Mingfei hadn’t seen his parents in more than six years. The good news was that they were supposedly still alive, and wrote him a letter every six months. The bad news was that every time they wrote, his mother regretfully explained that their plan to return to China to visit him had been postponed again, because “there have been new developments.”

His parents were both archaeologists, supposedly working on a major project whose results, once announced, would astonish the world as much as Sven Hedin’s discovery of ancient Loulan. In middle school, Lu Mingfei had been very proud of them. He read lots of books about archaeology and talked about it enthusiastically with his classmates on the way home. But he soon realized that the ones who should be proud were the guys whose parents came to pick them up. After school, a pack of boys would saunter down the street side by side, taking up nearly half the road. Then a car horn would sound behind them, and one of the guys would instantly stop swaggering, climb obediently into the family car, and disappear. One by one they peeled away, until usually only Lu Mingfei remained, still swaggering along by himself.

Looking out through their car windows, the others watched him kick a stone and wander freely into the distance, and envied him terribly. He could go anywhere he wanted. Browse a mall, buy a snack, even shoot some pool.

“Lu Mingfei’s family treats him the best. They never make him do anything.”

In fact, when Lu Mingfei was alone, he didn't browse malls or play pool. Once he had sat in the internet café long enough to feel sick of it, he went home. But after entering the building, he didn't go inside the apartment. He squeezed through the iron grating that led to the roof, sat beside a humming air-conditioning unit, and looked out over the city until the sun went down.

Lu Mingfei thought of his parents as Superman and Superwoman. Perhaps if the plane they were on crashed one day, they would finally appear before him, holding it up as they brought it safely to earth. Otherwise, they would always be busy saving the world, rather than doing anything for him, Lu Mingfei. Superhero parents were certainly something to brag about. In practice, though, they might as well not exist. He could barely remember what they looked like anymore. Only when he occasionally looked at an old family photograph could he faintly recall that man and woman, and their old house with its walls covered in Virginia creeper.

What interested his uncle and aunt more was the money his parents regularly sent from abroad. Thanks to that money, Lu Mingfei could attend an elite private high school. Thanks to it, his uncle and aunt could buy a small-engine BMW, his uncle could afford convincing counterfeit designer goods, and his aunt had money to lose at mahjong. Thanks to it, his cousin Lu Mingze had acquired the nickname "Crown Prince Ze" at school. The cousins attended the same high school. Lu Mingze not only had better grades, but dressed more carefully, and whenever girls joined him for a meal, he insisted on paying. His parents even dressed especially well for his parent-teacher conferences, leaving everyone with the impression that he was a child raised in a jar of honey.

If Lu Mingze hadn't been 160 centimeters tall and weighed 160 jin—eighty kilos—he probably would have found a girlfriend long ago.

And Lu Mingfei was merely "Lu Mingze's older cousin."

Lu Mingfei didn't particularly mind. Even his parents didn't care about him. How much could he ask of an uncle and aunt?

With both hands in his pockets, his head drooping and his eyes on the ground, Lu Mingfei went downstairs. He bought what his aunt wanted at the convenience store, then wandered over to the bookstall for the latest Fiction Illustrated.

His aunt thought Lu Mingze was clever, studious, ambitious, and especially devoted to literature. Even reading Fiction Illustrated became "our Mingze is studying" in her mouth. Every time a new issue appeared, she took it as another development in Chinese youth literature and hurried Lu Mingfei out to buy it so Mingze could keep up.

The old man at the newsstand downstairs thought Lu Mingfei was both melancholy and a bit of a freeloader, with a passion for literature. He was always buying Fiction Illustrated, though he never read it. Instead, he squatted beside the stand and read the latest Home Computers and Games for free, tossed it back, frankly declared that it was getting worse and worse, dusted off his pants, and left.

Lu Mingfei had a quietly sneaky streak. Lu Mingze was forever saying things like "in my house" and ordering his cousin to do this or that. Lu Mingfei always complied. Then, out of sheer pettiness, he visited Lu Mingze's secret Qzone page.

After reading some literature, Lu Mingze had adopted the pen name "Lonely Snake" and copied a great many sorrowful sentences onto his Qzone, alongside close-up selfies taken on his phone. Occasionally he uploaded pictures of his wrists smeared with red ink to look as if he had cut them, with poems more or less saying that without love he might as well die. Lu Mingfei knew his cousin's

romantic instincts were stirring. At school, any budding romance died the moment the girl saw him in daylight, so now he was hoping for a thunderous collision of souls on QQ.

Lu Mingfei registered a new QQ account under the name “Sunset’s Imprint.” He uploaded a photo of a cute, short-haired girl, entered his age as sixteen, and set his status to “Let your smiles and sorrows leave their imprint on my life.” While Lu Mingze was online at home, he slipped off to an internet café and struck up a conversation with Lonely Snake. Before long, Lu Mingze apparently felt that his little snake had finally found something delicious, and was more than happy to let his smiles and sorrows leave their imprint on a girl’s life. At home, he cheerfully hummed Shin’s “Parting Song” every day; on QQ, he kept asking to meet, ready to launch into an earth-shattering romance. Lu Mingfei agreed with absolute conviction, but always set the date for when his aunt would be dragging Lu Mingze off to piano lessons. Each time, the lovely girl slipped through his cousin’s fingers, leaving him bitterly distraught and lending his renditions of “Parting Song” a rather mournful note.

It was the happiest thing that had happened to Lu Mingfei lately.

That was the sort of person Lu Mingfei was. Not especially good, not particularly capable of doing anything bad. Almost eighteen, and he still had no idea where his future lay.

“Mingfei, I hear you’re going abroad to study,” the old newsstand owner said idly.

“Hardly. I’ve only applied. Who’d take me?” Lu Mingfei was squatting beside the stand, helping himself to a magazine.

“Studying abroad is good. Come back with a foreign degree, and you’ll make plenty of money.”

“I don’t want plenty of money. If I can’t get into college, I’ll help you run the stand. Just pay me enough to buy PS2 games.”

“No ambition. There’s no money in running a newsstand. I only do it because I’m old.”

Lu Mingfei rolled his eyes up toward the sunlight filtering through the green leaves. “Seems pretty nice. You can sit in the sun, space out when no one’s around, and watch pretty girls go by.”

The subject rather depressed him. He had applied to American universities, but certainly not because his grades were so dazzling that he stood much chance. Everyone had a different way of assessing his academic performance. His homeroom teacher said, “Lu Mingfei, were you born a lead weight? Do you have any idea how much you single-handedly drag down our class average?” His aunt told his uncle, “Mingze gets his good grades from my side of the family. Just look at your family’s genes. Hopeless!” Only Lu Mingze showed him any consideration, encouraging him on QQ: “Sunset! So what if your grades are bad? People like us have to walk our own path! As far as I’m concerned, you’re a wonderful girl!”

The idea of sending him abroad had come to his aunt in a flash of inspiration, and she had championed it single-handedly. She stood over him while he filled in the applications and generously paid the several-dozen-dollar fee for each school. She had her reasons. English was the only subject Lu Mingfei was decent at. When he tagged along with his English-obsessed classmates to take the TOEFL, he had enjoyed a spectacular stroke of dumb luck and scored well. With his grades, a first-tier Chinese university was a long shot. Skipping the national exam to study abroad was fashionable these days. They could try the applications, and if another stroke of dumb luck landed him an American acceptance letter, she would have something to show for all the money his parents had sent.

His aunt also had a second, "smaller" calculation. Lu Mingze's grades were a little better than Lu Mingfei's, but hardly outstanding. He couldn't get into the famous universities she was always talking about, like Tsinghua or Peking University. Skipping the exam to study abroad would be a respectable alternative. But college determined your whole life; she couldn't bear to let Mingze take that risk. After much thought, she seemed to recall some famous saying about how "every difficult path must first be trodden by the tough soles of the brave." Suddenly, Lu Mingfei struck her as very brave indeed. She would have him use those tough soles to tread a path for Lu Mingze. If he failed, no harm done. It would merely prove the path was blocked. Lu Mingfei could wait a year and take the entrance exam alongside his cousin.

Unfortunately, courage alone clearly couldn't open that difficult path. It was strewn with ankle-twisting stones. More than a dozen replies had already arrived, and their openings were much alike:

"Dear Applicant:

Thank you for your interest in our college. We regret to inform you…"

Several hundred dollars in application fees had bought his aunt nothing but repeated expressions of gratitude from Americans. Charity was proving painful. Lu Mingfei, meanwhile, was neither anxious nor impatient. He had the serene stillness of an old monk in meditation. He merely squeezed out a sorrowful expression whenever another rejection arrived, to keep his aunt company in her disappointment.

Only one university had yet to reply: the most highly ranked of the prestigious schools, the University of Chicago.

"Any mail for me?" Lu Mingfei poked his head around the gatehouse door, putting on an English accent. "Mingfei Lu."

"Yes. From America." The guard tossed out a letter.

Lu Mingfei felt the envelope. One thin sheet of paper. Definitely a rejection. Acceptance letters came with forms and informational materials, a whole thick stack. Thanking you for your application and regretting that you hadn't been admitted took only a single printed page.

He tore the envelope open. To his surprise, the letter was written in Chinese:

Dear Mr. Lu Mingfei:

Thank you for your interest in the University of Chicago. We regret to inform you that you have not been admitted.

However, as we often say, there is more than one road. The question is whether you are willing to take it.

Allow us first to introduce ourselves. Cassell College is a private institution located on the far outskirts of Chicago, Illinois, in the United States. We are affiliated with the University of Chicago and maintain extensive academic exchanges with it.

We have had the honor of receiving your application materials from the University of Chicago. Following a careful evaluation, we believe you meet Cassell College's admission requirements and would like to extend this invitation to you.

Please contact our Professor Guderian as soon as you receive this letter. He is currently on an academic visit to China and will arrange your interview.

Should you have any questions, please also contact Professor Guderian. I will assist him in providing any help you may require. My name is Norma Lawrence, secretary of Cassell College. It is a great pleasure to make your acquaintance.

Yours sincerely,

Norma

Lu Mingfei lowered the letter and felt his forehead, rather dazed.

It had begun perfectly normally, a standard rejection letter. How had everything changed after "However, as we often say, there is more than one road. The question is whether you are willing to take it"? Apparently, he was already on an interview list. Some of his high school classmates had successfully applied abroad, but an American professor traveling all this way to interview someone was a first. Lu Mingfei couldn't imagine what he had done to deserve it. He hadn't even contributed an application fee to this Cassell College.

Had Lu Mingze discovered Sunset's Imprint's true identity? Was this some elaborate revenge?

But the postmark on the envelope really was from Illinois, USA.

He tipped the envelope upside down. Apart from that one sheet of expensive paper, there was nothing else inside. That settled it: this had to be a scam. It told him to contact some Professor Guderian immediately, but didn't even give him a phone number. The thought actually made him feel a little better.

"Sign here." The guard tossed him another slip.

"You have to sign for letters?" Lu Mingfei asked, puzzled.

"A package came with it. You have to sign for that."

Still confused, Lu Mingfei signed and received a large FedEx envelope with something hard inside. He hesitated, tore it open, and tipped out… a phone.

An all-black N96.

Lu Mingfei felt he needed a moment to collect himself. He switched it on. The battery was actually more than half full. There was a single entry in the contacts: Professor Guderian.

"Definitely a con artist! And someone who lives in this complex! Only someone who knows us would know our situation!" His aunt slapped the letter and delivered her verdict with absolute certainty.

"But what con artist would spend that much? It's an N96! Even a gray-market one costs over four thousand yuan. An official one's over five thousand!" His uncle kept covering the black phone with fingerprints, like an old woman caressing a jade bangle passed down through the family.

His uncle was a man of taste. Lu Mingfei had once had the privilege of accompanying him to dinner and watching him set his phone down with his left hand and his lighter with his right, each landing on the table with just the right weight. In the course of conversation, he casually rolled up his sleeve to reveal a high-quality fake Montblanc watch bought in Guangzhou, winning unanimous praise for his taste. Lately, he had mentioned more than once to Lu Mingze that the new N96 was very "high-end" and suited him perfectly. But his aunt, who controlled the family finances, had given him a firm "No!"

"What Cassell College? It's got to be after our money! Affiliated with the University of Chicago, my foot. Chu Zihang, who ranked first in our school, went abroad last year to a college affiliated with

Chicago, too. One of his cousins is a university professor and already has a green card. Those colleges affiliated with famous universities are practically Ivy League. Even Americans can't get in!" Lu Mingze rarely took such an interest in his older cousin's future.

Lu Mingfei knew Chu Zihang was Lu Mingze's idol. When most of the other students were still wearing Nike and Adidas, Chu Zihang was already into brands like Burberry. He would loosely knot a Burberry scarf over a Diesel pullover and walk down the corridor with an expressionless face, and the whole school would call his look British. Once, two girls had been disciplined for clawing each other's faces over "whose Chu Zihang was," even though he had never so much as spoken to either of them.

Lu Mingze recounted this senior's exploits to Sunset's Imprint, declaring inspirationally that one day he would proudly prove to the whole school that he was every bit as good as Chu Zihang.

Lu Mingfei thought the real issue was all those flirtatious looks from girls across the grade. Lu Mingze cared more about "how to become a male lion ruling over a pride of lionesses" than about being as accomplished as Chu Zihang.

Lu Mingfei didn't envy Chu Zihang at all. Sometimes he thought, These people treat Chu Zihang like an idol, but none of them knows what he's doing in America. Maybe he's washing dishes in a restaurant. Without anyone teaching him, he had developed something of Ah Q's knack for consoling himself.

His Chinese teacher once held up his essay as a bad example and savaged it in class, saying it showed no imagination, only pessimism—just like its author, who had no ambition whatsoever.

Lu Mingfei had felt a little like standing up and saying that he had fantasies, too.

Once, after watching all three Matrix films back-to-back, he had suddenly felt that he must possess some extraordinary ability that had yet to be discovered. Like Neo, he was "the One." One day, a mysterious figure would come to uncover his power. Beneath everyone's blazing gaze, he would transform… and do something that shook the world.

But while delivering his criticism, the Chinese teacher had his lofty gaze fixed on the dozing students in the back rows and didn't spare Lu Mingfei so much as a sidelong glance. Lu Mingfei could only duck his head and abandon his explanation of his inner journey.

No one would discuss this magnificent idea with him, so he kept elaborating the details by himself. By senior year, the fantasy had acquired a full set of scenes. Whenever the school held its Lunar New Year gala, the pretty little piano prodigy Liu Miaomiao, who had passed the Grade Ten exam, would play onstage while the boys in her class danced around the piano in matching black formalwear. Lu Mingfei would sit in a forgotten corner with his chin in his hand, imagining that perhaps a helicopter would descend from the sky to collect him. Men in black suits and dark glasses would enter the hall with the icy efficiency of CIA agents in a movie and say in low voices, "Mr. Lu Mingfei, this is no time for a New Year's show. The organization needs you." They would put him in a black military uniform and a long trench coat, then escort him out under the eyes of his classmates. Outside, a black helicopter would roar, its great rotors whipping up a wind that cut across their faces like knives. Then the pretty Liu Miaomiao and all the dancing boys would stop and stare blankly at his retreating back.

The point of the story was never how he would save the world. It was the way everyone else would look at him as he left.

So. Damn. Cool.

Lu Mingfei knew perfectly well that the fantasy was only a way to pass the time. But he could find nothing about himself to be proud of. As far as he could tell, his future would be to attend some obscure college, fall in love there, then graduate, find a job, and rent an apartment. Perhaps when his parents occasionally remembered him, they would urge him to get married. So he would marry, have a child, and go to work every day.

And now, with this letter from America, something was actually going to disturb the stagnant pool of his life. Yet in the family meeting, he felt like an outsider, huddled in one corner of the sofa with his hands placed obediently on his knees, while the endless chatter of his uncle, aunt, and Lu Mingze filled the living room.

He stood and left. No one noticed the departure of the person at the center of it all. The other three kept arguing about whether the interview invitation was real. His aunt and Lu Mingze seemed rather shaken. If it was genuine, it was a spectacular stroke of dumb luck, the kind that didn't come to anyone once in ten years, and somehow it had come to Lu Mingfei. His aunt wasn't used to seeing this droopy boy suddenly perk up. How was Mingze supposed to outdo him now?

Lu Mingfei returned to his room, logged onto QQ, and stared at the baseball-cap girl's avatar. Still gray. Offline or invisible—either way, no message. He glanced at the clock on the wall. It had been eighteen hours since he had left Chen Wenwen a message asking whether she would attend the literary club activity tomorrow night.

Chen Wenwen didn't actually wear baseball caps. Her long hair was soft, fine, straight, and lovely; it needed no covering. Lu Mingfei had met her on the first day of school. She had arrived discreetly in a Passat, wearing a white cotton dress and white ankle socks edged with lace, a Hello Kitty clip in her long hair. The most dazzling girl in his class should have been Su Xiaoqiang, the "Little Celestial Princess." That day she had arrived in a Mercedes S500, dressed head to toe in DKNY, pride dancing in every glance. After waving goodbye to her coal-business father, she had gone to register, appraising the boys in her new class and expecting their admiring looks in return. But the boys were all stealing glances toward a corner by the window. Having finished her paperwork, Chen Wenwen sat there on a bench with a copy of Marguerite Duras's The Lover. Sunlight shone on her cotton dress and skin, making everything seem translucent.

After fifteen years of being the proudest girl around, the Little Celestial Princess had lost to a young literary type on her very first day of high school. She seethed. To make things worse, a tactless boy beside her pointed toward Chen Wenwen and said quietly, "I guess she's the prettiest girl in our new class."

When had the Little Celestial Princess ever suffered such humiliation? She stamped hard on his foot and turned away.

That boy was Lu Mingfei.

Really, Lu Mingfei was an honest person. He thought Chen Wenwen was prettier than the Little Celestial Princess, so he said so. How could he have known it would earn him a three-year feud? There had been seven or eight boys admiring Chen Wenwen, all thinking the same thing. The others simply understood the principle of "admiring in silence." Later, those boys formed a literary club with Chen Wenwen at its center. They met every week to read cold, sorrowful works of European and American literature and wrote reading responses for the Chinese teacher to mark. Lu Mingfei's uncle described

these as books for “middle-class white women” and couldn’t understand how someone as scatterbrained as Lu Mingfei had become a club officer.

To Lu Mingfei, Chen Wenwen was the first girl he had ever idolized, his model of the good girl who would make a happy home. At fifteen, he had thought there could be no greater happiness in the world than marrying her. He believed he had a tiny chance because she had personally invited him to join the club. As president, Chen Wenwen had invited only two members: Lu Mingfei and Zhao Menghua, whom the Little Celestial Princess was determined to have for herself. Zhao Menghua was easy to describe. Of everyone in the school, he was the likeliest to become “the next Chu Zihang.”

Zhao Menghua was applying abroad, too, and hadn’t received any offers either. Yet this muddleheaded Cassell College had sent an interview invitation to Lu Mingfei.

“Up for a match?” A big-faced cat avatar was flashing on QQ. The name was “Nono.” Lu Mingfei couldn’t remember adding this person, but he never turned down an invitation. Few enough people added him in the first place.

“Sure,” he replied absently.

Lu Mingfei was still using the pointing stick. Something was on his mind, he felt sluggish, and Nono sounded like a girl’s name. The genuinely good players in the channel were all middle-aged-guy types. But he soon discovered that this opponent was not only vicious but cunning. The moment his attention wandered, two Zerglings ambushed the Drone he had sent to scout. Losing one Drone was no big deal, but that neat little trap put him on his guard. He reinforced his base and sent six Zerglings to patrol nearby. It saved him. He spotted the enemy squad of Zerglings the instant they entered his territory. Their chance at a surprise attack gone, they had to pull back at once.

Lu Mingfei didn’t dare get careless again. He plugged in the mouse.

Only then did the real battle begin. Both sides upgraded their main forces from Zerglings to Hydralisks, and both simultaneously sent Mutalisks on air raids while their Hydralisks attacked, opening up a second front. By the time the Queens appeared, the fighting was white-hot. Each player had four bases. Mixed armies fought a savage tug-of-war over the open ground in the center, splashing sheets of blood across the battlefield. Sweat broke out on Lu Mingfei’s forehead. His hands danced over the keyboard as if he were playing the piano. It couldn’t be easy for the other player, either. The way they were pushing their micro was close to professional level. He had never faced anyone this strong. His competitive streak stirred, and he decided to risk upgrading his main base to tier three and bringing out the “three-horse team”: Devourers, Guardians, and Ultralisks. It was a fundamental shift in strategy. If his opponent hesitated even briefly and failed to attack while he was spending his resources on the upgrade, victory would be his.

The progress bar crept forward. His heart raced and his palms sweated. To bluff, he added a squad of Hydralisks and three Lurkers outside. If his opponent believed he was massing a large army and held back, she would have fallen for it. Those were all the troops he had. Every other resource had gone into the upgrade.

Almost there. Once the upgrade finished and the three-horse team appeared, he could advance through the air and on the ground, steadily picking off enemy bases one after another.

Lu Mingfei could see the first light of victory.

“You’re teching to tier three.” A line of text appeared at the bottom of the screen.

Lu Mingfei froze.

"Just quit. I've got four squads of Hydras and four of Lings, all with level-two attack and armor," Nono continued typing.

The progress bar was almost full, but Lu Mingfei could only type "GG." As she typed, Nono had shared her vision with him. Outside his main base, still upgrading to tier three, her army was massed. Once it attacked, the victory would be crushing.

Lu Mingfei left the game, returned to QQ, and told Nono, "Respect!"

Nono didn't answer. She left a grinning, big-toothed laughing emoji and logged off.

For the first time in his life, Lu Mingfei felt that someone had seen right through him. It was like a dearest friend, gone for years, coming back to find him. He sat there in a daze for a while, then clicked on Nono's profile. It was blank. He searched his memory and was certain he had never known a StarCraft player that good—much less a girl.

Chen Wenwen's avatar was bouncing in his contact list, but it was gray. She had come online and already left.

"Sure. See you the day after tomorrow." That was her message.

He had waited almost nineteen hours for those few words. But his low spirits seemed to evaporate. He jumped onto his bed, whistled, wiggled his hips, and beamed, completely forgetting that Nono had beaten him.

When Lu Mingze entered their shared bedroom, he looked his older cousin up and down and said impatiently, "Mom and Dad called that Professor Guderian. Your interview's at the Regent Hotel the day after tomorrow. They said you should get ready."

The following evening.

"Hey, Old Tang. Do you know what they ask in American college interviews?" Lu Mingfei typed on QQ.

"What? You got an interview?" Old Tang's panda avatar bounced frantically.

Old Tang was the only person Lu Mingfei could think of who might help. He lived in New York and was Chinese American. His last name was probably Tang. Everyone called him Old Tang, though he wasn't particularly old. Apparently, he had grown up in America, so his spoken Chinese wasn't very fluent, but he managed well enough typing online. Apart from occasionally thinking a little too highly of himself, Old Tang had no serious faults. His ambition in life was to become Indiana Jones.

"Yeah. Tomorrow morning. I've searched all over the internet, but I still don't know what they'll ask," Lu Mingfei admitted.

"Well… different schools ask completely different questions. NYU and Harvard, for example, are nothing alike."

"So which do you know better, Harvard or NYU?"

"Didn't I tell you I entered the workforce right after high school?" Old Tang posted a dejected panda face.

"'Entered the workforce'! Now that phrase shows real progress in your Chinese!"

"Enough, enough. Let's video chat. I'll coach your pronunciation," Old Tang said.

Lu Mingfei glanced at Lu Mingze, asleep on the other bed, and hesitated. “Keep it down, then. My cousin’s sleeping.”

“No problem.”

The call beeped twice and connected. A cheerful-looking guy with drooping eyebrows waved from the window and thundered, “Hey! Bro!”

Lu Mingfei nearly lunged forward and swallowed the speakers.

“Quiet! Quiet!” Waving frantically at Old Tang, he unplugged them and connected his headset.

“What’s the big deal?” Old Tang muttered. “My place is right by the elevated tracks. It’s noisy here. Where are you, anyway? Why so careful?”

“I live with my uncle and aunt,” Lu Mingfei whispered.

“Oh, oh.” Old Tang nodded and lowered his voice, his Chinese sliding off-key. “So if this application works out, you can move out on your own? You should’ve said! Leave that interview to me!”

“You’re a real friend, Old Tang.” Lu Mingfei gave him a thumbs-up.

“As the number-one StarCraft player in the channel, if I don’t look out for number two, what kind of big brother am I?” Old Tang said. “Ha ha!”

For a moment, Lu Mingfei was touched. He felt a little more confident about tomorrow. He had drifted around all day, watched the sunset from the roof as usual, and still had no idea what to do. No one could tell him what an American college interview was like. The other applicants were probably having their pronunciation corrected word by word by tutors or parents. But Lu Mingfei had no one to help. After wandering around online for ages, he had happened to see Old Tang’s avatar bouncing and messaged him on the off chance. He didn’t even know Old Tang that well.

So there was someone, in some corner of the world he hadn’t thought of, who could help him after all. Someone with a baffling determination to play big brother and look after him.

Loyalty. This was loyalty!

“Come to think of it, I lost both my parents, too,” Old Tang went on with a sigh. “It’s hard getting by in America, you know, especially for people like us with both parents gone. At least I can get welfare…”

“Pah, pah, pah! Who lost both their parents? My mom and dad are just away from home!” Lu Mingfei spat furiously at him.

“Oh, oh. Saw-ree, saw-ree. Got the wrong end of the stick and the wrong end of the feelings.” Old Tang repeatedly clasped his hands in apology on the screen.

“Come on, man. Can you stop mangling Chinese? And what’s ‘saw-ree’? It’s ‘sorry,’ all right? Aren’t you supposed to be coaching my accent?” Lu Mingfei had no answer for his complete lack of a filter.

“Right, right. And once we’re done, we’ve got a few more matches to play. Come on, let’s start!” Old Tang cleared his throat. “The most common opening question is, why did you apply to our school? ‘Why did you apply this college, please show me some reason?’”

“But I didn’t apply…”

"Come on! No talking back. Repeat after me! I'm taking responsibility for your future, bro! 'The great faculty is the key reason, and your college have very good research atmosphere…'"

"'The great faculty is the key reason, and your college have very good research atmosphere…'" Lu Mingfei repeated each sound after Old Tang.

Night deepened. The small southern city grew still. Streetlights illuminated empty roads. Most apartment lights were out; only a few scattered windows remained bright. Behind one of them, a boy repeated the same sentences over and over in his indistinct pronunciation, cramming at the last minute. Tens of thousands of miles away, a guy eating yogurt shouted "No, no, no!" at every sound he got wrong.

Lu Mingze rolled his eyes, glanced at Lu Mingfei, grunted impatiently, stuffed both hands over his ears, and turned over.

The third morning. The Regent Hotel.

It was the most luxurious hotel in the city, part of a global five-star chain. Lu Mingfei knew the place because his uncle loved drinking tea and chatting with friends in its lobby, having the waiters refill the pot until the strong tea became plain water. It cost little that way, while allowing him the satisfaction of enjoying world-class service.

Lu Mingfei had never been through its glass doors. Now he looked around with eyes red from staying up all night.

This hotel is fucking luxurious! American schools are fucking rich! he marveled.

He sat outside a conference room on the executive floor. There were exactly seventeen chairs, one for each of the seventeen applicants. No one had asked for identification. As he had cautiously stepped through the hotel entrance, an attendant had smiled and asked, "Are you here for the Cassell College interview? Please follow me to the executive floor." Then a pretty young woman in a skirt suit and ten-centimeter heels had led him to this room, where he found familiar faces.

Chen Wenwen, Su Xiaoqiang, Zhao Menghua, and Liu Miaomiao were all there. So were others from his school whose faces he knew but whose names he couldn't remember, along with some he had never seen.

"Lu Mingfei?" Everyone who knew him sounded equally astonished, as though his presence here were an extraordinary event.

He could only wave the letter in his hand and grin. "I'm here for…" He swallowed. "…an interview, too."

Then he slunk to the last chair. A form and a pencil lay on it. The form asked for his name, age, and similar details. He filled it in while his eyes darted around.

Things looked utterly hopeless. Everyone had prepared, and every one of them was formidable. Zhao Menghua's pronunciation went without saying: his tutor was American. So did Su Xiaoqiang's: she had spent a year in America during middle school. Even the usually casual Chen Wenwen had coordinated her outfit carefully: a navy skirt suit, white lace-edged socks, flat black shoes, and a white neck scarf. She had replaced her hair clip with one made of mother-of-pearl. She looked like one of those British aristocrats' children in their school uniforms on television.

Lu Mingfei scratched his head and sighed.

"She looks so nice." Having lost interest in comparing their chances, he turned to admire Chen Wenwen.

An attendant brought refreshments: a croissant and a glass of hot milk. Lu Mingfei ate the bread, drank the milk, and, with the problem of basic survival solved, went back to watching Chen Wenwen. After a while, a thought flashed through his head… What if a stroke of dumb luck got him through, and he could study abroad with her?

He looked up at the ceiling and suddenly gave two foolish chuckles, startling the people around him.

"Lu Mingfei, quiet. The interviewers are here. They're inside." Chen Wenwen covered her mouth as she whispered, pointing toward the inner conference room.

"Are you ready?" Beaming, he leaned over to make conversation. It was a pointless question. He only wanted to hear her speak.

"I'm not very confident." Chen Wenwen glanced at Su Xiaoqiang and Zhao Menghua, then lowered her eyes, looking a little discouraged. "My spoken English isn't as good as theirs…"

"You'll be fine! I think your English is really…" Lu Mingfei began.

"Is Liu Miaomiao here?" The inner door opened and a tall, thin young man stepped out, speaking fluent Chinese and looking as unmistakably Chinese as anyone could. He wore a fitted dark-green suit, finely edged in silver at the collar. Gold buttons and cuffs gleamed, and a badge embroidered in silver thread rested on his chest. It looked like a school uniform, but Lu Mingfei had never seen one so exquisitely tailored.

The pretty pianist shot to her feet, her voice trembling slightly. "Here!"

"I'm Ye Sheng, one of your interviewers. Please come with me." The young man smiled, showing white teeth.

Liu Miaomiao walked gracefully inside with Ye Sheng. The door closed. The sixteen people left outside looked at one another, none able to hide their nerves.

"Hey, did you look up this Cassell College's website?" Zhao Menghua glanced at Su Xiaoqiang and Chen Wenwen, lowering his voice. "Apparently, it's a really prestigious school. Lots of Harvard professors have gone over to teach there!"

"Yes." Chen Wenwen nodded. "But I got an interview invitation without even applying."

"Prestigious schools are like that, aren't they? They don't care about application fees. Just your ability," Zhao Menghua said.

"If they only care about ability, how did someone like that sneak in?" Su Xiaoqiang gave Lu Mingfei a sidelong look.

Lu Mingfei shrugged his shoulders with the shameless indifference of someone who had nothing left to lose.

"I wonder how many they'll admit," Chen Wenwen whispered.

"One or two would be plenty!" Su Xiaoqiang said. "Haven't you heard? Harvard only admits a few undergraduates from China each year."

Lu Mingfei's heart sank. He had no idea how many Chinese students Harvard admitted annually, but if there were only a handful in a country this huge, the odds of that particular stroke of dumb luck landing on him were microscopic. Eight-tenths of his hard-won confidence vanished.

"Well, I'm just here to try. I don't have much hope," Chen Wenwen said softly.

"None of us does," Zhao Menghua said to comfort her.

"I don't care." Su Xiaoqiang was as haughty as ever. "If they don't take me, I'll go to Stanford. My dad has connections!"

The door opened, and Ye Sheng made a courteous gesture. Liu Miaomiao came out, turning back to thank him. She was clearly trying not to look disappointed, but the disappointment was written honestly across her face.

The pretty pianist hadn't even lasted ten minutes! Her eyes a little red, Liu Miaomiao returned to her chair, took her bag, and headed straight out.

"Su Xiaoqiang," Ye Sheng said.

The Little Celestial Princess sprang up, too, her lovely eyes wide, her teeth chattering.

Watching her follow Ye Sheng inside on stiff legs, Lu Mingfei let out a "Ha!"

"Don't laugh at her. Aren't you scared?" Chen Wenwen gave his shoulder a push.

"I'm not scared. What have I got to be scared of? I'm just here for the ride." He laced his hands behind his head and sprawled across the chair.

When the Little Celestial Princess came out, her steps were stiffer than when she had gone in. Her expression was more angry than disappointed or dejected. Ye Sheng smiled politely behind her. She turned and shot him a furious look. Then he called Zhao Menghua inside.

"What kind of college is this? They're making fools of us!" Su Xiaoqiang turned and left.

Lu Mingfei and Chen Wenwen exchanged a baffled look. The Little Celestial Princess had done worse than Liu Miaomiao. She had lasted perhaps five minutes.

Inside, the interviewer seemed less interested in conducting interviews than in practicing swordplay, cutting people down faster and faster. Zhao Menghua, reputed to have the best spoken English in the senior class, didn't last even three minutes. When he was escorted out, his eyes were blank.

"Chen Wenwen," Ye Sheng said.

"Good luck!" Lu Mingfei called softly after her.

She glanced back at him and nodded gently.

Seconds and minutes passed. Everyone outside remained silent. Lu Mingfei could hear his own heart pounding. He was a little afraid—afraid that Chen Wenwen would emerge with that same disappointed face.

She lasted fifteen minutes. When she came out, her face showed nothing. She kept her head down, looking at the tips of her shoes.

"How was it? How was it?" Lu Mingfei hurried over.

Chen Wenwen hesitated, then secretly beckoned him closer. "They'll ask…"

Delighted, Lu Mingfei was just about to lean in when Ye Sheng said, "Lu Mingfei."

He froze and turned. Ye Sheng was beckoning. "Lu Mingfei, you're next."

Strange. He had never met Ye Sheng. Had the man recognized him instantly from the tiny photograph on his University of Chicago application? Lu Mingfei was curious.

He followed Ye Sheng into the conference room. It was almost empty. At a vast table that could seat dozens sat just one girl, smiling sweetly. She wore the same uniform as Ye Sheng, only in a skirt suit, with a rose-red lace scarf tucked into her collar.

"My name is Aki Sakatoku. I'm also one of your interviewers." The girl stood and bowed to Lu Mingfei in the unmistakably Japanese manner.

"Oh-high-yo." Without thinking, Lu Mingfei bowed back.

After so many years shut away at home, playing countless PS2 games and watching endless anime, he did know a couple of lines of Japanese dialogue.

"Ohayō." Aki Sakatoku covered her mouth and laughed softly, correcting the Henan accent he had somehow given his Japanese. Her smile had an older sister's warmth.

Looks like I've made a good first impression, Lu Mingfei thought happily.

Ye Sheng sat beside Aki Sakatoku, opened his notebook, and looked at him. "Then let's begin."

Lu Mingfei nodded and took a deep breath, settling it deep in his belly. He had trained all night. Now came the test!

"Do you believe in aliens?" Aki Sakatoku asked gently.

He froze for an instant. Then he felt… a nuclear bomb go off inside his head… mushroom clouds everywhere, and nothing else at all.

What was happening? Surely the first question was supposed to be "Please introduce yourself" or "Why did you apply to our school?"

The answer to the first one was, "My name is Mingfei Lu, a Chinese high school student, I like online computer game and panda…"

The answer to the second was, "The great faculty is the key reason, and your college have very good research atmosphere…"

Old Tang had enthusiastically polished those answers. Lu Mingfei had then recited them seventy or eighty times before finally getting them down.

But this… What was this about aliens?

All that preparation… Completely useless!

Lu Mingfei's eyes went as round as brass bells, and his head slowly drooped. This was the kind of loser he was. His luck was always spectacularly rotten. He was the guy who penciled a desk full of formulas before an exam, only for the teacher to make everyone swap seats; who finally managed a peek at the answer sheet next to him, only to discover that his neighbor had Test A and he had Test B… As a born loser, he should have had the courage to believe in his fate instead of putting up a pointless struggle.

"Sure. I believe in aliens," he said. Suddenly, he felt Zhao Menghua was a hero for having lasted three minutes.

"Really?" Aki Sakatoku's expression was mild, offering no sign of approval or disapproval. "Why do you believe in them?"

Hell, why did he believe? Believing was just believing. Nobody in the world could prove they had seen an alien, and yet some people believed and others didn't. It was like asking why you liked the girl at the next desk in the white cotton dress. You could come up with thousands of reasons, but the real

one was simply that you didn't know what was happening: whenever you saw her, your heart raced; you cared terribly about what she said and remembered everything to do with her. And so you knew you liked her. Why? There was no reason, Lu Mingfei thought.

"I wander around on the roof at night a lot. Look at the stars when I've got nothing to do," he said.

"Yes. Good. Looks at the stars in his spare time." Aki Sakatoku took very earnest notes.

Lu Mingfei couldn't understand her seriousness. You would have thought he was China's foreign minister, solemnly delivering a mass of diplomatic language that needed to be carefully recorded.

"If you look at the stars, you start thinking. If there aren't any aliens, the universe is so huge, tens of billions of light-years across, and a beam of light has to travel tens of billions of years to get from one end to the other, passing through so many galaxies. But the only time it meets people is here on Earth. It takes less than a second for light to pass Earth, so in tens of billions of years, there's only one second when it encounters anyone. That would be the strange thing, wouldn't it?" he said.

"Loneliness? Were you implying that the light is lonely?" Ye Sheng interjected.

Lu Mingfei scratched his head. He hadn't actually been implying anything, but his answer seemed to have acquired a little depth. So he nodded, tacitly allowing Ye Sheng to see him as a lonely kid.

"Second question. Do you believe in superpowers?" Aki Sakatoku asked.

"Sure," Lu Mingfei said. "Absolutely."

Once he stopped caring, the questions weren't difficult at all. If superpowers didn't exist, then Jotaro Kujo's Star Platinum wouldn't exist, nor Luffy's Gum-Gum Fruit, and Hiei's Dragon of the Darkness Flame would naturally be fake, too. Then the main things left in the world would be the Montblanc watches his uncle never stopped mentioning and the soaring housing prices his aunt complained about more every day. His own future would be getting up every morning to catch a bus to work, paying the mortgage with his salary at the end of each month, and tiptoeing around his mother-in-law's home on weekends, trying to please her… assuming any girl would marry him.

So in Lu Mingfei's world, superpowers simply had to exist.

"And why do you believe in them?" Aki Sakatoku watched him with an encouraging smile.

"I believe… because I believe. Same as aliens," he said.

He really couldn't give her the actual reason. He could hardly say, "I love Jotaro Kujo's Star Platinum, and I want it to be real."

"A badass life needs no explanation," Ye Sheng said.

Lu Mingfei stared. Why had the interviewer suddenly come out with an internet catchphrase?

He's probably making fun of me, he thought.

"Third question. Do you think the foundation of human existence is idealist—mind and soul—or materialist—matter and the physical body?" Aki Sakatoku asked.

Lu Mingfei's mind went blank on the spot.

Had these college interviewers fried their brains? Why was question three so different from the first two? This was high school politics class, wasn't it? Analyzing materialism and idealism. But he had forgotten every bit of that after passing the graduation exam!

His face reddened, and he gulped air. Who knew how many people this question had taken down? But he had to get through it!

He let out a long breath, rolled his eyes, and stuck out his tongue.

"Er… what does sticking out your tongue mean?" Ye Sheng gave Aki Sakatoku a hesitant look.

"I don't know." Lu Mingfei sighed. "The question's too deep. I really can't answer it. Can I… give up?"

Ye Sheng and Aki Sakatoku were silent for a moment, then nodded. "Of course. Thank you for your interest in Cassell College."

Ye Sheng stood. "I'll show you out."

Lu Mingfei had lasted one minute and thirty seconds, setting a new record for the quickest execution.

Chen Wenwen was waiting outside with her bag. Seeing him emerge, she hurried over. "Why are you out so soon?"

"The politics question got me…" His head drooped. "I'm not as good as you guys. How many did you answer?"

"The politics question got me, too. My answer was a mess. They said I hadn't passed." Chen Wenwen lowered her head.

"But you were in there fifteen minutes!" he said, startled.

"I talked about flying saucers for fifteen minutes…" she whispered.

"Huh?" He stared at her.

Then, in an instant, joy welled up inside him. He reached out and patted her head. "It's fine, it's fine! With questions from a bunch of lunatics like that, anyone who passed would have to be a lunatic, too!"

She raised her head, a hint of a smile appearing on her downcast face. Lu Mingfei's heart bloomed. It felt like the greatest reward the day could have given him.

What did it matter if he couldn't go abroad? Chen Wenwen wasn't going either!

Late at night, Ye Sheng sat at the conference table, going through the applications once more.

He looked up at Aki Sakatoku beside him. "Where's that little girl? Haven't seen her all day. She didn't even show up for the interviews. She's supposed to be an interviewer, too."

"Off having fun somewhere. That's why she came along in the first place, isn't it?" Aki Sakatoku shrugged. "What can you do? She's still just a little girl."

"How did the interviews go?" The door opened, and someone hurried in carrying a briefcase. "I booked a red-eye and came straight here after landing."

It was an elderly man, travel-worn, with thick glasses perched on his nose. His gray hair was a fluffy mess, not because he had permed it, but because he hadn't combed it in who knew how long. His suit was shabby, his trousers baggy.

"Professor Guderian." Ye Sheng stood. "We interviewed seventeen students in all…"

"Don't waste time! I'm asking about Lu Mingfei! I only care about Lu Mingfei!" Professor Guderian looked as anxious as a parent rather than an interviewer. "Tell me—how did he answer?" The old fellow of German descent spoke remarkably fluent Chinese.

Ye Sheng and Aki Sakatoku exchanged a glance. He turned to the page of notes on Lu Mingfei, hesitated, then shook his head.

"He left after just a minute and a half," Ye Sheng said.

"The best students always hand in their papers first!" Professor Guderian was delighted.

"Well… for question one, he said he believed in aliens because without them, humanity would be rather lonely in the universe…" Ye Sheng smiled helplessly.

"What a wonderful answer! I'm genuinely moved!" Professor Guderian clicked his tongue in admiration. "That's Lu Mingfei for you!"

"It… it's that good?" Ye Sheng stared. "For question two, he believed in superpowers as well, but couldn't give a reason…"

"Perfect!" Professor Guderian declared.

"That's… a perfect answer? That's the answer… the college had in mind?" Ye Sheng and Aki Sakatoku looked at one another.

"Let me explain!" Professor Guderian said. "In question one, not only did he say he believed in aliens, he introduced the crucial concept of loneliness. Loneliness is what binds our people together! That one word goes straight to the heart of the question. Aliens are a metaphor for the difference between our kind and ordinary people. For question two, belief requires absolutely no reason. What we mean by belief is an innate sense of trust that comes from within. If he had invented reasons for his trust, he would have lost points. How did he answer question three?"

"I don't know…" Aki Sakatoku touched her forehead. "I mean, he said he didn't know…"

Professor Guderian raised his head and drew a deep breath. "If I didn't know how extraordinary his bloodline was, I'd think he'd peeked at the answers."

"Don't tell me the answer is… 'I don't know'?" Ye Sheng scratched his head.

"The answer is 'I don't know'! His bloodline determines his worldview. A person straddling two races also stands somewhere between idealism and materialism in his understanding of the world. That demonstrates his potential," Professor Guderian said loudly. "Any student with real potential is bound to feel precisely that uncertainty about the world!"

"Professor Guderian, aren't you simply… playing favorites?" Aki Sakatoku asked with a wry smile.

Professor Guderian paused, then spread his hands. "Well… a little… But I really do think he answered rather well…"

"I understand that the college makes allowances for students with exceptional bloodlines. But favoritism this blatant… isn't it a bit much?" Ye Sheng shook his head. "If that's how it is, why interview anyone at all?"

"You don't understand. We haven't had an S-rank candidate like this in decades. If we turn in an interview report that says he failed… the principal won't let us off either!"

Ye Sheng and Aki Sakatoku exchanged a look. "He really is… S-rank?"

"Yes. It's been checked again and again. Of all the candidates, he's rated S. The only S! These interviews were, in fact, arranged for him alone!" Professor Guderian nodded and lowered his voice. "This is classified at the college's highest level. That's why you weren't told before setting out."

Silence.

"Ah!" Aki suddenly cried.

Professor Guderian clutched his chest. "Why are you shrieking all of a sudden?"

"I just remembered something awful. Your favorite S-rank student… He seemed extremely disappointed with his answers. So after saying 'I don't know,' he said he was giving up and walked straight out." Aki and Ye Sheng looked at each other.

"But he answered so well! Why would he give up?" Professor Guderian looked ready to leap into the air.

"With those questions and those answers…" Ye Sheng shrugged with a wry smile. "You might be the only person who thinks he did well."

"We must fix this! We have to get him back! I'll call his family!" Professor Guderian patted himself all over, searching for his phone.

Ye Sheng scratched his head and sighed. "Let me call… You'll frighten his family like this. They'll think you're up to something."

Three in the morning. In the dead silence, a telephone rang down the hallway of Lu Mingfei's home.

His aunt jolted upright from sleep and turned toward the phone on the nightstand, which was ringing so merrily it almost seemed to be jumping up and down.

"Did someone in your family die? Calling in the middle of the night!" She snatched it up and shouted furiously.

Soon, the anger left her face. She couldn't say a word. Her husband sat up in bed and saw his wife, hair disheveled, eyes vacant, as though she had been struck by lightning.

The ringing next door woke Lu Mingze, too. He turned toward the other bed and saw his older cousin licking his lips in his sleep, making happy little piglike grunts.

The following morning. The Regent Hotel.

The whole family had turned out for the VIP dining lounge on the ninth-floor executive level. His uncle, in an immaculate suit, stuck out his belly and lectured the boys about behaving properly in a high-class place and not constantly touching the cutlery. His aunt looked around, clicking her tongue in admiration. A high-class hotel really was high-class.

"Mr. Lu Mingfei? Green tea or dark tea?" A neatly dressed waiter approached and addressed Lu Mingfei, sandwiched between his uncle and aunt.

"What are the prices?" His uncle displayed the air of a man accustomed to fine establishments.

"Everything is complimentary for guests in the presidential suite. That is the suite Professor Guderian has booked."

"American schools really are rich!" His aunt acquired an instant respect for Cassell College.

With a ding, the express elevator opened. A burly, gray-haired old man strode toward their table by the window, Ye Sheng on his left and Aki Sakatoku on his right. Flanked by the handsome young man and lovely young woman like a hunter with hound and hawk, he cut a commanding figure. Without a word of preamble, he seized Lu Mingfei's hand. "Hello, Lu Mingfei!"

"Hello… Professor… Guderian?" Lu Mingfei was embarrassed by this overwhelming enthusiasm. "Your Chinese is really good."

Professor Guderian's eyes lit up. He scratched his head happily. "Is it that good? I learned from CCTV's evening news. We promote Chinese throughout the college. Everyone knows China is going to become the most prosperous place in the world!" He looked at Lu Mingfei, eyes shining, openly trying to win him over. "Join us. You won't need English. Every student speaks Chinese."

Lu Mingfei blinked. What did that mean? Chinese? No need for English? In a life with so few bright spots, that TOEFL score was about the only thing he had to show. If even his one bright spot didn't matter, what did Cassell College see in him? Professor Guderian, whom he had just met, looked positively overjoyed.

"Hello, Professor Gu. I'm Lu Mingfei's uncle." Unable to bear being left out, his uncle squeezed between them.

Unable to remember the whole name Guderian, he had very cleverly shortened it to Professor Gu.

"You two really don't look alike!" Professor Guderian shook his hand.

Now it was his uncle's turn to be embarrassed. For all his grandeur and his presidential suite, this Professor Guderian seemed a little out of touch.

Behind him, Ye Sheng tugged his sleeve. The three of them sat across the table.

"Let's have breakfast." Professor Guderian took his fork in his left hand and knife in his right, never taking his eyes off Lu Mingfei.

Lu Mingfei felt he was being watched with the anticipation of a gourmet regarding a roast chicken.

The expensive breakfast included salmon rolls and freshly squeezed lemon juice, and the solid-silver cutlery was decidedly impressive. It immediately banished his uncle's displeasure. After all, there was nothing shameful about Lu Mingfei not looking like him. Hosts and guests alike were happy.

Professor Guderian praised Lu Mingfei's outstanding interview performance. His uncle was delighted to say that you could tell at a glance Cassell College was an American school for the elite. Chinese universities simply couldn't compare with such style.

Ye Sheng had prepared thoroughly. He produced a copy of the college's official registration with the U.S. Department of Education for his aunt to inspect, followed by a photo album. This was the library; this was the sports center; this was the concert hall. The campus in the pictures was elegant and old-fashioned, like a completely renovated castle.

One photo showed Ye Sheng himself on a windsurfing board, a sea of sails competing behind him. It was the annual college windsurfing race, he explained. Cassell had beaten the University of Chicago three years running.

His aunt was won over, too. She exclaimed that their Mingfei must have earned extraordinary blessings in a previous life to attend such a school.

Lu Mingfei had a strange feeling. It was like marrying off a daughter. He was the daughter who cost money at home but would bring in a bride-price if married out. The groom's family was eager, and the bride's family was more than happy to oblige.

He worked up his courage. "Professor Guderian… what does your college see in me?"

"Your overall qualities! Your enormous potential!" The professor didn't look remotely as though he were joking. "We think so highly of you that we want not only to admit you, but to give you a scholarship. I've decided to allocate thirty-six thousand U.S. dollars a year from the scholarship fund under my name. Enough to see you through all four years!"

His uncle and aunt gasped together.

"Professor Gu… there aren't… any conditions attached, are there? Like having to pay it back afterward… We should be clear about that first." His uncle sensed something wrong.

"No! Absolutely not! A scholarship is a reward for your nephew, because he is outstanding!" Professor Guderian declared with righteous conviction.

"That sounds fake." His uncle shook his head.

"Of course, there are other reasons. Lu Mingfei's parents happen to be honorary alumni, and they have made donations to the college. All other things being equal, we give preference to alumni's children."

Lu Mingfei looked up at once. It felt as though a small rabbit were jumping in his chest. He had forgotten how long it had been since he had heard any real news of his parents. His mother's letters only told him to take care of himself and study hard, the same thing every time. Sometimes he felt those letters were just a way of brushing him off, and his parents no longer cared about him at all.

"They care about you very much," Professor Guderian said. "I haven't met them myself, but I hear they've been working on a very important research project, traveling all over the world these past years. I have a photograph of them here. Oh, and a letter your mother wrote to the college about you."

He took a photograph from his pocket and placed it before Lu Mingfei. It showed a summer garden. In the distance was what looked like Cassell College in the sunset. Closer were walls of climbing greenery, a deep, luminous green. A man and a woman walked hand in hand among them. The man wore a loose white shirt, wide-legged trousers, and wooden sandals. The woman wore a plain white cotton house dress.

Lu Mingfei reached out and gently touched the two faces. That handsome man and beautiful woman were his parents, but they were so far away, in some corner of the world he could never reach. His nose began to sting. In the photograph, they were looking into each other's faces, smiling warmly. Clearly, it was their own little world for two. They had probably forgotten that, between them, they had once made a child.

His aunt offered a concise assessment. "Two people their age, still so romantic!"

Professor Guderian passed him a letter next. It was short and printed out, probably an email:

Dear Principal Anjou:

It has been a long time since we were in touch. I hope you are as well as ever.

We probably will not be able to meet for quite some time. There have been new developments in our research, and we cannot leave.

There is something I would like to ask of you. My son Lu Mingfei is now eighteen. He is a clever child. His grades may not be especially good, but we both believe he can accomplish something in scholarship. If possible, please help him gain admission to Cassell College.

Since I cannot tell him in person, please pass on a message for me: his mother and father love him.

Yours sincerely,

Qiao Weini

Lu Mingfei read in silence. For a long time, he said nothing.

Professor Guderian cleared his throat. Then, looking straight into Lu Mingfei's eyes, he said with immense tenderness and slightly imperfect pronunciation, "Mingfei, Mommy and Daddy love you."

Lu Mingfei stared, completely stunned.

"The principal insisted that I pass on your parents' message. He cares about you very much, too," Professor Guderian said.

The clumsy delivery was too much for Lu Mingze, who burst out laughing. His parents couldn't keep straight faces either. In the letter, Qiao Weini's words were so tender they could have brought tears to your eyes. Spoken by a gray-haired, gray-bearded Professor Guderian with his clueless expression, they acquired an irresistibly comic incongruity. Ye Sheng and Aki Sakatoku shook their heads with helpless smiles. The professor reached out and gave Lu Mingfei a hearty pat on the shoulder.

The atmosphere at the table suddenly grew much warmer.

"I'm going to the restroom." Lu Mingfei stood.

He leaned his back against the restroom door and stood quietly for a while. Tears began to run silently down his face.

They had all laughed, but he couldn't see anything funny about it.

It should have been moving. Through all those years, all the way to eighteen, hardly anyone had cared what he thought or what he did. Time after time, he had walked home from school and watched his classmates get picked up, one by one. Looking back at the dust those cars left behind, he had sometimes thought that perhaps no one in this world loved him at all.

"Mingfei, Mommy and Daddy love you."

Lu Mingfei believed it. On paper, the words hadn't really made him feel anything. But when Professor Guderian said them aloud, suddenly he believed.

"I love you." Words like that had to be spoken. Saying them was different from writing them on paper. Especially to a drooping little kid starved of love.

He knew he was being rather stupid, but he couldn't help the sadness. He could only hide in the restroom. He slid down against the door and squatted, tears streaming, drawing circles on the tiles. He would wait until the tears stopped, then go out and say he had needed to take a dump.

Just then, a pair of running shoes with a muted purple pattern appeared before him.

He looked up in surprise. A girl stood there. From the bottom up: running shoes, close-fitting jeans, a little white tank top beneath a cropped blue-striped shirt, and a baseball cap perched on her head.

Something seemed wrong. He couldn't work out what. He blinked.

The tall, radiant girl looked down at him sidelong. Sterling-silver four-leaf-clover earrings swayed at her ears, their tiny diamonds flashing painfully bright.

"This is the ladies' room," she informed him at her leisure.

Lu Mingfei returned to the table with his head hanging. The pretty, tall girl followed, her face cold.

"Oh? Nono, I thought you'd gone out to have fun." Professor Guderian stood. "Let me introduce Chen Motong, a second-year student of Chinese descent and our student interviewer for this visit. This is your new schoolmate, Lu Mingfei."

"Nono?" Lu Mingfei paused. The name sounded familiar.

"I ate at a street-food stall last night, and my stomach's been a little upset. I've been in the restroom." Chen Motong sat beside Aki Sakatoku.

"Why didn't you invite me? I'd love to try one of those things called street-food stalls." Professor Guderian sounded disappointed. "I've heard about them on the news."

"In a report about recycled gutter oil, was it?" Chen Motong picked up her knife and fork and stole the last salmon roll from Ye Sheng's plate.

"I have one left, too. You can have it." Aki Sakatoku forked hers onto Chen Motong's plate as well.

"You work together so well. Just like a married couple. Why haven't you gotten married yet?" Chen Motong mumbled around a mouthful of salmon roll.

Ye Sheng and Aki Sakatoku looked at each other, both a little helpless and a little embarrassed.

Lu Mingfei was grateful that the girl hadn't exposed his humiliation. But as soon as she joined them, the warm family atmosphere evaporated. Sitting closest to the window, Chen Motong looked at no one and buttered her bread by herself. In the sunlight, her long hair glowed a deep red, like wine.

He had never met a girl like her. She wasn't like Su Xiaoqiang, who cared so much about how others saw her. Nor was she like the delicate, quiet Chen Wenwen, who avoided people's eyes. Chen Motong looked like a proud princess who didn't care about anything. Even when she looked straight at you, you felt that she wasn't really seeing you at all.

His uncle was stealing looks at her wrist. Lu Mingfei knew what he was looking at: the silver, diamond-set Omega watch.

"Mind if I eat yours, too?" Chen Motong wiped her mouth with a napkin and fixed her eyes on Lu Mingfei.

He could only nod. What a rare honor: such a proud princess actually looking into his eyes and speaking to him… for the sake of a salmon roll.

"Nono, some manners. Look after our new student," Professor Guderian said.

"He has no appetite." She glanced at Lu Mingfei. "Look how distracted he is. He could probably even walk into the wrong restroom."

His heart gave a jolt. Chen Motong stuck out her tongue and took his entire breakfast plate.

"Oh? Really? Mingfei, is there anything you're still worried about?" Professor Guderian looked into his eyes. "An opportunity to attend Cassell College is extremely rare. You must treasure it!"

"I… I still need to think." He lowered his head.

His uncle, aunt, and Lu Mingze were dumbfounded. Had something short-circuited in his brain? A free meal had fallen from the sky. What was there to think about? Other people couldn't get such an opportunity however hard they begged. He should just open his mouth and catch it.

Professor Guderian grew anxious. "If there are any conditions we can meet, just name them!"

"No." Lu Mingfei shook his head. "I…"

"It's his first love." Chen Motong twirled her fork, Lu Mingfei's salmon roll speared on it. "Let me think. White… long hair… very gentle… quiet… a hundred sixty-five centimeters tall… a girl in his class. Yes, more or less. Someone like that."

She turned to the window and chewed as though no one else existed.

Lu Mingfei shuddered. Lu Mingze's ears pricked up. His uncle and aunt gave him suspicious looks. The table fell silent. The only sound, extraordinarily clear, was Chen Motong chewing his salmon roll.

"Nono, stop it," Aki Sakatoku said.

"Just kidding." Chen Motong pushed away the empty plate, showed her bright white teeth, and gave Lu Mingfei a beautiful, unfriendly smile. "We hardly know each other. We only met today, didn't we? Even if he had a first love, how would I know who she was?"

Everyone exhaled together. Professor Guderian looked immensely relieved.

"Our Mingfei wouldn't get involved with girls. Would you, Mingfei?" His aunt was reassured. He hadn't secretly found a girlfriend behind her back, which meant her authority in the household remained intact. Besides, she rather doubted anyone could be blind enough to fall for him. The girls at his school were all well-brought-up young ladies. What chance did he have?

"Who'd want me?" Lu Mingfei chewed and chewed a stalk of asparagus. As long as his mouth kept moving, he didn't have to fake an expression.

"A student's priority should be studying," his uncle said.

"You're teching to tier three," Chen Motong suddenly said.

His heart trembled. The asparagus fell onto his plate.

Late at night, in the quiet, Lu Mingfei sat at his laptop with two things open: QQ and StarCraft.

His uncle and aunt had spent the day scolding him for not knowing a good thing when he saw one. No matter how Professor Guderian pleaded or persuaded, he had insisted he needed to think.

"What's there to think about? Still hoping for Harvard, are you?" His aunt had finally snorted in contempt.

Chen Motong had been right. It was because of Chen Wenwen.

He had read a StarCraft story called "The Bloodstained Totem," about a giant robot fighting on another planet that secretly used the military network to chat on QQ with a little girl on Earth. Under low, lead-gray clouds, the robot, named Godzilla, fought Zerg through hails of bullets while exchanging warm little messages with the girl.

One day, Godzilla told her on QQ, I'm going to die. All my battery fluid's leaked out. I'm running out of power.

The girl said, You're funny. You really think you're a giant robot? If you don't feel like talking, just say so. See you tomorrow.

Godzilla said, Talking with you feels so nice.

Then it was forced offline. On a distant planet, an angry Zergling leaped onto the wreck of a giant robot and tore through its circuits with sharp claws.

Lu Mingfei felt he was that giant robot, and Chen Wenwen was the little girl. Sometimes she told him very private things, and he was happy, replying with all sorts of cute emojis to show he was listening carefully. But she never understood why he did it, and didn't know that he waited for her on QQ, hour after hour. If one day the circuits inside the giant robot called Lu Mingfei failed, would Chen Wenwen feel sad?

The more he thought about it, the sadder he became. It was a tragic feeling: battery fluid leaking through his chest, circuits crackling all over his body.

The literary club's group chat was silent. Without Chen Wenwen, no one would ever discuss literature. The beauty of literature was mainly a matter of the beauty of the muse. The muse sat in the sunlight in a white cotton dress, her long hair loose. That was the beauty of literature.

In the StarCraft channel, Old Tang was imparting secret techniques to a crowd. Ever since defeating Lu Mingfei, he had styled himself the channel's top player.

The big-faced cat avatar flashed. Nono was online.

Lu Mingfei hesitated. "It was you?"

"Yeah. Chen Motong." Her reply felt lazy. "Nothing to do, so I came on for a couple of games."

"How did you know my ID?"

"Crowdsourced stalking. Heh. You actually use an ID like 'Mingming.' Sounds like a girl. And 'Sunset's Imprint'… Are you pretending to be a girl online?"

"You could even dig that up? Keep it secret, please. That's just me messing with my cousin."

"Kidding. Norma found it. A piece of cake for her. You're pretty good at StarCraft."

"Come on. I lost to you."

"I lost. Norma was playing with me. We both controlled the same side. At the end, I knew you were teching to tier three because she secretly revealed the map and saw it."

"May every cheater's whole family drop dead!" Lu Mingfei typed.

It was automatic. Everyone tossed that line around in the group. Nobody took it seriously.

"I'm the only one in my family," Nono replied.

Lu Mingfei paused. "Sorry."

"What's there to be sorry about?" Her reply was flat. "Want a game?"

"Not in the mood."

"Girl broke your heart?"

A shiver ran through him. Nono was like a little witch, seeing through everything about him, leaving him nowhere to hide.

"Not yet… I don't have a girlfriend, so obviously my heart isn't broken. What do you want from me, big sis?" he typed.

"'Big sis.' That's sweet." Nono sent a toothy grin. "Come on, tell me what's going on. Maybe I can help."

"How could you help? You don't even know her."

"No, I don't know Chen Wenwen." The little witch replied instantly.

"How much do you actually know?" Lu Mingfei was suddenly terrified.

"Too much."

"Who… are you people?" His hands were shaking a little.

"Suspicious, right? Your parents haven't been home in six years, then suddenly recommend you to an American college. Your grades are average… no, actually, they're terrible, but the college gives

you a huge scholarship. You clearly talked complete nonsense in the interview, but the interviewers say your answers were wonderful. Compared with that, knowing who you have a crush on is nothing."

"Yeah. Only my uncle and aunt don't suspect anything. They think my parents can do anything. All the way home, they kept asking how to get my cousin sent abroad, too."

"Beg me! Beg, and I'll tell you things. Like… what Chen Wenwen's thinking…" The little witch's evil nature was stirring again.

"You know?"

"A woman's intuition tells me…"

"What?"

"She doesn't like you."

"Get lost!"

Lu Mingfei didn't believe it. He remembered that afternoon when only he and Chen Wenwen had been in the classroom. He was wiping the blackboard. She sat on the teaching platform in a white cotton dress, sneakers, and white ankle socks, humming softly. The slanting evening sun shone on the newly replaced desks. Virginia creeper hung down outside the window. In that evening between spring and summer, everything was especially still. Suddenly, Chen Wenwen had turned and asked, Lu Mingfei, would you like to join our literary club?

He had felt petrified, only his heart still hammering. Outside, flowers and grass grew wild, the sun sank, the cicadas seemed to sing a hundred times faster. Time slipped through his fingers, the hours changed, yet the gaze between him and Chen Wenwen seemed eternal.

"Just kidding. Come on, let me advise you. Have you ever given her flowers?" Nono asked.

"Does foxtail grass count?" He perked up and began talking nonsense again.

"Taken her to a movie?"

"When the school screened revolutionary films for educational purposes, I sat next to her at Sparkling Red Star."

"When's her birthday?"

"October tenth."

"Ever given her a birthday present?"

"She borrowed my pen to write back to the boys who sent her birthday cards. Then she didn't return it. The next day she said it could count as my present…"

"Could you be any more hopeless?"

"I don't think so."

"You're a disgrace to Cassell College!" Nono was angry. "Come on. Let your senior teach you a thing or two. First, you have to pursue a girl! If you don't make a move, do you expect her to confess to you? Second, what matters most to a girl is feeling happy and cherished. Have you ever tried making Chen Wenwen feel that way?"

"Happy and cherished?" He stared.

"For example, suppose—and this is only hypothetical—Chen Wenwen really likes you, but you don't feel anything for her. Then one day you fail an exam and feel utterly miserable. Suddenly, there

she is, picking you up in a Ferrari. In front of everyone, she strokes your hair and says, ‘There, there. Don’t worry. You’ll do better next time.’ Wouldn’t you practically explode with happiness? Even if you didn’t like her before, wouldn’t you fall into her arms on the spot?”

“Immediately! No hesitation! I’d put a leash around my own neck and run after her barking!” Lu Mingfei answered with absolute conviction.

“Hopeless! That makes you look way too easy. At least squirm a little and pretend to resist!”

“Senior… what should I do, then?” He was entirely sincere about becoming her pupil.

“Burn your boats! Tell everyone you like her. Say it loud. Gamble your dignity as a man and your future on it. Do you understand girls? No girl will really hate a boy for a confession honest and brave enough. Even if she doesn’t accept, she’ll remember you.”

“What if she doesn’t accept?”

“Fly to America with your beautiful memories of heartbreak.”

“That sounds pretty tragic…”

“Loving someone isn’t easy. You have to fight your way through an army! The last Zergling, racing through the fire of countless Dragoons, down to its final hit point, slashes out with one claw and turns the battle! If you die halfway, that’s natural enough. But a Zergling that won’t charge into the guns isn’t a good Zergling!” Nono said.

Lu Mingfei paused. He felt the killing intent in her words, and that beautiful, indifferent face suddenly appeared before him. That girl like a blade of steel… Now she had swung it, cutting straight into his heart, blood splashing everywhere. In that instant, he made the boldest decision of his eighteen years. He would be the Zergling that charged into the guns. In those final three months before graduation, the last time he and Chen Wenwen would be classmates, he would tell her he had liked her for three years. However feeble that final swipe, whether or not it broke through her defenses, he was determined to be a good Zergling!

“Understood!” he said.

“Bring flowers. If you don’t know what she likes, go with roses. Deep red. No girl really dislikes roses. Have moving music in the background. Most importantly, say it in front of everyone. That shows your courage!” Nono said. “Good luck, little bro!”

“Yes, ma’am!” He imagined a mighty female general issuing orders to him, her foot soldier.

“But… if you succeed, the road to Cassell College will close to you forever!”

With that, Nono logged off, giving him no chance to reply.

Lu Mingfei tipped back his head and let out a long breath. He was eager to try, convinced that this bold confession would succeed. Giving up America for it was nothing. He would never see Nono again, though. That was a slight regret. He felt he would miss her. Before Nono, no girl had ever burst into his world with such ferocity. Not even Chen Wenwen.

He looked at the gray big-faced cat avatar, no longer bouncing, and suddenly felt it was a kind of magic. The moment his confession succeeded, Cassell College, Professor Guderian, and Nono would vanish from this world like bubbles.

In a suite on the Regent Hotel’s executive floor, Nono sipped her coffee at ease.

QQ was still open on her Apple laptop. She had merely set herself to invisible. Lu Mingfei's final message arrived: a simple "Thank you."

In another chat window, someone with the ID "Sonic" said, "What are you doing? Teaching him how to confess to a girl? If our S-rank gives up the gate to Cassell for love, the principal will go insane."

"Are you nuts? I'm just messing with him." Nono wrinkled her delicate nose and smiled coldly. "How could that kind of confession work? Chen Wenwen's a literary girl. If she likes someone, she'll accept him. If she doesn't, she won't care how much he offers. Music, roses, and shouting 'I love you' are supposed to do it? Please!"

"Could you be any more immoral?"

"No." Nono shrugged. "I have to admit, this is the most immoral thing I've ever done."

"Why pick on a freshman?"

"A freshman? He's S-rank! You and I are only A-rank. If we don't bully him while we have the chance, it'll be harder once he gets to college," Nono said.

"Let's hope nothing unexpected happens. Suppose Chen Wenwen's just as secretly passionate as he is. She's liked him for three years but won't say it, and all they're missing is a confession. Then you'll have ruined everything."

Nono stuck out her tongue. "Surely I can't be that unlucky?"

"The Student Council needs someone like him. The only S-rank. We absolutely can't let the Lionheart Society get him!" Sonic said.

"Nono." Ye Sheng opened the door and poked his head in. "Professor Guderian wants you to join the discussion."

"Oh." She slipped on her cotton slippers and trotted out, holding her coffee cup.

In the outer room, Professor Guderian, Ye Sheng, and Aki Sakatoku sat around a coffee table, looking rather grave. A freshly printed document lay on the table.

"Nono, I have an assignment. I can only entrust it to you." Professor Guderian picked up the document. "The college just faxed us the profile of a Russian candidate who appears to have an excellent bloodline. I must fly to Beijing at once and connect to Russia. I'm leaving the rest of Lu Mingfei's enrollment to you."

"Me?" Nono stared. "What about Ye Sheng and Aki?"

"Operation Kuimen has been moved forward. The principal will soon be coming to China in person. Professor Mans has ordered us to report to Sichuan immediately," Ye Sheng said. "Aki and I still need some time for coordination training."

"Is it really that urgent?" Nono pouted. At moments like this, she still looked like a child.

"When it's your turn to carry out an operation, you'll understand. You can't wait an hour, or even a minute." Ye Sheng patted her shoulder. "Miss certain moments once, and you might as well have missed an entire lifetime."

"You should say that with your hand on Aki's shoulder. Then add, 'So I'm asking you to marry me,'" Nono said, unable to resist.

Aki blushed.

"All right. What do I do about Lu Mingfei?" Nono looked at Professor Guderian.

He scratched his head. "If you want to know what I really think… bring him to America even if you have to kidnap him!"

Lu Mingfei thought Nono was an angel who brought good luck. Not long after she logged off, Chen Wenwen suddenly spoke in the group. All the invisible members promptly appeared and clustered around their muse, each brimming with literary eloquence, nothing like people suffering through the nightmare of college entrance exams.

"Shall the literary club have a graduation party before we graduate?" Chen Wenwen suggested.

Everyone cheered, Lu Mingfei among them. Hardly anyone in the club would oppose her suggestions. Zhao Menghua joked that she was the club's Liu Bei, with an irresistible power to attract men.

"A dinner? Boring. I'm on a diet," Su Xiaoqiang said coldly.

No one had expected her to condescend to join the literary club. The presidents of both the tennis and pool clubs admired her and had eagerly invited her, but she hadn't given either a second look. Instead, she had joined the club run by her sworn rival, looking less like a recruit than someone who had come to wreck the place. Her target, though, was Zhao Menghua, not Chen Wenwen. The Little Celestial Princess made no secret of it and announced it far and wide. Once, treating the girls to Pizza Hut, she had suddenly stood up, raised a glass of beer, and declared, "I invited you all to dinner to tell you I like Zhao Menghua. If you want to fight me for him, come on. I don't care how many of you there are!"

Majestic!

"Not dinner. Let's rent a small cinema auditorium and watch a movie," Chen Wenwen said.

Lu Mingfei's heart stirred. Nono's words echoed in his ears. A small cinema auditorium? Heaven was being far too generous. It sounded like a venue prepared especially for his confession!

"What should we watch?" someone asked.

"WALL-E," Chen Wenwen said.

"WALL-E? Sure! Let's sneak snacks in," Zhao Menghua said, using its English title. An English fanatic like him never watched dubbed Chinese versions and referred to blockbusters only by their English names.

"I'll cover popcorn and Coke. Nothing else!" the Little Celestial Princess announced grandly.

"Then we're a perfect match. I'll cover eating the popcorn and drinking the Coke," Lu Mingfei couldn't help quipping.

"Please! Who's a perfect match with you?" The Little Celestial Princess expressed boundless contempt.

Everyone chimed in, excited. Renting a theater with the club before graduation and watching an animated love story sounded like a wonderful memory.

A love story! Love was the crucial part! Lu Mingfei felt flowers blooming in his heart.

As if it were some mysterious sign, Chen Wenwen had chosen WALL-E. The story of a grubby little trash-collecting robot who fell in love with EVE, a snow-white robot girl like a princess. Lu Mingfei had watched it over and over. He was too embarrassed to admit that the final sequence had

moved him to tears: WALL-E crushed into scrap by the evil captain robot, EVE racing to find parts to save him, breaking the sound barrier with him in her arms.

That must be love. Even a little garbage-collecting robot could have his springtime! Lu Mingfei found it overwhelmingly moving.

"Lu Mingfei, come buy the tickets with me. Everyone, give your money to him," Chen Wenwen said.

The group agreed. As an officer of the literary club, Lu Mingfei's main duties were collecting money from everyone and running errands. Giving him this job was standard practice.

But this time, Chen Wenwen had said she would go with him.

Walk the same road with some people, and it feels absurdly long. Walk it with others, and it is so short you can hardly bear to take another step.

Lu Mingfei and Chen Wenwen ambled along the cobbled riverside path, dawdling and swaying with every step. He walked it after school every day, but suddenly found it offensively short. Why hadn't the city government spent a little more and made this pedestrian street fifty kilometers long?

"Lu Mingfei, which university do you want to apply to?" she asked.

They had just reserved the auditorium. Afterward, he had gone with her to buy a paper bag of bellflowers. While there, he had checked the price of roses. With no holiday approaching, they didn't seem very expensive. He could scrape together enough for ninety-nine. Now she was walking home beside him, holding her bag of bellflowers. For the first time, he learned that she actually lived not far from his own home. She was wearing the white cotton dress from their first day of school. It smelled nice.

"Anywhere, as long as I can get in," he said. He was too embarrassed to mention that Cassell College had said he passed the interview.

"Will you apply locally?"

His heart gave a leap. She's quietly asking where I'm going! There's a chance!

"Anywhere's fine. A school with lots of classmates would be best."

She smiled without a sound and gave a soft "Mm."

They walked in silence with their heads lowered. He counted his steps, happy, feeling that some subtle understanding existed between them.

"Hey. Why do you look so bashful?" someone asked ominously from ahead.

Startled, he looked up. The girl before him lowered her enormous sunglasses, rolled her eyes at him, held her hands beside her ears like a giant deer's antlers, and called loudly, "Hi! Hi!"

Lu Mingfei knew exactly why Nono was putting on this warmth of old friends reunited. It was entirely for Chen Wenwen's benefit. He had experienced this little witch's methods before.

"A friend of yours?" Chen Wenwen was a little embarrassed, feeling overshadowed by Nono's princess-like air.

"Uh-huh." Lu Mingfei mumbled.

"Hi, hi! What a coincidence!" Nono bounced in front of Chen Wenwen. "You must be Chen Wenwen?"

"How do you know my name?" she asked, surprised.

"He told me. He said…" Nono stopped abruptly and looked at Lu Mingfei with wide eyes. "Oh, right. Don't you still owe me ice cream?"

Blackmail. Naked blackmail!

But as long as Nono didn't start spouting nonsense right now, he would do anything.

He quickly took out his money. "What flavor?"

"Vanilla with strawberry sauce." Nono removed her baseball cap and ran her hand through her long, dark-red hair.

He could only pay up. The three strolled along the river eating ice cream. Locust blossoms fell onto Chen Wenwen's white dress and Nono's baseball cap. Nono bounced along as though she had springs under her feet, while Chen Wenwen spoke to her softly. Lu Mingfei followed behind with his head down. Nono's arrival had stolen his chance to talk. There was nothing left for him to do.

"Does Lu Mingfei say a lot of bad things about me?" Chen Wenwen asked.

"No. He says he loves literature, so he joined the literary club."

"Oh. Were you classmates in middle school?"

"Elementary school. I've been studying in America since then. Only just came back." Nono turned to Lu Mingfei. "Remember all that Virginia creeper on our classroom building? I went back the other day. It's reached the roof!"

He nodded vigorously. The ice cream was worth it. Nono was an honest businesswoman, making it all sound wonderfully real.

"Did your family immigrate?" Chen Wenwen asked.

"No. I have a Chinese passport. I only went there to study. I'm a college sophomore."

"Did you skip grades? Lu Mingfei's only a high school senior."

"Oh, we weren't in the same class. I was his senior." Nono patched the lie instantly, apparently without blinking. "Isn't that right, Lu Mingfei?"

"Yes! My senior!" he said solemnly.

Nono's smile bloomed.

They parted at a fork in the road. Lu Mingfei and Chen Wenwen continued ahead; Nono took the other branch. Watching her bounce away, he felt that the girl was somehow unreal. She always gave him the sense that she might disappear at any moment.

Lu Mingze had been unhappy these past few days. Sunset's Imprint was hardly ever online, leaving him frantic. He monopolized the laptop even more fiercely, giving Lu Mingfei no chance at it. Lu Mingfei knew his cousin resented his extraordinary luck and wanted someone to confide in. He would have loved to hear those confidences… He simply hadn't had time to slip out to an internet café.

His aunt nagged Lu Mingze about spending too much time online and needing to study if he wanted to get anywhere, while, as usual, ordering Lu Mingfei to buy milk for tomorrow's breakfast. He stepped out and heard Lu Mingze suddenly grow agitated inside, for some reason, and start arguing loudly with her.

He didn't go downstairs. He climbed to the top floor instead. Above it was the roof, crowded with whining air-conditioning units. The stairs up had the atmosphere of a horror film. Cardboard boxes, two broken motors, a discarded sofa, and a wooden coffee table sat under layers of dust, with barely enough space to put a foot between them. At the top, building management had installed an iron gate marked ROOF CLOSED. Lu Mingfei hopped expertly over the junk like a nimble kangaroo. Just beyond the gate lay a few feet of shadow, and then an infinity of stars.

He squeezed through the gap in the gate, stood beneath the starlight, took a deep breath, and looked out over the city under the night sky.

This was his secret territory. Here, he was free to enjoy the wind, the light of the sky, and the changing scents of the city as spring gave way to autumn: sometimes locust blossoms, sometimes leaves, sometimes the sweet fragrance of pineapples sold on the street below.

He sat on the edge of the roof as though on a cliff, feeling both precarious and weightless, like a bird carried high on the wind.

The whole city was lit. Its hard skyline vanished into the glow. From a distance, the office towers looked like square cages woven from light. Farther away lay a broad lake. Beside it, traffic flowed along the elevated road, headlights merging into a river of light. Lu Mingfei imagined each point in that river was a living firefly, trapped within the narrow, curving road, able only to rush forward in search of an exit.

He wondered where his own exit was. He thought of Chen Wenwen.

After Nono had left that afternoon, Chen Wenwen had suddenly suggested going down to the river. Dandelions bloomed across the grassy bank, one fluffy ball after another. She picked many and put them in the paper bag with her bellflowers, then sat talking beside him, shoes off, feet soaking in the clear water. Once they went to college, she said, everyone would separate. Perhaps they would only meet in summer. Perhaps they wouldn't see each other for a long time. That was how many good friends slowly forgot one another.

As she spoke, sadness filled her eyes, even more than when she had been reading Duras's The Lover on the first day of school.

He sat beside her, looking into her eyes, watching the wind loosen the dandelion seeds in the bag she held and scatter them over the water like a little snowfall.

Deep inside his heart, a small bird seemed to flutter.

Now the phone against his chest vibrated.

"Lu Mingfei?" It was Nono's voice.

"Yeah," he said.

"I'll tell you a secret. Professor Guderian flies to Beijing tomorrow. If you want to enroll, you'd better decide tonight. We don't have many places. Wait too long, and you might lose your chance."

He grew anxious. "Can't you wait until tomorrow? Tomorrow…"

Tomorrow, he was going to do something earth-shattering, with success or failure hanging by a thread. If Chen Wenwen accepted his confession, he wanted to stay in China. Otherwise, all he could do was slink off to study in America, leaving a legend at his high school: a guy whose life had reached rock bottom, only for a stroke of dumb luck to land him an American college offer.

"No. Professor Guderian's already booked his ticket." Nono sounded cold.

After a long silence, he scratched his head. “Then… I understand.”

“What does ‘I understand’ mean?”

“It means… I guess I’ll have to pass,” he said.

“So you’re turning us down? That’s harsh! Chen Wenwen’s not even that pretty. Think carefully. The gate to Cassell College opens at most once for anyone.”

“Just because you’re prettier than Chen Wenwen doesn’t mean I’ll like you…” he said listlessly.

“A hero! I didn’t know you had that kind of nerve!” Nono seemed angry. “Fine! Goodbye!”

The call ended. Watching the screen slowly go dark, Lu Mingfei felt he had made an enormous gamble.

Now, gazing over the city in the night, he thought about tomorrow’s party. Chen Wenwen had asked him to give a speech. Before dozens of club members, he would do the most recklessly daring thing of his life.

“Only I have absolutely no way back; free to chase, with no one to refuse…” he hummed tunelessly.

Through the remarkable life that lay ahead of him, he would always be like this. Usually limp as a dried-up cucumber, but once he decided on something, as perky as a stalk of celery that had been soaking in water.

“I’m a guy who goes crazy once in a while.” That would later become a favorite saying of Ricardo M. Lu.

In the restroom at Wanda Cinema, Lu Mingfei faced the mirror, listening to his heart pound, going over and over whether he had thought of every step in advance.

The movie would begin soon. The decisive moment was coming.

Flowers, music, and a loud confession. Nono’s three secret weapons.

The flowers were ready. He had picked plenty of dandelions by the river that afternoon, tied them into a bunch, and wrapped them in a paper bag. At the last minute, he had abandoned roses. Chen Wenwen liked dandelions. They had more character.

The music was arranged, too. He had taken a genuine pack of Chunghwa cigarettes from his uncle’s drawer and exchanged it for two fake packs at the downstairs tobacco and liquor shop. One fake pack went back in the drawer. The other became a gift for the projectionist. It had always been one of his ways of raising funds. The projectionist promised to run a short clip before the feature: EVE carrying WALL-E through the sound barrier, with its overwhelmingly moving soundtrack.

He had searched online for his confession, assembled the most touching phrases, and prepared a speech in his head:

“It’s been three years, and now we in the literary club are probably going our separate ways. Once we part, perhaps we won’t get many chances to meet again. Every spring, summer, autumn, and winter, when flowers bloom and fade, when snow falls and melts, it won’t be this same group of us together. It makes me a little sad… As an officer of the literary club, I’m very happy to stand here and give our final speech. It should be addressed to all of you, but there’s only one person I want to speak to…”

At that point, the Little Celestial Princess, the least patient of them all, might jump up and shout, “Lu Mingfei, what are you babbling about?”

If she asked, he would answer in the fiercest voice he could muster, “Shut up! I’m not talking to you! I’m talking to Chen Wenwen! I’ve liked her for three years! I’m not waiting three years, then three more, then another three! I don’t want to be the ‘nice guy’ for the rest of my life!”

That last line, adapted from Infernal Affairs, made him feel like a real man. Tough was good. Better than sounding so wistful and indirect that Chen Wenwen handed him a “you’re a nice guy” rejection on the spot. That would be humiliating. No being a timid little bunny of a man. The most that would get you was a lifetime as every woman’s platonic friend!

He nodded hard at his reflection, face fierce, gaze sharp, conveying, Mingfei, you’re amazing!

“Lu Mingfei, what are you doing?” Zhao Menghua entered the restroom.

“My face suddenly cramped up for some reason. I’m moving it around to see what’s wrong.” Thinking quickly, Lu Mingfei turned, twisting his mouth and squinting even more extravagantly. “Do I look like Stephen Chow?”

“No. More like Arale.” Zhao Menghua handed him a bag. “Clothes. Change before your speech. Chen Wenwen says you should look a little more formal.”

Inside was a Korean-cut black two-button suit, a white shirt, and a narrow black tie, exactly the right size for his skinny frame. He had once wanted a suit like that, but his aunt had refused. How did Chen Wenwen know he wanted one? An enormous sense of happiness hit him on the head like a hammer, nearly making him dizzy.

He hurriedly reached for his phone to call Nono. He wanted to tell her that before the bayonets had even drawn blood, he was already sounding the victory march.

“Sorry, the number you have dialed is currently out of service. Please try again later…”

He slowly closed the phone. He supposed Nono had left, too, disappearing forever like fireworks and bubbles.

Now there truly was no turning back. He would confess, and he had to succeed.

He entered the auditorium. Su Xiaoqiang’s voice pierced his ears like a needle. “Ha ha ha ha! Look, everyone! A monkey in a suit…”

The dozens of club members, already seated with Coke and popcorn, burst out laughing. His face turned eggplant-purple.

“What’s so funny? We’ve got piglets in suits, too,” someone said.

The club’s fattest pair of twins, Xu Yanyan and Xu Miaomiao, came in wearing black suits as well. Equally round and plump, they stood side by side like two basketballs.

“You two giving speeches, too?” Lu Mingfei studied them curiously. All three were dressed identically.

“No speech. We’re just the background,” Xu Yanyan said. “Extras. There’s money in it. Why not?”

Confused, he glanced at Chen Wenwen. She gave him a slight nod, her eyes bright and clear.

“Stand there for your speech.” Zhao Menghua pointed to a sheet of copy paper on the floor in front of the screen. “Right on that spot. Don’t block the screen. We’ll be showing photos of the club.”

Photos of the club? He hadn’t expected that. What about the clip he had arranged?

The projectionist’s dependable figure seemed to appear before him. When Lu Mingfei handed over the cigarettes, the man had snapped his fingers with a look of supreme confidence, tilted his head

forty-five degrees, and raised a firm thumb. “The projection booth’s my turf! Don’t worry! It’s in the bag! I’ll cut it in somehow.” Lu Mingfei decided to trust him.

The lights dimmed. Only that sheet of white paper on the stage remained especially clear. All right. That was his stage. One battle in a lifetime. Win this girl, and happiness for the rest of his life was secured! Everything was ready: dandelions, WALL-E, the speech. Now he was suited, shod, and full of spirit.

He bounded onto the stage, stood on the paper in front of the screen, and took a deep breath, ready to shout to the whole world: Chen Wenwen, I like you!

Nono had told him to gamble everything a man had. He felt ready.

Suddenly, a brilliant light blinded him. The projector had started. Hushing sounds rose throughout the room. He raised an arm over his face. Damn it!

He hadn’t said anything yet. Why had the next part started already? Had the projectionist got the timing wrong? As his eyes adjusted, he suddenly saw Xu Yanyan and Xu Miaomiao standing to his left like two bowling pins.

“What are you doing up here?” he whispered at Xu Yanyan.

“Extras.” Xu Yanyan looked innocent.

He looked around. To his left, a huge, unmoving letter L appeared. The projector was putting letters on the screen.

People were still hushing him. Unable to stand it, he ran a few meters away from the screen to look.

One line: “Chen Wenwen, Lve Yu!”

He didn’t understand the two strange words, but sensed something was wrong.

“Get back! Get back!” Xu Yanyan whispered. “Without your letter, it doesn’t make a sentence.”

“Letter?” He looked again. Out of the corner of his eye, he saw Zhao Menghua leap onto the stage, holding a great bunch of deep-red roses, surrounded by his close friends.

This time, he understood. Cold spread inch by inch from his fingertips, into his heart, deep into his skull, into the joints still aching from all the running he had done to pick dandelions. Xu Yanyan and Xu Miaomiao were the two o’s. He was the lowercase i. Together, they made the perfect sentence: “Chen Wenwen, i Love You.”

A stylish lowercase i, no less. Lu Mingfei could have racked his brains forever and never thought of anything so romantic. But someone else had better brains, and much better English. He’d had an English tutor at home since childhood, after all. A stylish little i was child’s play for him.

Lu Mingfei looked at Chen Wenwen. She was looking at Zhao Menghua, her eyes holding something like the dew of a summer evening, about to spill. By the river, she had been so melancholy and quiet. Not now. He could see the joy in her eyes. He felt he had turned to stone and was about to crumble, bit by bit. Suddenly, he thought of the dandelions in his bag. After all his running on the way here, had they shed their seeds until only bare stems remained?

“Go back! Go back! The sentence doesn’t work without you!” someone shouted from below.

Slowly, he returned to the screen and stood on the sheet of paper, lowering his head to look at no one. The lowercase i looked especially wilted.

"Today was supposed to be our literary club party, but I wanted to take the opportunity," Zhao Menghua said loudly. "We're about to go our separate ways. I don't want regrets. I want to tell Chen Wenwen… Well, it's all on the screen… I had to take a chance! Otherwise, once we're scattered all over the country and never see each other, I'll have liked someone for three years without anyone knowing. How pathetic would that be?"

"Yes! Way to go, boss!" Xu Yanyan and Xu Miaomiao clapped, and Zhao Menghua's friends clapped with them.

"Leading lady! Onstage! Leading lady! Onstage!" Zhao Menghua had clearly prepared everything, even the cheering section.

A spotlight fell on Chen Wenwen. She stood, her white clothes almost translucent, like an angel. She inched toward the stage, blushing red enough to squeeze tomato sauce from her cheeks. Zhao Menghua's friends surrounded her, asking in the familiar tones of supporting boys in a teen movie, "Will you say yes? If you will, hurry up! Zhao Menghua's a great guy!"

Lu Mingfei watched Chen Wenwen, watched her lips. He could hear nothing else. For him, the moment was silent as death, and only one person's voice could break it.

Chen Wenwen's.

"I like… you, too," she told Zhao Menghua softly.

The silence shattered, like thunder tearing across the sky, lightning striking the heart of heaven, rain falling with a soft hiss.

Amid the noise came a sudden wail. Lu Mingfei looked up and saw the Little Celestial Princess run out with her hands over her face. They had been enemies for three years. Now, suddenly, he felt they had quite a lot in common. He almost wanted to run after her, pat her shoulder, and comfort her. But he was the i that wasn't allowed to move.

Everyone rushed up to surround Chen Wenwen and Zhao Menghua, like guests at a wedding. Lu Mingfei thought they must all have known. Only he and Su Xiaoqiang had been kept in the dark. Probably everyone had long since realized he liked Chen Wenwen. That was why no one had told him.

"Heh. So stupid," he told himself, bitterness rising all the way into his nose.

Music swelled. On the screen, EVE broke the sound barrier and crossed the sky with WALL-E. A girl using every power she had to save the little loser she loved, before the two nestled together to music from an old romance. Moving. Perfect for the scene before him. Zhao Menghua had an arm around Chen Wenwen, who rested her bowed head against his shoulder.

The projectionist came in through a side door, one of Lu Mingfei's fake Chunghwa cigarettes in his mouth. With his look of supreme confidence, he snapped his fingers, tilted his head forty-five degrees, and gave Lu Mingfei a thumbs-up, as if to say, Didn't your buddy deliver?

Have you lost your fucking mind, mister? Lu Mingfei wanted to grab his collar and shake him.

But he had no strength left. He slowly sank into a squat against the screen. No one cared about the words I Love You anymore. Even when he turned into a lowercase e, nobody gave him another look.

"Quite a surprise, huh, sister-in-law?" one of Zhao Menghua's friends asked heartily.

"Not at all. I guessed what you were up to ages ago. I just didn't say anything. You're all so shameless." Happy and shy, Chen Wenwen swung Zhao Menghua's hand in hers.

So everyone really had known. Even Chen Wenwen herself. Head hanging, Lu Mingfei quietly made for the exit. Behind him, EVE pressed her face to WALL-E's on the screen. The music was warm and sweet. Chen Wenwen was still EVE, but he wasn't WALL-E. He was nothing.

No, wait. He was the expendable supporting boy who had played an important role on the leads' road to love.

"Don't run off, letter! Don't run off! Extras get red envelopes, too!" Zhao Menghua's friend called after him. "Everyone gets credit!"

Lu Mingfei turned. Zhao Menghua closed one eye and made a face at him. He knew what that meant. He felt he should go back and fight him, but his PE grades were far worse than Zhao Menghua's, too. Besides, the other boy had a whole pack of friends. He had been a loser for so many years that he was used to it. He said, "Oh," then turned and went back toward the stage, back to being his i.

Light shone from behind him, like lightning breaking through dark clouds. Someone had pushed open the auditorium doors with force.

A few times in every life, you feel as though you have seen the gates of heaven swing open. Lu Mingfei had waited eighteen years. At the lowest, most pathetic moment of his life, the gates opened.

The angel who walked in swept her gaze around the room, her eyes sharp as knives.

Everyone fell silent. This stranger who had burst in outshone everyone present. Dazzling. So dazzling that Lu Mingfei thought she must have come purely to steal the show.

"Ricardo, we're running out of time. Are you staying for the rest of this?" Nono walked up to him, speaking in a clear, icy voice that everyone could hear.

Her entire style had changed. Her loose dark-red hair was now immaculately arranged. She wore a deep-purple skirt suit, a pale, moon-white silk blouse, purple stockings, and a full set of custom gold jewelry inset with amethysts. Suddenly ten centimeters taller than usual, she was so imposing that even Lu Mingfei's legs weakened. She caught him just in time and steadied him.

"Oh, I…" He was dazed. He had never felt anything like it. He had become the focus of every eye, like a kettle on a solar cooker, about to be burned by their stares.

"I told you not to wear discount clothes like these." Nono beckoned.

Two impeccably made-up girls pounced and began stripping off his clothes, fierce in their approach but gentle in their hands. He had no time to dodge. Nono took a comb from her small handbag and moved behind him to fix his hair, with a tenderness somewhere between his mother's and an older sister's. The girls were probably clothing-store assistants. They kept fitting and matching five or six suits and five or six pairs of leather shoes on him.

"Now that's our Ricardo M. Lu." Nono patted his cheek, smiling with lethal solicitude.

She faced his classmates, so only he knew what she was doing. Cheerfully, she pinched his cheeks into a fox's face, then a pig's. He knew she was delighted with how utterly pathetic he looked. This little witch would never let anyone get the better of her. She had to be the one who overwhelmed people, the one who rescued them, never the other way around.

"Zhao Menghua set you up on purpose, junior," she whispered.

"How do you know?"

"I used a little feminine charm, and your chubby friend told me." She looked extremely pleased.

"Feminine charm?"

"I spoke to him first. That's all." She pinched his cheek harder. "You think I'm as good to everybody as I am to you?"

The two assistants finished by placing a folded pocket square in his breast pocket, then looked to Nono for approval.

She looked him up and down and frowned. "It'll do. Still a long way below Ricardo's usual standards."

"Good evening, everyone. Ricardo has another engagement tonight, so we'll be leaving first. Enjoy yourselves. Have fun." She inclined her head to his classmates, wearing the flawless smile of a great household's steward: cool and impossible to fault.

"Ricardo?" Zhao Menghua asked.

"Ricardo M. Lu. That's what we all call him," Nono said.

"Let's go! Chin up, chest out! Stop standing there like an idiot!" She jabbed him in the waist.

He nodded and obediently headed out. She linked her arm through his, carrying a faint scent of perfume. Unfortunately, she now looked a little taller than he did. It felt like an older sister picking up her brother after school. He thought Chen Wenwen must be watching his back now, nestled beside Zhao Menghua. He had stolen Zhao Menghua's thunder, but gained nothing himself.

Everything scattered, like fleeting light.

A car waited outside: a Ferrari 599 GTB Fiorano, red as flame. He had read in car magazines that one of these cost nearly five million yuan. He gave Nono an uncertain look.

"Get in. Act natural. They followed us out to watch. Look as though you're thinking, 'A Ferrari? Whatever. At home, it's nothing but Bugatti Veyrons and Maybachs.'" Her lips barely moved.

He sat in the passenger seat, hands placed obediently on his knees. Nono started the engine, and the Ferrari shot forward like a horse freed from its reins. He knew he was getting farther and farther from his past. But he didn't look back.

At night, the Ferrari raced along the elevated road, lights blazing on either side. Watching them stream past outside, he felt he was dreaming. Now he had become one of the little fireflies in that river of light, surging forward with the others, not knowing whether an exit lay ahead.

"I never thought anything like this would happen to me," he murmured.

"Like what? The girl you secretly love slapping you beautifully across the face in front of everyone, then kicking you into a corner?" Nono glanced at him.

"Being picked up in front of my classmates by a hot girl driving a Ferrari."

"Damn it. The hot girl driving the Ferrari is out of gas," Nono said.

Their speed dropped sharply. The Ferrari turned off the elevated road and into a deserted side street. The engine died. They stopped outside a twenty-four-hour pharmacy, whose doorway supplied the street's only patch of light.

"Shit. Forgot to fill up." Nono slapped the steering wheel. "Let's get out and wait. They can send another car." She opened her door and hopped out.

"We could walk a little and get a cab," he suggested.

"No. I don't want to walk. I'm wearing heels." She rejected the idea for the simplest possible reason.

He looked below her suit skirt. Sure enough: Mary Jane heels at least ten centimeters high. Thanks to them, she had instantly evolved from an athletic girl into a glamorous young woman with an older-sister air.

Pleased, she stood close beside him. "See? Almost as tall as you."

"Would it kill you not to get one up on people?" He sat on the curb, hugging his knees.

Without worrying about her exquisite suit, she sat beside him, took out her phone, and texted.

"Why are you all so nice to me?" he asked.

"It's not 'all of us.' It's me. The college just wants you enrolled. It doesn't care who you like," she said. "Call it returning a favor. You bought me ice cream, didn't you?"

He suddenly turned to her. "Hey. You didn't plan all this, did you? You're all messing with me together? Otherwise, why were you dressed like that? You're not the type to play glamorous older woman when you've got nothing to do."

Nono made a face. "You're such a dummy. Who'd bother messing with you? I left in jeans and sneakers. When I found out someone was making a fool of you, I drove off to buy an outfit, changed, and ran in. I was running the whole way."

He looked into her eyes and knew she wasn't lying. He was so moved he almost cried, but held it in.

"It's nothing. If you enroll, you'll be one of us at Cassell. As your senior, I have to look out for you," she said.

"Do I still have a chance?"

"You're an exception. You get one more choice. The last one. Think carefully. Once you choose, turning back won't be easy." She patted his shoulder and smiled mischievously. "But joining us is fine now, anyway. Chen Wenwen doesn't like you, just as I guessed."

"Could you stop picking at the wound?" He turned away. "She didn't mean it. She just doesn't notice I exist."

"All right, all right, Romeo. In your heart, Chen Wenwen can do no wrong. She could slap you a thousand times and you'd still adore her." Nono shrugged. "She didn't know you liked her? She knew, and still let you make that fool of yourself?"

"Tell me. Why do you actually want me? Don't lie. Is it just my parents? Can you explain it? Even if I'm jumping into a fire pit, I ought to know why."

Nono slapped his forehead. "A thirty-six-thousand-dollar annual scholarship! If you won't jump into a fire pit that good, plenty of people will fight for the chance! Aren't you precious."

He had no idea how to handle her. He had worked out the pattern: if he became even slightly forceful, she became ten times more so. Force wouldn't work. He needed cunning. He nudged her with his shoulder. "We're friends, right? Give a friend a tiny hint." He held his fingers close together to show how tiny, his voice coaxing. "Otherwise, I'm all nervous. That's no good."

"All I can tell you is that you're extremely important to us. Admitting you wasn't Professor Guderian's decision. It was the principal's. As for why he thinks so highly of you…" A little fox's charm appeared in her eyes and brows. "Come on. Call me big sis!"

"Big sis," he said very clearly.

"Good boy." She was delighted. "But I don't know why he insists on admitting you either."

He was utterly defeated. "All right. I accept. What else can I do? I haven't revised properly. I won't get into a good school through the entrance exam. And after making such a splash in front of everyone today, what will they think of me?" He lowered his head. "If I don't accept, what am I supposed to say when I go back?"

He felt sad. The Ferrari before him, the little princess Nono beside him, the thirty-six-thousand-dollar scholarship, and distant Cassell College all seemed insubstantial as illusions. He didn't know why they had suddenly appeared in his life, or when they might suddenly disappear. He was the hero of a male Cinderella story. A witch had given him a beautiful friend and a Ferrari, but at midnight the spell would break and he would return to what he had been. What, exactly, was Lu Mingfei? What was he worth? Even he couldn't say.

Nono looked at his downcast eyes, his face plainly saying, I'm pretty sad. Something in her softened. Suddenly, she reached out with both hands and scrubbed his hair into a complete mess. "You look just like that little white rabbit the bear used to wipe his butt!" she said loudly.

She made him so angry he almost hiccupped. "You got used to wipe a bear's butt! Your whole family got used to wipe a bear's butt!"

She wasn't offended. Opening her arms, she tilted her head at him. "Come on, little bunny. Have a hug!"

Startled, he looked down. His gaze touched her chest beneath the silk, its curves soft as the ridgeline of spring hills, and he suddenly felt feverish. To avoid overheating completely and collapsing into her arms, he clutched his own chest and shrank back. "Why are you trying to cop a feel?"

She stuck out her tongue. "You look so pathetic. I'm comforting you. You think you're a tempting piece of tofu? At best, you're dried tofu!"

"Dried tofu has its dignity, too!" He could only talk nonsense to hide his fluster.

"Well? Made up your mind? Hurry up and decide. Miss this chance, and it's gone." As she spoke, she took off her heels. "My feet hurt. They hurt."

"I…" he said. "I've decided. I accept."

She set the purple-and-gold heels beside her and hopped onto the street in her stockings, unconcerned about the dirt. "Much better! See how much I sacrificed for you? I hate wearing heels. Call Professor Guderian. You have to tell him yourself for the choice to take effect."

"Take effect?"

"You're different from ordinary people. Your life has a hidden option. Once you make that call, it activates," she said. "We always say there's another choice. It's just a matter of whether you want it."

"A hidden… option?" He opened his phone and dialed Professor Guderian.

"Mingfei, I'm in Beijing. Have you decided?" The professor sounded even more nervous than he was, as though Lu Mingfei were a peerless beauty considering whether to marry him.

He licked his lips. "I have. I agree to sign the documents."

Nono was playing hopscotch on the paving stones, not looking at him.

"You confirm?" Professor Guderian was delighted.

"I confirm." Lu Mingfei felt his words were like a bride's "I do." They would shape the rest of his life.

"Authentication successful. Option activated. Lu Mingfei. Date of birth: February 14, 1992. Sex: male. Identification number: A.D.0013. Rank: S. Added to the Cassell College register. Database access enabled. Account activated. Course selection form generated. I am Norma, secretary of Cassell College. It is a pleasure to serve you. Your airline ticket, passport, and visa will arrive within three weeks. Welcome, Lu Mingfei." A composed female voice sounded over the phone.

Professor Guderian's voice returned. "Mingfei, your voiceprint signature is complete. Norma will take care of everything else. Just wait for the mail. Are you with Nono? Stay where you are. I'll send transport immediately. There are still a few signatures you need to put on paper."

The call ended. Lu Mingfei was still a little dazed by everything that had just happened.

"Norma's the college's central computer. A computer with a human personality. Leave anything to her. She's absolutely first-rate!" Nono said. "Come play hopscotch!"

"Oh. Sure," he said.

One, two, one, two. As he hopped, Lu Mingfei had no idea what was happening around the world. Everything so far was only the beginning. Huge numbers of data packets poured from the supercomputer called Norma, bound for different corners of the globe. The name Lu Mingfei appeared on many screens and was committed firmly to memory. Data locks released. Thousands of secret gateways across the planet opened to Lu Mingfei.

Cassell College opened its arms to its new student.

A tremendous noise traveled through the dark night sky. He looked up and saw a huge black shape approaching at low altitude.

"No way," he murmured.

"The old man's that eager to collect you?" Nono looked up. "He even sent a helicopter."

Friday, May 15, 2009. A black helicopter swept over the small southern city like a great bird, passing above the boy Lu Mingfei.

The curtain was about to rise once more on the war hidden within history.

Act Two

Golden Eyes

It was the painting's oppressive power.

In it, the sky was iron-gray mingled with the color of flames. A single enormous tree stood beneath it, its dead branches reaching in every direction, weaving a dense web that held up the cracked heavens.

Bones littered the wasteland. A black beast was rising from deep within the heaps of remains, skulls hanging from its wings. It spread those vast membranes and breathed black fire into the sky.

A piercing roar echoed inside Lu Mingfei's head. Incredibly, he felt he could hear the creature screaming.

Amid the bustling crowd, Lu Mingfei glanced at the ticket in his hand, then up at the cathedral-like dome of Chicago's railway station.

A huge suitcase stood on either side of him; together they weighed almost as much as he did. His backpack bulged where his aunt had stuffed in a pressure cooker. A woven plastic sack held a twelve-hole hollow-fiber quilt, his pillow was strapped to a suitcase, and his passport was clenched between his teeth.

Heaven's chosen son and newly minted international student Lu Mingfei had brought his entire overseas survival kit across the ocean on a United Airlines flight, landing alone at Chicago's international airport. According to the itinerary Norma had prepared, he would take the CC1000 Express from the station to Cassell College.

"I really wish I could take you myself, but I have to fly to Russia," Professor Guderian had said regretfully over the phone. "Don't worry, though. Norma will arrange everything."

Norma was indeed an outstanding secretary. Three weeks later, a gigantic envelope reached him containing everything from his passport to his itinerary, plus Cassell College Enrollment for Dummies, labeled underneath: Lu Mingfei Edition.

Despite its ridiculous title, the guide proved extremely useful—until he reached Chicago's railway station.

"The CC1000 Express? Never heard of it… Perhaps a branch-line train? But that number doesn't sound right… The new timetable lists every service. Check again… The ticket looks genuine, but I really don't know any such train." Different station employees all gave him versions of the same answer.

There was no such express in the timetable.

"This is one hell of a screwup!" Lu Mingfei wanted to tear his hair out in the middle of the crowd.

God promised Moses, Go to Canaan, the land of milk and honey, and gave him a map. With divine power, Moses crossed the vast Red Sea, escaped his Egyptian pursuers, and barely survived—only to find signposts reading TO INDIA, TO CHINA, and TO JAPAN, with no TO CANAAN anywhere. The friendly policeman below the signs said, "Canaan? No idea. Never heard of it!"

That was approximately how Lu Mingfei felt.

He had only twenty dollars left. His aunt had given him five hundred for traveling expenses. But at Chicago customs, a chubby officer had counted the dozens of pirated PS2 discs he had brought, written a terrifying figure on a receipt, and complimented his taste all at once. “Oh? Resident Evil 4! Ha! You like Dynasty Warriors, too? Hey! I love Dragon Quest!…”

Perhaps out of appreciation for his taste, the fat officer had left him twenty dollars.

Now this Moses from across the world stood outside Subway, clutching his single twenty-dollar bill, wondering whether to grit his teeth and go hungry or buy a sandwich-and-Coke combo. Whatever the merits of that thirty-six-thousand-dollar scholarship, he had only twenty dollars now. Spend six and fourteen remained. How many more days could he last? Perhaps he should save his food money to buy a phone card and call the college. He had no phone. His uncle had kept that N96 as a treasured farewell gift.

“One dollar, just one dollar…” someone said behind him.

It was the standard American beggar’s refrain, much like the rhythmic songs of beggars in old China.

“No! I am poor! No money!” Lu Mingfei replied in plain, economical English.

He turned to inspect the tall, burly young man behind him. The face buried in a full beard was rather handsome, his candle-bright eyes full of yearning. His dark-green plaid shirt and loose, dragging trousers looked as though they hadn’t been changed or washed in ages. A beggar like this was a rare sight in America. The others dressed better.

“Chinese?” Recognizing his nationality, the man instantly switched to fluent Chinese. “Kind sir, spare enough for a Coke. I’m really not a beggar. I just lost my wallet while traveling.”

You know the begging patter in both Chinese and English that well, and you’re claiming you’re not a professional? Lu Mingfei thought.

“Fingel von Frings. Really not a beggar. A college student.” To prove it, the young man took a dictionary-sized textbook from the shoulder bag behind him.

Its title was in a mixture of English and Latin. The book looked old, and Lu Mingfei seemed to have seen that sort of writing somewhere before.

This guy actually spoke fluent Chinese… A thought flashed through his mind. He had seen that style of writing on his Cassell College admission documents.

“Are you waiting for… the CC1000 Express?” he asked.

Each took a magnetic ticket from his pocket. They were identical: black cards bearing a silver image of a vast, leafy tree.

“I’m a freshman. Lu Mingfei.” He offered his hand in friendship.

“One of my own! At last, someone who can give me a dollar for a Coke.” Fingel seized his hand.

Is there anything besides Coke inside that bird’s nest you call a head? Lu Mingfei thought.

“Brother, I admire you. You look like a loyal friend!” Sprawled across a bench, Fingel took great bites of a sandwich and drank Lu Mingfei’s Coke.

Between them, they had twenty-five dollars. Since Coke came with free refills, Lu Mingfei suggested they needn’t buy two cups. All they needed were two straws and twice as many refills.

Fingel came from Germany, an advanced capitalist nation, but showed none of the supposed German fastidiousness about hygiene. He enthusiastically praised his Chinese schoolmate's ingenuity.

"What year are you in, senior?" Lu Mingfei asked.

"Eighth."

"Eighth?" Lu Mingfei choked on his Coke.

"Well, fourth, actually. I repeated a year," Fingel said.

"Then how is it eighth?"

"Repeated it four years running…"

Deeply concerned about his future, Lu Mingfei decided to avoid the terrifying subject of repeating years. "Have you taken that train before?"

"Every semester. Otherwise you have to take a helicopter. The campus is in the mountains. This is the only train that goes there. Nobody knows its timetable—nobody at Chicago station, anyway. The last conductor who knew its schedule died two years ago. He said it had been running since before World War II," Fingel said. "Don't worry. A train always comes eventually. Low-ranking people just have to wait."

"Ranking? What's that? The bourgeoisie and the proletariat?" Lu Mingfei asked.

"Something like aristocratic status. Higher-ranked students get privileges. College resources go to them first. Like having a train sent for you sooner."

"Eight years here, and your rank still isn't high enough?"

"To tell the truth, I'm caught between being expelled and scrambling for enough credits!" Fingel spread his hands.

"Is it easy to find work after graduating from Cassell? You've spent four years in your fourth year and still don't want to drop out?"

"No. They assign you a job!" Fingel belched loudly.

Lu Mingfei looked through the station's floor-to-ceiling windows. Dark skyscrapers stood shoulder to shoulder like giants. Night had fallen over Chicago. Trains scattered bright sparks as they passed along the elevated tracks. Pedestrians hurried by; neon lights flashed.

He and Fingel had spent two nights at the station. Without hotel money, they could only wrap themselves in blankets and sleep on the waiting-room benches. Had their magnetic tickets not actually worked in the gates, security would have thrown them out long ago. Yet no one at the station knew anything about the mysterious CC1000 branch-line express.

Fingel didn't care. Every trip back to college was like this, he said. They could only blame their low rank. High-ranking students were met by a train on arrival and boarded through a VIP entrance without causing a stir. Lu Mingfei had to ask just how low their ranks were. Roughly medieval serf level, Fingel said. Seeing his spirits fall, he added consolingly that there were ranks below serfs. Some people ranked about level with mules.

Only the two of them remained in the waiting hall. Fingel wandered about with his textbook, his reading echoing through the huge space. Lu Mingfei wrapped himself in his blanket and curled up on a wooden bench. As his mind grew hazy, he dimly heard distant bells.

The bells echoed, apparently from a faraway church. Eyes closed, his thoughts wandered: a wasteland under the moon; a dark church silhouette in the distance; crowds running across the wilderness with torches that couldn't light their faces, leaving them hidden in shadow. They ran toward a full moon, impossibly large, half sunk below the horizon. From a mountaintop, those people leaped toward it.

He started. Why had he thought of that? Mad, magnificent, and real—as though he had witnessed that splendid scene himself.

Why were those bells so monotonous? Something was wrong. He was in Chicago. Outside lay busy roads, noise, a hubbub of voices. Why could he hear only that solitary, monotonous tolling? There shouldn't have been a church nearby.

He sat up. An enormous moon was slowly rising beyond the windows. Moonlight flooded in like a tide approaching the shore. The whole waiting hall lay beneath its cool, watery light. Window frames cast shadows across the bench backs. A boy sat in silence, his face lifted toward the moon.

Lu Mingfei looked around. Fingel was gone. So were the guards at the entrance. The distant Subway had switched off its lights. Only he and the boy remained. It was strange, but he dared not speak or even breathe hard. The silence filling the hall felt impossible to break.

The boy looked Chinese, about thirteen or fourteen, in a jet-black little evening suit. Light flowed over his young face. Lu Mingfei couldn't understand why a child that age wore a silence and sorrow that said, I have lived for thousands of years. Nor why, with so many empty benches, he had chosen to sit beside him, as though waiting for him to wake.

Lu Mingfei lifted off the blanket and sat beside the boy. They watched the moonlight without a word. Time flowed slowly, as if they were two people watching the sea.

"Shall we trade?" the boy asked softly.

"What? What?" Lu Mingfei didn't understand.

"Shall we trade?" the boy asked again.

"Trade what? I don't have money… I am poor, no money…"

"So you're still refusing?" The boy slowly turned his head. Flame-like light flowed through his golden pupils, like a mirror reflecting fire.

In an instant, that fire swallowed Lu Mingfei's entire consciousness. His body convulsed. As though facing mortal danger, a tremendous force erupted inside him. He jerked backward.

"Ah!" Fingel's scream jolted him awake.

Fingel was crouched nearby, clutching his head. Noise came from outside: footsteps, car horns, wheels grinding against rails, every sound of the metropolis. Two guards dozed against the doorway. The distant Subway was still lit.

Another dream? Lu Mingfei thought.

He had never had two dreams stacked together before. In the first, crowds ran across a wasteland. In the second, he spoke to a boy. He had woken from the first straight into the second, when he had really been asleep on the bench all along, without even lifting his blanket.

"Don't do the high jump in your sleep! You just leaped like a startled flea!" Fingel complained.

Lu Mingfei wiped sweat from his forehead. Why had he been frightened? The boy's golden eyes? What was strange about golden eyes? The anime-club girls wore colored contacts in every shade imaginable.

"Get your luggage. The train's here," Fingel said.

He heard bells and a train whistle. Fingel was right. A train had just arrived, its headlights sweeping the platform. At two in the morning, on a night with no extra services scheduled, the CC1000 Express pulled in.

A dark figure appeared beside the empty ticket gate: a man in an old-fashioned dark-green conductor's uniform, with a gold badge on his cap. He rang a little gold bell and carried a flashlight and a card reader.

"CC1000 Express. Passengers, please prepare to board. Passengers, please prepare to board." His voice echoed through the hall.

The guards went on sleeping. Only Fingel seemed to notice the conductor. No one even looked out from the brightly lit Subway. A man in such an antiquated uniform appearing in a modern Chicago station in the middle of the night ought to have been remarkable. Yet nobody noticed him.

Lu Mingfei shivered. The conductor was like a… ghost!

"Why does it feel like… a train to hell?" He grabbed Fingel's sleeve.

"Just the effect of his Yanling. Perfectly ordinary living guy. A Backstreet Boys fan, too," Fingel said.

"Yanling?" Lu Mingfei stared.

"We're here! Fingel and Lu Mingfei!" Fingel waved.

Lu Mingfei cautiously took out his ticket and followed him toward the gate, dragging his bags. Only when he saw the conductor's face did he believe Fingel. The man really didn't look like a ghost. He was chewing gum and blowing bubbles.

The conductor swiped Fingel's ticket. A green light came on with a beep.

"Still haven't dropped out, Fingel? I thought I wouldn't see you this year."

"I finish what I start," Fingel said. "Train's awfully late. Did my rank drop again?"

"To F. You started at A, remember. You've fallen all the way from heaven to hell."

"Really gone from serf to livestock…" Fingel muttered.

Lu Mingfei's ticket passed through the reader. The light turned green, but this time cheerful music played.

"Lu Mingfei?" The conductor's beautiful green eyes brightened. "Terribly sorry. A dispatching error. You're S-rank, but we get so few people that high that the system must have malfunctioned. Like the millennium bug."

"S?" Fingel's eyes widened. "Isn't the principal the only S?"

"Not the only one. But there are no more than ten," the conductor said. "Hurry aboard. We don't stop long."

"Can I ask something… Is this really an official train? Why isn't it in the timetable? Why didn't it arrive on time?" He couldn't help himself. Everything about it was uncanny. If it really was the Hell Express, at least he could say a prayer before boarding.

"Of course. Specially approved by Chicago's city government, direct to Cassell College. It isn't listed because it's an irregular branch-line service. You know those special trains that use the public railway but go to particular mines or factories? We're like those." The conductor answered straightforwardly, without a hint of mystery.

They followed him onto the platform. The high-speed train waited on the tracks, headlights dazzling. It was black and streamlined, with brilliant silver-white vines spreading over the paintwork, magnificent as a work of art. Outside its one open sliding door stood a familiar figure: Professor Guderian.

The train raced through the black night. Across a narrow oak table, Lu Mingfei and Fingel faced Professor Guderian. The carriage was elegantly European, its walls covered in Victorian-patterned wallpaper, its windows framed in solid wood. Dark-green leather sofas were embroidered with gold. Every detail was exquisite. Both boys had changed into Cassell uniforms: white shirts, dark-green suits edged in silver, deep rose-red neck scarves, the college's World Tree emblem embroidered on their breast pockets. No college tailor had ever measured Lu Mingfei, yet the clothes fit perfectly. Turning back a cuff, he found a name stitched inside in dark-green thread: Ricardo M. Lu.

The moment he boarded this train and put on these clothes, he felt he had become upper class. Extremely upper class.

Yet he couldn't help feeling afraid, for no clear reason, as though something terrible were about to happen.

"Coffee or hot chocolate?" Professor Guderian asked. He sat against the wall, a huge canvas-covered painting behind him.

"Hot chocolate." Fingel raised his hand.

"I wasn't asking you. Be serious. I'm your temporary adviser, assigned by the college. This is freshman orientation." The professor looked at Lu Mingfei. "You could have something stronger, too."

"You can… drink alcohol while meeting your adviser?"

"They just give you something to calm your nerves so you don't start screaming halfway through orientation," Fingel whispered.

"Is… is it that bad?" Lu Mingfei shrank back.

"Worse… than you think," the professor said quietly. "First, I'm sorry I'm late. Russia held me up longer than expected. Only after returning did I discover the dispatching error and that you still hadn't been collected, so I came along on the train. Second, every student must take an entrance qualification exam. We call it the 3E exam. Without passing, you cannot be admitted, and your scholarship cannot take effect yet."

"A qualification exam?" Lu Mingfei relaxed. "Still frightening… but at least my heart survived that."

"Please sign this confidentiality agreement." The professor handed him a document.

His hand trembled over the strange mixture of Latin and English, but he signed. The train was carrying him toward mysterious Cassell College at more than two hundred kilometers an hour. This was the road his parents had pointed out. What could he refuse now?

Professor Guderian carefully put it away. "As a legitimate university registered with the U.S. Department of Education, Cassell College has always offered high-quality education to students of

exceptional talent, along with help finding jobs. Our normal course lasts four years. People like Fingel, who haven't graduated after eight, are very rare. We follow a traditional residential system. All students must live on campus. At graduation, you receive an official degree. Unfortunately, our degrees may not correspond to subjects available at other universities. If you wish to pursue a master's or doctorate, you will have to remain here."

"You mean… it isn't a proper degree?" Lu Mingfei grew wary.

"No, quite proper. Our degrees fully meet the department's requirements. I mean that our subject is unusual." The professor chose his words. "Extremely unusual."

"How… unusual?" Lu Mingfei blinked.

"You know what a seminary is?"

He nodded.

"A seminary is a specialized school whose students mainly study God. Medical schools principally study the workings of the human body. Business schools examine the ancient question of exchange. Cassell is another such specialized institution. What we study is…"

He stood, seized a corner of the canvas covering the enormous oil painting behind him, and whipped it away.

The terrible scene lay exposed beneath the lights. The instant Lu Mingfei looked at it, he felt as though an enormous force would fling him backward.

It was the painting's oppressive power.

In it, the sky was iron-gray mingled with the color of flames. A single enormous tree stood beneath it, its dead branches reaching in every direction, weaving a dense web that held up the cracked heavens. Bones littered the wasteland. A black beast rose from deep within the heaps of remains, skulls hanging from its wings. It spread those vast membranes and breathed black fire into the sky.

A piercing roar echoed inside Lu Mingfei's head. Incredibly, he felt he could hear the creature screaming.

"A dragon?" His voice trembled.

"Yes. A dragon. More precisely, the Dragon Emperor Nidhogg. According to the Poetic Edda of Norse mythology, at Ragnarök it will gnaw through the roots of Yggdrasil, the World Tree. On that day, the world will end." Professor Guderian ran his fingers over the neatly shelved, finely bound ancient books. "If you knew Latin, you could read their titles. Dragon Genealogy, Dragons and Yanling, The Key of Solomon, On Dragon Bloodlines, Dragon Genetics… Thousands of years of accumulated knowledge. Countless generations have sought and studied dragons. Cassell brings it all together. Here you can study alchemical engineering, magic-powered mechanical design, theories of dragon lineage, and other disciplines. Every course has the same ultimate goal." He looked directly into Lu Mingfei's eyes. "Slaying dragons!"

"S-slaying dragons?"

"Slaying dragons." The professor nodded. "In places you know nothing of, this has gone on for thousands of years. Humanity has written one history without dragons, but another history bears their presence on every line. The secret is too astonishing. If it escaped, the consequences would be impossible to predict. So for thousands of years, certain families we call the Bloodline Clans have held it together and shouldered the duty of killing dragons. They trained descendants in combat,

incantations, magic, and alchemy, sending them onto the battlefield to bury one attempt at a dragon revival after another. Today, Cassell College carries on their legacy."

"Their… legacy?"

"Yes. The old dragon-slaying families were vast, and most have died out. In this new era, we can no longer rely on family succession. We need a modern educational system." He offered his hand. "Welcome to Cassell College, Lu Mingfei!"

"Could you… not stick out your hand and welcome me before I've decided? Your college is a vocational school for dragon slayers? Please!" Lu Mingfei's face twitched. "Can we keep the joke within reason? What is this, the opening cinematic of a new Dragon Quest? How did I get inside your cinematic? Could someone give me a portal out?"

A world-shattering crash. The entire train rocked. Every light flickered and died. Darkness fell.

"Hey! Did we hit a mountain?" He felt himself over. Apparently unhurt. "Anyone injured? Anyone know where the candles are?"

"Lu Mingfei, everything they said is true," someone said softly in the dark.

The lights returned. The same luxurious train, the same leather sofa. But Professor Guderian and Fingel were gone. He turned. The boy from his dream at Chicago station sat beside him.

"Y-you… where did you get on?" he stammered.

"I've been here all along. I was waiting for the train, just like you," the boy said mildly.

"You sound like a vengeful ghost…"

"Look outside," the boy said. "Welcome… to the realm of dragons!"

Following his gaze, Lu Mingfei looked out the window. His pupils dilated. Before that world, he lost even the strength to breathe.

It was no longer dark. The train sped across an immense ice field. White ice with a faint blue sheen covered a mountain stabbing into the sky. The heavens were blood-red. Torrential rain fell, every drop crimson, running down the windows. Atop the ice peak lay the dragon from the painting, motionless, its wings reaching all the way to the foot of the mountain. Thick, reeking blood stained the entire peak. Crowds climbed its wings. Those who reached the summit gathered around its head and drove sharp iron spikes into its skull, hammering fiercely at their ends. Each time they bored a hole, white fluid spouted like a fountain, then quickly evaporated into dense white vapor. They cheered and leaped, their cries shaking the sky.

"Nidhogg, the Black Dragon King. Thousands of years ago, he was killed on his own throne. His throne was that mountain, eternally covered in ice and snow. His killers left his enormous corpse on its summit, wings hanging to its foot. Blood ran down like lava, staining the mountain red and melting the ice. Blood-colored vapor rose into the sky, became dark-red clouds, and fell as scarlet rain. His killers bathed in it and cheered. They called that day the beginning of the New Era," the boy said softly.

"Oh… God!" Lu Mingfei trembled at the distant sound of hammers striking iron spikes.

"This is the oldest emperor, unrecorded in history. On the day he died, everyone rejoiced." The boy's voice was calm.

He seemed to enjoy the hammering enormously, closing his eyes to savor it in silence, a faint smile on his face.

"How wonderful. Without that day, the world would never have become what it is." He opened his eyes and looked at Lu Mingfei.

Somehow, Lu Mingfei felt such terrible sadness in his smile.

Thousands of years… of sadness.

"You and that black dragon…" he ventured. "Were you close?"

"No. Not at all. Quite the opposite," the boy whispered. "I am the one who most wants to kill him. No one in this world wants him dead more than I do!"

Lu Mingfei opened his eyes to find himself lying on a leather couch beneath a blanket. He was in an elegantly old-fashioned study, bookcases all around and a crystal chandelier overhead.

He sat up and looked around. Professor Guderian was dozing at a nearby desk.

"You're awake?" The professor raised his disheveled head.

"Where are we? Did the train overturn? I just heard this huge crash." He pressed his forehead. A blood vessel seemed to throb inside his skull.

"We're at Cassell. The journey was perfectly smooth. Why would we hit a mountain? You were so frightened during orientation that you fainted. We had to carry you off the train…" The professor spread his hands. "Some freshmen have been rather surprised before, but a reaction like yours is unprecedented. Are you… that afraid of dragons? Fundamentally, they're only a powerful species."

"No!" Lu Mingfei stared into his eyes. "I'm not afraid of dragons… Have you seen The Terminator?"

"Yes. Arnold Schwarzenegger. I'm very fond of him. The current governor of California." The professor nodded.

"Remember the scene where John Connor's mother is at a police station? She tells the police she saw a robot that traveled back through time from an era when humanity's nearly extinct, firing a laser rifle everywhere…" Lu Mingfei said. "And the police tell her she's mentally ill!"

"You think I'm mentally ill?"

"Either you are or I am!" he shouted.

"All right. Some freshmen need physical evidence!" The professor clapped his hands.

The study door opened. A middle-aged man whose face practically announced I AM JAPANESE strode in with a sturdy, silver-edged black briefcase in each hand. Setting them on the desk, he bowed respectfully to Lu Mingfei and introduced himself in fluent Chinese. "I'm Masashi Toyama, a psychological counselor here at Cassell. It's a great pleasure to meet our S-rank freshman. We haven't had an S-rank freshman in more than forty years."

"Really? May I ask what sort of person the one forty years ago was? An unrivaled master dragon slayer?" Lu Mingfei tried to think along their lines.

"He had the chance. But in the second semester of his sophomore year, he shot himself. So that was that," Masashi Toyama said with complete candor.

"Shot himself?"

"His grades were too good, his thinking too acute. While studying dragon lore, he got trapped in certain philosophical difficulties and couldn't find his way out. So he shot himself. That was when we added psychological counselors," Masashi Toyama said.

"Sounds promising." Lu Mingfei drew a breath. "I've always been famous for being slow."

"But you have potential!" Professor Guderian gave Toyama an exuberant thumbs-up, clearly indicating that his student was the best.

Lu Mingfei couldn't understand what there was to celebrate. He wanted to cover his face.

"We've brought two pieces of evidence proving that dragons exist. Both are high-grade artifacts we borrowed especially from the college archives." With a passcode and fingerprint, Toyama opened the first case. Beneath layers of foam lay a black scale, about half the size of a palm, perfectly shield-shaped, its surface gleaming as though freshly oiled. Fine patterns showed clearly beneath the sheen.

"Feel it," Toyama said.

Lu Mingfei cautiously picked it up. It felt artificial, rather like steel—cold and tough, yet almost as light as plastic. Its edge was sharp enough to cut his fingers at the slightest pressure. Then Toyama pressed something into his hand.

He stared. It was a handgun.

"Walther PPK. Seven-point-six-five-millimeter caliber, muzzle velocity two hundred eighty meters per second, effective range fifty meters. The Equipment Department made a few improvements. Now you can shoot the scale." Toyama set it on the windowsill.

"I know this gun… James Bond uses it." Lu Mingfei's face was white.

"Yes, the classic Bond pistol." Toyama covered his ears. "Don't worry. Just fire. Aim at the scale."

"Lunatic logic is impossible to understand." Miserably, Lu Mingfei raised the gun. Following his high school military training, he aimed at the scale, gritted his teeth, and pulled the trigger.

A thunderous blast. It felt as though a sledgehammer had hit his chest. The PPK's recoil was like firing an aircraft cannon. He toppled backward into the sofa, stars filling his vision, nearly losing consciousness.

"So he isn't one of the physically gifted students!" Toyama's surprised voice sounded beside him. "Perhaps I should have brought an ordinary revolver."

"Was that gun modified by Equipment? Honestly, don't casually test things those lunatics have worked on!" Professor Guderian complained repeatedly.

"I was curious. It's a fine gun. It might not blow a dragon's eye apart with one shot, but it should leave a mark on fourth- or fifth-generation dragons," Toyama said.

Lu Mingfei shook his head hard until his surroundings came into focus. First, Professor Guderian's concerned face. Second, the black scale swaying in Toyama's hand. Perfect and unblemished. Nothing had marked its surface. He was absolutely certain he had hit its center. He wasn't an athletic student, but in military training he had been one of the rare shooters to score a hundred with ten shots. His instructor had been astonished that this unremarkable boy handled a gun so well.

A pistol comparable to an aircraft cannon hadn't pierced that scale.

"A dragon scale. Sven Hedin found it in 1900, in the ruins of Loulan in Xinjiang. He didn't recognize it, but discovered that neither fire nor hammer blows could damage it, so he took it from China to Europe. Someone there recognized it: Meinhard Cassell. That's our first piece of evidence. Beginning to believe us?" Toyama asked.

"Couldn't it be high technology?" Lu Mingfei still resisted.

"Even a titanium alloy made using nanotechnology couldn't stop that shot," Toyama said. "I have a doctorate in materials science from the University of Tokyo. Trust me."

Not just lunatics everywhere. Highly educated lunatics everywhere, Lu Mingfei thought.

"Now, the second piece of evidence." Toyama opened the other case. A cylindrical glass jar appeared before Lu Mingfei, like the specimen jars his biology teacher used.

His mouth fell open as though he had been struck by lightning. If Toyama had stuffed an orange into it, he probably wouldn't have noticed. Suspended in pale-yellow formalin was a lizardlike animal, yellowish-white, its long tail curled around it like a fetus in the womb. Long whiskers drifted slowly beside its mouth. With its eyes closed, it looked peaceful as a baby. Without the two membranous wings spread from its back, he would have taken it for some ancient lizard.

"A red dragon hatchling. It isn't even dead, merely dormant. Dragons are difficult to kill, especially the noble first and second generations. Even destroying their bodies cannot destroy their souls. They can awaken again," Toyama said. "An exceedingly rare specimen. Humans usually can't capture dragons. They sense the activity of our brains and attack or flee before we approach. This specimen was discovered in India in 1796. Fortunately, a giant python seems to have swallowed it just after it hatched. Local farmers killed the python and found the hatchling in its stomach."

"Are you sure it isn't plastic?" Lu Mingfei covered his face. "It's over. My entire worldview's finished."

"Look closely. The detail, the patterns on its scales. What artist could make a plastic model this perfect?" Toyama brought the jar nearer.

Now only half a centimeter of glass separated their faces. Its wings and whiskers stirred in the liquid, as though it hovered among clouds. Toyama was right. Those details, those patterns, were too real. Only nature or God could create something like this. Such creatures existed in history's shadows, in different peoples' legends, at the limits of human imagination—and inside this sealed glass jar.

"Perfect, isn't it?" Toyama sounded admiring.

"Perfect," Lu Mingfei murmured.

He stared at the membranes covering its eyes and remembered those golden pupils opening slowly in the dark, as though the gates of the world were opening before him.

The hatchling in the formalin suddenly opened its golden eyes. Its whole body jerked from head to tail. Stretching its neck, it roared at Lu Mingfei. Burning dragonfire ignited deep in its throat and burst out! It spread its wings fiercely, trying to break free of the jar. Awake now, though no larger than a cat, it possessed a dragon's majesty.

Lu Mingfei didn't dodge. All three stood stupefied, watching the ancient specimen revive.

The tiny flame died at once. Formalin flooded the hatchling's throat, making it cough in agony like a drowning man. Nor could it break the glass. Its powerful wingbeats left not even a mark. This awakening, centuries in the making, ended as quickly as it had begun. Soon the hatchling curled up again, peaceful once more, returning to dormancy.

"Aaaaaaah!" At last, Lu Mingfei could scream. Trembling, he pointed at the jar.

"Don't shout," Professor Guderian murmured.

"Didn't you see? Didn't you see? It came alive! It came alive! A living dragon!" Lu Mingfei shook the utterly stunned old man and yelled.

"I saw." The professor turned to Toyama. "You saw it, too, didn't you?"

White-faced, Toyama could only nod. "Yes… But that really wasn't what I meant to do. I didn't know it would wake up just now…" His voice suddenly rose almost to a shriek. "What happened? Did those people in the archives mislabel it? Its awakening date is supposed to be 2077! Their careless labels could kill us! It breathed dragonfire just now! Dragonfire!"

"Thank goodness we began switching to nanomaterial containers two years ago. Otherwise it wouldn't have held…" Cold sweat covered the professor's forehead. "Heavens. Professor Manstein and I calculated its awakening date. We shouldn't have been wrong… Unless… unless it was a bloodline summons!"

"A bloodline summons?" Toyama turned to Lu Mingfei, plainly regarding a monster.

"What else could wake a dragon early?" The professor's eyes blazed as he thumped Lu Mingfei's shoulder. "Your powerful bloodline called to it! Now do you understand how extraordinary you are?"

His shoulder was nearly collapsing under the blows. "What are you talking about? Don't blame me for a potentially fatal accident! I didn't do anything!"

"The Dragon Emperor can make humans submit merely by looking at them. You needn't do anything. You're a dragon hybrid with second-generation capabilities!" The professor nodded vigorously.

"What hybrid? My dad's human. My mom's human. Read too many Strange Tales from a Chinese Studio? Think everyone in China has babies with dragons?" Lu Mingfei argued.

"No. They are indeed human. But both are dragon hybrids, so your blood contains a substantial proportion of dragon blood." Guderian exchanged a glance with Toyama. "You'll learn sooner or later. Most people at this college are hybrids. Do you know how we determine rank? By bloodline! You're S-rank because your dragon blood is exceptionally pure!"

Lu Mingfei was dumbstruck. Suddenly the professor looked like an old dragon, liable to breathe deadly fire into his face at any moment.

What was this place? A whole college of dragon hybrids? How was that different from a dragon's nest? And in that nest, he was… a little white rabbit! His dragon blood was pure? Why had a fine young mammal raised under the red flag suddenly been classified as a reptile?

"Your proportion of dragon blood does not exceed fifty percent, though. We don't admit students above that. Their potential far exceeds ordinary people's, but the dragon blood slowly turns them into followers of dragons," the professor said.

"You have… a grudge against dragons?"

"Humanity does. Not just us." His eyes shone. "Your Dragon Genealogy course will explain everything. Now that you know dragons exist, would you like to learn more? There's a way! Every course includes knowledge about them. Why don't we choose your classes?"

"I don't want to learn more! Can I withdraw?" Lu Mingfei raised a hand.

The professor looked disappointed. "Well… You can. But the agreement you signed includes memory erasure. If you withdraw, these memories must be removed. Having glimpsed the real world, wouldn't it be a shame to leave?"

"What shame?" Lu Mingfei asked.

"Who wouldn't want to know the real world? It's broader than you can imagine. Beside it, the world you knew is as tiny as a grain of rice on a wasteland," Toyama said.

Lu Mingfei paused, then immediately shook his head. "No. Don't want to. I've never minded being a fat, white rice weevil."

"It isn't just memory loss." The professor patted his shoulder. "Think. Your parents are of dragon blood. Your uncle and aunt don't like you. You have no particular talents. If your memory's erased and you're sent back to China, you'll have to repeat a year for the entrance exam. Can you imagine how miserable that would be?"

The old man had struck his weakness exactly. Compared with some grand, authentic world, the pressure of repeating the college entrance exam was real to him—terrifyingly real.

His face fell. "All right. I'll try it for a couple of days…"

"Excellent!" Excitement flashed in the professor's eyes. "I already have your training plan! For the first semester, I recommend Introduction to Dragon Genealogy, Magic-Powered Mechanical Design I, and Alchemical Chemistry I as your major courses. Take Old Norse for your language elective, and Tai Chi for PE. That gives you thirteen credits. No other freshman should match you. I'll make you Cassell's second truly deserving S-rank student in more than forty years!"

"Higher expectations? Parents like these don't understand their son at all. Do they think they gave birth to a genius?" Lu Mingfei felt utterly powerless. "All right. Let's stop talking around it. What if I fail?"

"Just retake the course. Unless you seriously violate the rules, Cassell doesn't expel students. Some fail for years and still keep retaking the exams." The professor sounded reassuring. "Remember Fingel? He's been in his fourth year for four years… Nobody told him to leave."

Reassurance? This was a naked threat. Fingel had once been a spirited A-rank student. Now he had been tormented into a sleazy vagrant. And that S-rank senior had shot himself. Apparently, the higher your rank, the more likely you were to die, Lu Mingfei thought.

"Fine. I agree. I'll sign. One last question: why is Chinese compulsory? Why do you all speak it?"

"An excellent question." The professor nodded. "According to the Research Department, several heavyweight figures among the dragons, at the rank of prince, lie dormant in China. They're about to awaken. Chinese became compulsory ten years ago. Every one of you bears the duty of entering China's heartland to kill Dragon Kings!"

"No wonder you assign jobs after graduation… You couldn't recruit anyone for work like this!" Lu Mingfei said.

"But our benefits are excellent. We even pay for your medical insurance!"

"Please! You're in the dragon-slaying business. How could anyone live without medical insurance? This work could kill you! What's the maximum coverage? Fifty million dollars?"

"It covers flying your remains back to China, free of charge…"

"What?" His eyes widened. He imagined a corpse under a white sheet being carried off a plane, a tag on its head bearing the familiar name Lu Mingfei.

Flanked by Professor Guderian and Masashi Toyama, both clapping his shoulders heartily, he left the office like a wilted chicken. Men dressed as maintenance workers passed them with toolboxes, apparently heading to repair the window in which the aircraft-cannon PPK had blasted a large hole.

Outside the medieval-style building were green lawns, crimson cobbled paths, and castle-like buildings. Pigeons rose and settled on a distant church roof. Sunlight restored a little of Lu Mingfei's vitality. At least it looked as though he still lived in the human world.

"My mom…" he began.

He needed to find out exactly what role his parents had played in this enrollment fiasco. What parents could be scheming enough to torment their only son to death? Had they found him abandoned? It hadn't felt that way when he was little.

A piercing alarm suddenly tore through the air, echoing across campus like a ghost racing and howling. Lu Mingfei froze. The two men's instantly grave expressions clearly signaled trouble.

"Huh? An air raid?" He looked around. "Dragons attacking? Do dragons carry out air raids? Right, they can fly!"

Only after saying it did he realize he had accepted Cassell's premise that dragons existed. He also noticed something strange. The enormous campus was empty. Only the three of them stood beside the lawn. Even if summer vacation wasn't over, that was unreasonable.

"Damn… Forgot what day it is… Find cover! Shit, they're about to start!" Toyama shouted.

"Back to the office!" the professor said grimly.

Too late. People in black combat uniforms, carrying M4-series rifles, appeared on the building's stairs behind them. Maintenance workers rushed out of the office, apparently to stop them. The others raised their weapons and fired. The burly carpenters, built like special-forces soldiers, fell the instant they emerged.

Looks like his insurance for shipping his remains home would come in handy right away.

Before the guns turned toward them, Toyama dragged Lu Mingfei and the professor into a narrow passage. The black-clad intruders ignored them completely and raced past. People in dark-red combat uniforms poured from the church. This utterly silent campus abruptly became a battlefield. Armed figures streamed from every building, grouping by uniform color and spraying one another mercilessly. Many dropped the instant they appeared. The gunfire was deafening. Lu Mingfei almost thought he was on a North African battlefield in World War II.

He couldn't speak. He could only stare at the professor.

"What does the Student Council president think he's doing? What's his name again? Does he want to lose credits?" Guderian covered his ears and roared at Toyama.

"Has he ever cared? His GPA's already low!" Toyama ducked nimbly. A bullet whistled over his head. A real bullet, Lu Mingfei was sure. A fraction slower, and Toyama would have fallen like the maintenance men. A Student Council uprising? Did these students consider armed conflict their vocation?

"Caesar Gattuso!" Toyama straightened angrily. "That spoiled brat with the Bugatti Veyron!"

He drew his aircraft-cannon PPK and changed the magazine, his face set with a commando's resolve before battle.

"I'll remember him! If he takes my class, I'll make him regret it!" Guderian shouted.

As he spoke, his life ended. A bullet struck his body with tremendous force, leaving a smoking hole in his shabby suit. Blood splashed out. He lowered his head and painfully examined the wound, then seized Lu Mingfei and said only, “Your course selection form… Remember to fill it in!”

He collapsed. Toyama tried to rush to help, but a bullet struck his back. As though someone had shoved him, he lurched forward several steps and never rose again.

Surely… this can’t be a joke? Lu Mingfei thought. People had died, unmistakably, right before him.

Back pressed to the wall, he felt countless trajectories crossing outside, murderous bullets whipping past. The campus was a slaughterhouse. He was only a freshman, not even assigned a room yet. He didn’t know which side were dragons and which humans. Trembling, he felt his head was full of paste. If a bullet pierced it now, whatever sprayed out certainly wouldn’t be brains.

“Locate them! Locate them! Forty-three enemies left!”

“Twenty-seven left! One sniper unlocated! Thirteen of ours down! Take that sniper out!”

Both sides roared into radios while firing continuously. Strangely, nobody tried to enter his passage. Only stray shots kept coming. He stood rigid beside Guderian’s and Toyama’s bodies, imagining himself a peaceable wooden post.

Who knew how long the slaughter lasted? Smoke covered the campus. Bodies littered lawns and paths. Both sides had deployed grenades, grenade dischargers, shoulder-fired rockets, and more. He had browsed enough weapons magazines to recognize the expensive hardware. Bullets shattered a row of nearby windows, once again demolishing his hope that this was merely an exercise.

Those weapons were the real thing!

His pulse approached a limit of a hundred eighty beats a minute. Adrenaline flowed like sweat… He could die any second, yet somehow nothing happened… nothing… nothing… Exhausted, he crouched with his chin in his hands and watched. Gradually he grasped the situation. The black and dark-red teams were enemies, each trying to storm the other’s headquarters. Black’s was the small building they had just left; Red’s was the church across the lawn. Fire centered on the parking lot between them. Assault teams had to cross it, but there was insufficient cover. Fully exposed to the barrage, more than forty people had died there.

“If you were Zerg, charging like that would make sense. You spawn fast and have no brains. But as Terran, shouldn’t you siege some tanks and shell the position first? Or send a Ghost to drop a nuke?” he thought wildly.

As though a commander had understood StarCraft master Lu Mingfei’s intentions, a Red fighter appeared, trying to cross the lot with a black briefcase. After nimbly dodging several barrages, he was knocked down by a sniper’s shot from above. The overturned case bore a clear yellow nuclear symbol.

Lu Mingfei’s face twitched. “I was only saying… You actually have one? Not bad, I guess… A nuclear blast this close probably wouldn’t hurt.”

Hopeless. A battlefield for lunatics was beyond a normal person like him.

Gunfire thinned. Smoke cleared a little. A powerful, resonant voice sounded from every direction through the public-address system. “Caesar, how many have you got left? Still going?”

“Not bad, Chu Zihang.” The reply came over the same system, with a cold hint of laughter. “Just me and one girl left. Want me to send the girl charging in?”

“Chu Zihang?” Lu Mingfei paused. The name sounded very familiar.

"I've only got one girl left, too. Unfortunately for you, she's that sniper giving you trouble. As long as she covers the lot, you can't cross. Unfortunately for me, she isn't much good at charging either."

"Surely we won't have a stalemate this year? What a pity."

"It would be. I wanted to win your Bugatti."

"All I have left now is a hunting knife. You?"

"Murasame, of course. My command sword."

"See you in the parking lot."

"Good."

The loudspeakers' electrical hiss abruptly stopped. Both cut communications. The campus was quiet as a dead city, gun smoke hanging like morning mist. In his passage, Lu Mingfei looked around, sensing something bad approaching. After considering, he lay beside Toyama and Guderian. Turning toward the old man's face, he remembered that he had been kind to him, only to be killed for no reason. A little sadness stirred.

"Your own fault, working at such a weird college." He sighed and laid Guderian's arm across his back, making it look as though they had been shot together while the professor tried to shield him.

The church doors and those of the small building opened at once. Heavy combat boots took their first steps almost simultaneously.

The red-clad man carried a military hunting knife about half a meter long, gold patterns branded onto its black blade. The black-clad man held a long Japanese sword reflecting dazzling sunlight. They approached the parking lot, their measured footsteps drawing the tension tighter and tighter.

"What now? Hand-to-hand? You charge in carrying miniature nukes, then fight hand-to-hand?" Lu Mingfei thought.

At one edge of the lot, the red-clad man removed his mask. Brilliant golden hair fell around a face like a Greek sculpture. His rare ice-blue eyes were cold. Tossing his knife in the air, he watched the man opposite, who removed his own mask to reveal unruly black hair jutting in every direction, sharp as blades.

"You've done better than I expected, making it this far," the blond said.

"Praise from Caesar. An honor," the black-haired young man replied coolly.

"But this is as far as you go." The instant he spoke, Caesar shot forward like an arrow. An invisible pressure seemed to rush toward Lu Mingfei with him, making his heart tremble and his breathing stop. Caesar blurred with unbelievable speed, an eagle diving from the heights. His knife and the arm holding it vanished into an even greater speed, rendering the blade nearly invisible!

This was a stroke meant to kill. Hard, ruthless, bearing an emperor's imposing majesty. Even a block of iron before it would have split.

But Chu Zihang wasn't iron. The iron was in his hand. He stood still, sweeping his long sword slowly through an arc and holding it in midair. Caesar's almost certain killing stroke approached. Instantly, Chu's blade vanished, too. A flick of the wrist sent it flashing against Caesar's knife tip with modest force. This was skill beyond strength and speed. A blade was a lever; force at its tip transmitted maximum strain to the wielder's wrist. Chu struck the instant before Caesar exerted his full power—his weakest moment. He intercepted the attack!

Lu Mingfei couldn't follow the details. He saw Caesar reach Chu, who held his stance and shifted only his upper body. Caesar seemed to hit a wall. He stumbled slightly, leaned backward, then retreated several quick steps.

Chu had blocked that imperial pressure. Suddenly, Lu Mingfei could breathe again.

Metal hummed. Chu's long blade vibrated violently. Though it had touched the knife only for an instant, the tremendous impact set its tamahagane steel quivering like a plucked brass reed. Caesar's power was so great that the sword was dissipating it through vibration.

Chu backed away and examined his blade. "Murasame still falls short of Dictator."

A moment's stillness. Then they lunged again.

Dictator was fierce and unyielding in Caesar's hand. Chu's Murasame melted into the air like a phantom, suddenly flashing out in lethal slashes. Whenever Dictator intercepted it, it withdrew instantly and dissolved into a nearly invisible streak. Their desperate duel was graceful as a dance, too swift for Lu Mingfei to follow. A blurred black figure, a blurred dark-red one, Dictator's shadow, Murasame's dazzling reflected sunlight—all mingled beyond separation.

The sword's humming grew fiercer, mingling with Caesar's roars. Murderous intent thickened the air.

"Dictator? Murasame? What is this?" Lu Mingfei muttered.

Dictator meant the ancient Roman office of dictator. Murasame was a sword that shouldn't exist outside Japanese games. Supposedly, after killing a thousand people, the famed Muramasa blade transformed into the demonic Murasame, which shed rain to wash off the blood after killing. But Lu Mingfei had looked it up. An Edo-period writer, Kyokutei Bakin, had invented the sword in Nansō Satomi Hakkenden. And here someone had actually drawn it.

Could this get any more absurd? Caesar, my man, can you pull Frostmourne out from behind your back next? he thought as he lay there.

Faint footsteps came from behind him in the passage. He paused, ears pricking slightly.

They approached slowly. He suddenly realized the person might have a gun. Before he could leap up, raise both hands, and say, I surrender! Innocent passerby! a foot landed on his back. Its owner sprang lightly over him and out of the passage. The foot had hit over his lungs, forcing out a breath and an involuntary "Ow!" Startled, the person drew a Colt from her waist, spun into a crouch, then dropped cross-legged to aim behind her.

Their eyes met. He blinked. Those lovely, spirited eyes were startlingly familiar. So were the dark-red ponytail and swaying four-leaf-clover earrings.

"Come on, little bunny. Have a hug!" A voice sounded in his head. These were the eyes that had watched him then, so beautiful they frightened him.

"Nono, it's me!" He brightened. Apart from the two lunatics still fighting with blades, the last living person here was Nono.

She wore dark-red combat gear. He paused, realizing she was part of this battle: Red's last girl besides Caesar. Caesar's challenge had concealed an ambush. The last fighter would infiltrate Black's headquarters. Nono was his hidden arrow. Lu Mingfei realized he scarcely knew her. They had spent only a few hours together. Yet all the way across the ocean, it was this almost-stranger who had given him peace of mind.

Why trust her? Perhaps because there was no one else to trust.

And now she was pointing a gun at him.

He cautiously raised his hands. “Don’t shoot… I surrender… I’m… just passing through.”

Her gun stayed level. Not even an eyebrow moved.

“Senior… I, I…” he said.

A faint smile appeared at her lips. Suddenly she shouted, “Down!”

Without a moment’s hesitation, she pulled the trigger.

The bullet screamed over his head, missing it by a hair. At her shout, he had clutched his head and dropped flat.

That damned, inexplicable trust. She was pointing a gun at him, and still he obeyed without thinking.

Blood spread across her chest, turning the dark-red uniform black. A large-caliber sniper round had struck her squarely. Its force nearly toppled her backward, but with her last strength she held herself upright.

She looked down at the wound and nodded to him, her voice hoarse. “Obedient enough. Still too slow…”

He turned. A girl in black lay flat on the ground with a sniper rifle, smoke curling from its dark muzzle. He recognized an American Barrett M82A1, the “King of Snipers,” in .50 caliber. At this range, anyone hit was beyond saving. The bullet would turn their organs to bloody pulp.

She was Black’s last fighter, the star sniper. She had jumped from a side window into the passage. Nono could have shot her, but Lu Mingfei blocked her line of fire. They had faced off like cowboys, and Nono had fired a fraction of a second too late. Lu Mingfei… had been too slow.

He couldn’t believe his eyes, but the blood pouring down her chest said it was real. Her gaze unfocused. Signs of death appeared.

He seized his head. Pain tore through it as though something deep inside were drilling its way out. Darkness swallowed his vision. Brilliant golden eyes opened against it, and a bell-like voice asked, “Will you trade?”

Trade? Trade what?

A dim impulse urged him to agree. Somehow, agreeing would make things different. The instant he accepted, something would change.

The sniper sprang up, abandoned her rifle, and drew a combat knife from her lower back. Before Lu Mingfei could react, she stepped on his back and landed lightly beside Nono. Grabbing her hair, she drove the knife into her throat. Thick, reeking blood splashed over Nono’s face. A few drops struck his.

“We won! Caesar! You lost!” The girl raised her bloody blade.

They had indeed won. Neither Caesar nor Chu could break free of their duel. She could stroll into Red’s headquarters humming a tune and win this murderous game. If it were a game of Go, they had reached the endgame. The outcome could no longer change.

But a red stone appeared at the point of their ko fight.

A deafening gunshot drowned out her cry. A bullet from behind drove her forward with tremendous momentum. Disbelieving, she struggled to turn. Lu Mingfei was silently rising, holding Toyama's abandoned PPK, the pistol modified into an aircraft cannon.

That red stone caught fire.

Caesar and Chu broke apart together and looked toward the smoke-filled passage. An unsteady figure emerged, carrying the heavy King of Snipers. The rifle was nearly a meter and a half long and looked absurdly awkward in his hand. He wasn't carrying it like anyone with training.

Caesar frowned. "Who are you? Nonparticipants, out!"

A large-caliber bullet struck him head-on. He staggered back two steps and fell on his back.

A casing spun from the sniper rifle and hit the ground. Lu Mingfei blew across its chamber, his face vacant, expressionless.

Chu slowly turned, golden pupils reflecting Murasame's gleam. He dropped the sword and raised both hands. "Who are you?"

Chu Zihang. It really was his high school's legend, the Chu Zihang someone like Lu Mingfei could only watch from afar.

When Lu Mingfei was a freshman, Chu had been Student Council president, inspecting each class and awarding scores during morning exercises. Even in light rain, they had to keep going. Above them, dressed in spotless white, Chu would pass slowly along the top-floor corridor, looking down. Their movements were perfectly synchronized, like toy soldiers'.

But his eyes hadn't been this dazzling gold then.

"Lu… Mingfei?" Miraculously, Chu spoke his name.

Once, that would have moved him beyond words. The legendary senior remembered his name, perhaps had even noticed him. He wasn't one of Chu's lovestruck fangirls, but it was an honor all the same.

Now he said nothing, only watched Chu coldly.

"The game's over. I can concede!" Chu felt murderous intent cutting toward him against the wind and decided to surrender.

The black muzzle rose again. Lu Mingfei's bones moved with mechanical precision. He worked the action. A round slid into place. His finger tightened on the trigger. The gun's mechanisms seemed to merge with his skeleton. Muzzle aligned, his bones locked into their proper positions one by one. Chu's figure appeared in the sights.

"Dis…" Lu Mingfei uttered the syllable coldly.

The thunderous gunshot swallowed the next.

He pulled the trigger. The bullet screamed from the barrel and pierced Chu's chest. An enormous blossom of blood burst outward.

The campus fell silent. Sunlight shone on the gun smoke, turning it a lovely gold. Lu Mingfei seemed to stand in morning mist. After a long time, he propped the rifle against a wall, sat slowly on the steps, and rested his forehead on his clasped hands.

A vigorous march rang across campus. The long-silent PA system seemed to have woken from a nap.

He started, as if waking from a dream. Looking at the bodies, he raised his hands, but didn't know whom to surrender to.

An unfamiliar building's doors opened, and doctors and nurses poured out with cases bearing the college emblem. Dazed, he watched doctors inject the corpses, afraid to speak. A small old man with a shining bald head and thin, round gold-rimmed glasses approached, holding a handkerchief over his nose and mouth, frowning and sighing. The bullet-pocked walls made his sighs more heartfelt. Apparently, he cared less about the death toll than the property damage.

He looked Lu Mingfei up and down. "A freshman, judging by your clothes?"

Lu Mingfei nodded.

"Professor Manstein! Disciplinary Committee!" The little old man looked contemptuous. "Sit somewhere out of the way! Students these days! Instead of putting studies first when you arrive, you join these pointless games! Is it fun? Is it?" Growing angry again, he pointed at the cratered granite walls. "Money! All of that is money!"

Lu Mingfei shifted to one side. Someone patted his shoulder from behind. "Don't mind him. Manstein's a good friend. A little too fond of money, that's all. I'll ask him to look after your coursework."

He nodded quickly. "Yes, yes… But what exactly…"

He turned and froze. It was Professor Guderian, whose chest had been blown open. The old man still bore a huge bloodstain, but looked wonderfully spirited.

"A ghost!" was his first reaction.

"Alive! I'm alive!" The professor waved hastily. "Feel me. I'm warm!"

"So… you've successfully returned to life?" Lu Mingfei trembled.

"I wasn't dead. Don't let the students' little game frighten you. It's just live-action Counter-Strike. Today is Freedom Day. Students can do what they like without punishment under college rules." He sat beside Lu Mingfei.

"But you're covered in blood!"

"Oh, a tiny piece of alchemical equipment. Frigga rounds. They use them as toys." He took a cartridge from his pocket. Its bullet was an eerie deep red.

"In Norse mythology, Frigga is Odin's wife. To protect her son Baldr, god of light, she made everything in the world swear not to harm him. Everything swore, so even spears thrown at him would veer away. When these alchemical bullets hit, they instantly fragment and vaporize. No injury, just a bloodlike stain. They contain a trace anesthetic that immediately knocks you out. Originally tranquilizer rounds, now a Freedom Day tradition. Watch." He jabbed the bullet hard against the back of his hand. The solid projectile burst into blood-red dust, like the spray from a gunshot wound.

"That… that advanced?" Lu Mingfei marveled.

The professor's face twitched, and he toppled at Lu Mingfei's feet.

"Did… returning to life fail?" Lu Mingfei's face twitched, too.

"Idiot. The anesthetic took effect. Same as getting shot again." Manstein frowned. "Nurse! Another injection for him!"

The corpse-strewn battlefield now bustled like a sports meet. Medics injected the fallen one by one, then massaged shoulders and backs of the "dead" who had twisted joints while fainting, recording student numbers as they went. Once unmasked, the corpses were all eighteen- or nineteen-year-olds. The first thing they did on waking was whisper about who had won. Nobody quite knew. Both leaders lay in the parking lot, Caesar's head on Chu's arm and Chu's on Caesar's thigh, unusually intimate, huge bloodstains on their chests. Murasame and Dictator lay nearby.

Apparently someone had shot the two rivals while they dueled.

"Who did it?" someone yelled.

Lu Mingfei sat stiff-faced on the steps, wearing an expression that said INNOCENT PASSERBY.

"Quiet! More trouble? You've gone too far this year!" Manstein shouted. "You violated Freedom Day's special rules. I'll report this to the principal and have it canceled!"

"The three special rules: no alchemical equipment from the Ice Cellar, no casualties, no outside visitors. Correct?" someone asked.

"They only hurt themselves falling over. Everyone falls, don't they?" another said.

The speakers were Caesar and Chu. Newly awake, the sworn enemies were calm as captains returning from a soccer match. Each leaned against one side of the passage, arms folded almost identically. Caesar was languid; Chu expressionless.

"Fine! Caesar! Chu Zihang! You've got nerve! Wait until I tell the principal!" Manstein's hands shook with anger as he took out his phone and dialed. Everyone quieted. The principal evidently held an exceptional place in their minds. Every eye fixed on the phone.

Looking like a man wielding supreme authority, Manstein stabbed the speakerphone button.

"Hello, Manstein." The low, cultured voice sounded like that of a perfect European gentleman, yet the Chinese was impeccable.

"Principal Anjou, forgive the interruption. An exceptional situation. Students are suspected of violating this year's Freedom Day rules. Lionheart and Student Council members used Frigga rounds and turned the entire campus into a battlefield. Many injuries… substantial property damage. Extremely serious!" Manstein spoke with righteous severity. "And our proud students, especially Lionheart president Chu Zihang and Student Council president Caesar Gattuso, show no respect whatsoever for the Disciplinary Committee."

"Oh, Caesar's always been like that. You should be used to it by now, Manstein," the principal said mildly.

Manstein hesitated. "There's also the enormous expense… Preliminary repair estimates are around two hundred forty thousand dollars… Not including replacing the lawn. They've trampled your favorite Bermuda grass into a field ready for plowing!"

"Caesar, as our wealthiest student, you wouldn't mind paying to replace my beloved Bermuda grass?" the principal asked.

"As you please." Caesar shrugged. His Chinese was fluent enough for idiomatic phrases.

"Never mind. I'm joking. Take it from the board's fund. After all, the students won their annual anniversary celebration, Freedom Day, from us through their own efforts. We old fellows won't go back on our word." He laughed warmly. "Enjoy your holiday, then apply yourselves to your studies, my dear students. I wish I could spend this happy Freedom Day with you."

They exchanged glances and applauded together. Cheering, they untied their armbands and tossed them up, draped arms across one another's shoulders, swayed, and pulled teasing faces at Manstein.

Lu Mingfei applauded, too, beaming and nodding around to say, Hey, I'm one of you. I'm happy you're making fun of the bald old guy, too. As a newcomer, he rapidly grasped his position. To survive here, he couldn't be seen as the class officer who reported everyone to teachers. Public enemy of the students was a death sentence.

"There's someone else I'd like to greet," the principal said loudly.

Everyone paused. Silence returned.

"Is our S-rank freshman Lu Mingfei there? Chosen your courses? Did you choose my Introduction to Dragon Genealogy?" His voice echoed around them.

Astonishment filled their eyes. Whispers broke out everywhere.

"I did… I think… I chose it," Lu Mingfei said timidly. He had to answer. Guderian had taken the phone from Manstein and placed it before him.

"Delighted to hear your voice. Taking down Caesar and Chu on your first day! I look forward to meeting you in class. Do even better than your S-rank predecessor!" The principal hung up.

Lu Mingfei scratched his head. Better how? How could he surpass a senior who had shot himself over philosophy? Kill himself with an aircraft cannon? Suddenly, the temperature seemed to drop. Looking around, he found every eye fixed on him, cold with hostility.

Sunlight slanted through a porthole. The man in shadow ended the call, leaned back, and exhaled silently. Beyond the window lay a river. Their boat was passing between two mountains.

"Caesar and Chu causing trouble again?" the middle-aged man opposite asked. "Freedom Day repairs cost more every year. Perhaps we should limit it. Geniuses may enjoy unrestrained lives, but they're supposed to be disciplined soldiers."

"I deliberately give them room. Ten years ago, Cassell was a mysterious military fortress. But Mans, remember our defeat ten years ago?"

He nodded and sipped his black tea. "No one could forget."

"A well-trained army, annihilated. I had to rethink our educational approach. Perhaps in the war against dragons we need geniuses, not armies." The principal switched to English. "Somebody."

"Somebody?"

"The One! A unique genius. A leader. A dragon slayer even Dragon Kings fear. One would be enough. Like my friend Meinhard Cassell." He spoke quietly. "Genius needs freedom to grow."

"Perhaps. Caesar and Chu are unprecedented talents. But Lu Mingfei… You rated him S." The middle-aged man frowned. "I deliberately delayed the CC1000 to extend his observation period. But…"

"He's too ordinary?" The principal smiled.

"I see nothing exceptional."

"Don't be too surprised, but I don't know him well enough either. I don't know what he can do. His S-rank has a reason, though I can't tell you yet," the principal said. "He may be the genius we await. Or utterly useless."

"Put someone useless between the tremendous forces of Caesar and Chu, and he'll be crushed."

The principal scratched his graying hair. “Too early to call him useless.” He rose and looked outside. It was flood season. Little white flowers bloomed in the dark-green turf on the river islands along both shores.

“We’re passing above Kuimen. Before the Three Gorges Reservoir, the mountains on either side stood like gateposts,” he said softly. “The ancient Chinese spoke of the kui dragon, an ancient one-legged creature. Does Kuimen mean they once saw a dragon swimming here? When does Operation Kuimen begin?”

“In a week. Ye Sheng and Aki are ready. They’re my finest people. With the modified Moniach, I’m confident.”

“If our suspicions are right, don’t wake it. The King of Bronze and Fire, a noble first-generation dragon. No one can guess his power,” the principal said. “Come back safely.”

Late at night, Lu Mingfei sat cross-legged on his bunk, staring out the window.

He had been assigned Room 303 in Dormitory Area One, sharing with Fingel. When he had entered, head hanging, Fingel had been snoring on the upper bunk, utterly unaffected by the gunfire.

“You all right?” Fingel poked his head down.

“You don’t know what happened today.” Lu Mingfei sighed.

“I do. Your heroic exploits are sung across campus. You’re on the college news site. Quite a headline.” Fingel lowered his laptop for him to see.

“Who Claims the Freedom Day Crown? Who Blew Away Caesar, Then Chu Zihang?”

Below was a huge photograph of Lu Mingfei, with his student number, room, age, hometown, and every other detail. The final item kindly specified: SINGLE!

“Looks like a lonely-hearts ad…” he said.

“A wanted poster!” Fingel said. “You still don’t understand what you’ve done.”

“I didn’t do anything. I got a little worked up. Bullets everywhere. Wouldn’t you defend yourself?”

“Self-defense is fine. Blowing away Caesar and Chu with two shots when they only had blades—is that self-defense? And understand this: you won Freedom Day. You’d completed enrollment, so you were a student and eligible. You entered as a third side and were the last survivor. You won!”

“Prize money?”

“Far better. First, a year’s use of Norton Hall! Second, automatic qualification for next year’s Campus Star finals! And finally…” Fingel sounded awed. “The first girl you pursue here can’t turn you down and has to stay with you at least three months!”

“I have a very bad feeling…” Lu Mingfei grew wary.

“Understand why every guy here hates you now? Move the mouse over your picture.”

A blood-red cross appeared, plainly labeled: LOOK CLOSELY! THIS IS THE SON OF A BITCH! WHO’S GOING TO KILL HIM?

He turned completely to stone.

Bang, bang. A knock made him jump like a rabbit.

“Easy, easy. Nobody’s breaking in for revenge. They’ll show me some respect.” Fingel jumped down to open it.

Professor Guderian entered, delighted. His first act was a hearty shoulder-thumping. “Hey, my boy! I’m proud of you! Your name’s everywhere on campus in a single day!”

“Blow up the Pentagon and your name’ll be everywhere in America in a day, too…”

“What brings you here so late?” Fingel asked.

The professor handed Lu Mingfei an envelope. “Your student ID. This card gives you S-rank privileges throughout campus. Also, tomorrow’s the 3E exam. Are you ready?”

“The 3E exam?” Lu Mingfei stared. “What 3E exam?”

“A little test. Others might find it troublesome. For an S-rank like you, easy.”

“On what? Standardized? Just multiple choice and true or false?”

“Only Draconic. The dragons’ spoken and written language,” the professor said casually.

Lu Mingfei nearly lost his breath. “You said languages could be waived! What Draconic? Dragons write? How could anything like that exist?”

“Draconic isn’t foreign. It’s one of your native languages. You have dragon blood,” the professor said. “No need to study. It’s memory inherited through your bloodline. You’re S-rank. Your dragon blood is amazingly pure. You’ll understand naturally when you see it.”

He set both hands on Lu Mingfei’s shoulders and looked into his eyes. “Mingfei. Concentrate. Listen to every sound!”

Unfamiliar retroflex sounds burst from his mouth. An unimaginable way of speaking: thick and hoarse, yet carrying a sovereign’s authority, like church bells.

Lu Mingfei froze, staring at the ceiling, sadness appearing on his face.

“Praise our king’s awakening. Destruction is rebirth,” the professor translated. “Mingfei, did you hear the ancient Dragon Emperor’s voice? I can tell by your face. You understood!”

He turned to Fingel. “See? S-rank ability. Even when you were A-rank, you weren’t this sensitive to Draconic.”

Fingel waved a hand before Lu Mingfei’s vacant eyes. “Whoa. Looks like a mental shock. Spirit vision? Draconic characters appearing in your mind?”

“Understood, my ass. You’ve made a mistake… I really tried, but I still don’t understand!” Lu Mingfei looked miserable. “Are you sure you recruited the right person? There’s more than one Lu Mingfei in China.”

“You… didn’t understand?” The professor stared. “Then why do you look so sad?”

“Of course I’m sad. If I can’t understand it, I can’t pass.”

“Impossible… No visions at all? No feeling of… a great sovereign calling you?” The professor was badly shaken.

“I thought you were singing…” Lu Mingfei said cautiously.

After a brief fit of agitation, Guderian abruptly regained scholarly composure. Grasping his shoulders, he declared, “The first case! The very first! Interesting! Fascinating!”

“First case of what?” Fingel asked.

“The first dragon-blood descendant not to respond to the Dragon Emperor’s call!” He studied Lu Mingfei like a precious specimen. “You’ve mutated!”

"You've gone nuts," Lu Mingfei said.

"Listen. Awe of Draconic is inherited through dragon blood. Every hybrid responds to Yanling: Emperor. But you've undergone a genetic mutation and become insensitive. You're unique!" The old man was excited. "Is this why you're rated S?"

"Wait! Another possibility: I'm an ordinary human. Right?" Lu Mingfei said. "Doesn't that explanation make far more sense?"

"Impossible! The principal never misjudges bloodlines." Guderian rubbed his hands. "You must be extraordinary!" Then his face fell. "But what about tomorrow's exam? Who besides me will believe it's a mutation rather than a weak bloodline?"

"I will!" Fingel raised his hand. "You can tell he's mutated just by his face!"

"A problem. This could affect my tenure review." Guderian scratched his head.

"Tenure review? What's that got to do with it?"

"Well, I don't have tenure here yet." The old man looked embarrassed. "I've been here over ten years and I'm still an assistant professor. The principal did me a favor, assigning you to me. An unprecedented S-rank, he said, with unmatched potential. Training you into an excellent student would be as easy as the New York Yankees winning next year's Major League Baseball championship. Then I could get tenure."

"What is all this? Didn't you say you used to be a Harvard professor?"

"Yes. But to go from Harvard tenure to Cassell tenure, you must successfully train a student."

Lu Mingfei's vision darkened. "So… I'm an S-rank student with an assistant professor who has no teaching experience as my adviser?"

"Not quite. I did have one student after coming here. His name is Fingel…" He patted the man beside him, whose face said NOTHING TO DO WITH ME.

"Oh… So that's why I'm sharing a room with this extraordinary specimen?" Lu Mingfei understood.

"I understand your despair. But face reality." Fingel sighed. "You're in a useless professor's group, with a useless senior who hasn't graduated in eight years. Every male student wants your head. And I have the saddest news of all."

"What?" Lu Mingfei thrust out his chest. "Come on! It can't get worse. I refuse to believe it!"

"That Nono, or Chen Motong, you talked about the whole way…" Fingel leaned close to his ear. "She's Caesar's girlfriend!"

"Now I believe it…" Lu Mingfei said. Something deep in his heart gave a faint twitch, then suddenly felt empty.

Act Three

The Dictator

The metal doors opened and closed. The man was truly gone. In the unreal beam of light, the girl began to cry without a sound.

The little rods and spheres rolled together. Adams took shape again, chattering “Hee-ha, hee-ha, hee-ha!” It rolled over to EVA on several metal balls, waited a moment, then suddenly waved both hands above its head and shook its body in an ungainly dance. “EVA, be happy! EVA, be happy! EVA, be happy!”

Coins clattered from its hands across the floor. The girl’s tears fell onto the metal as well, splashing into faint, illusory glimmers of blue.

Late at night. Norton Hall. The conference room.

Every member of the Student Council’s executive committee was present. Caesar, the current president, sat on the sofa before the fireplace, chin propped on both hands, staring ahead. Above him hung the Gattuso family’s phoenix crest. The silence had lasted a long time. Almost everyone had their head bowed.

“For the first time in three years, we’re losing the use of Norton Hall. This will be our last meeting here,” Caesar said quietly. “For me, this is unprecedented. A crushing defeat.”

Dejection weighed on them like a mountain. Since Caesar took charge, the Student Council had always won Freedom Day. Under him, it had finally become a match for Cassell’s most traditional fraternity, the Lionheart Society. Even the appearance of Chu Zihang, the so-called super-A-rank, hadn’t cost them Norton Hall. Now, inconceivably, a freshman had beaten them.

“We didn’t lose. This was a disgraceful war of sneak attacks!” a senior committee member protested. “We shouldn’t give up Norton Hall!”

Indignation spread. The members whispered among themselves. The defeat was simply too unfair.

“Stop!” Caesar raised a hand. The authority in his voice silenced the room.

“I refuse to speak with cowards. Only cowards refuse to acknowledge defeat.” His ice-blue eyes showed no emotion. “I don’t intend to discuss why we lost. Lu Mingfei, an S-rank freshman from China, shot Chu Zihang and me and won this year’s Freedom Day as a third participant. Respect the rules. Under the rules, we lost. Lionheart has remained silent, which means Chu accepts the result. Are you inferior to Chu Zihang?”

“I’ve rented Amber Hall next door for next year’s Student Council activities. Move our belongings out. From midnight, this place belongs to Lu Mingfei.” Caesar rose and poured himself a cognac. “He should be preparing for tomorrow’s 3E exam. Do you think he’ll pass?”

“Caesar, you mean…?”

“A story just broke on the campus news site. Our S-rank freshman has no resonance with Yanling: Emperor,” Caesar said softly.

After a moment of silence, delighted surprise flashed in every member’s eyes.

"The exam results will show his potential. If he fails, he'll be demoted. With no Yanling resonance, how can he pass?" Caesar looked around the room. "I'm looking forward to it. I imagine Chu is, too. Nono, what do you think of him?"

"That loser? Probably straight down to Z, if there is a Z-rank." Leaning against the wall, Nono sounded unconcerned.

The committee members exchanged smiles. The 3E exam was the first hurdle, one that unsettled every freshman. Lu Mingfei wouldn't find it so easy to keep smiling. If he failed, he would plummet through the ranks—B, C, D, E, F—and become the college's laughingstock. A sheep slipping into a pride of lions in a lion's skin, then being exposed: its fate scarcely bore imagining.

Caesar didn't smile. He lowered his head and touched his chest where Lu Mingfei's bullet had struck.

"The initials are EEE: Extraction Evaluation Exam. It means a bloodline assessment. Its main purpose is to identify students' dragon blood. Those with dragon ancestry resonate with Draconic, producing spirit vision—Draconic characters naturally appear in their minds," Fingel explained. "That ability is crucial. Dragon descendants possess a supernatural power called Yanling. Within their domain, words spoken in Draconic become a rule. Language is the tool dragons use to exercise their powers. Students insensitive to Draconic usually lack ability. After 3E, they're demoted. The worst are ordered to withdraw."

"I was practically kidnapped and sold here! Now they'll order me to leave?" Lu Mingfei said.

"They'll wipe your memory and throw you out. You signed the confidentiality agreement. And if you go home now, you'll probably have to repeat your exam year, right?"

"That's an unfair contract! He wrote it in Latin. Who the hell could read it?"

Professor Guderian wasn't there to hear the complaint. Stumped by Lu Mingfei's inability to resonate with Draconic, the old man had declared it an academic problem and gone to the library to research it.

The room fell quiet. The window stood open. Sitting on his bunk, Lu Mingfei watched a beautiful full moon. Its light shone on the church spire's red tiles, and a pleasant night breeze brushed over him. What a lovely place. Tomorrow, he would be thrown out.

"Memory wipes are actually fun." Fingel's head dangled from the upper bunk like a hanged ghost's.

"Never had one. Soon I'll get to try. So happy." Lu Mingfei was magnificently calm.

He guessed Fingel was trying to frighten him. The best counterattack was a poker face. Just as when Lu Mingze would gleefully announce over dinner, I saw Chen Wenwen browsing a bookstore with a handsome guy from Class Two. She looked so happy! Lu Mingfei would put on a blank expression and say, What? Were you talking to me, my good man? Unable to breach his thick skin, Lu Mingze could only gather the dishes and retreat in defeat.

"Didn't some Chinese philosopher say people suffer because their memories are too good?"

"No philosopher. Ouyang Feng said it in Ashes of Time… Wipe away, wipe away. I'm definitely failing tomorrow. Wipe me clean and send me home to repeat the year. If I can't get into college, I'll be unemployed…" For no clear reason, he sighed.

"You just sighed," Fingel said.

"I yawned."

"You don't want to go back to China," Fingel said suddenly.

Lu Mingfei paused, not understanding.

"Nothing wrong with going back. I don't care. Caring wouldn't help anyway." Hands behind his head, he leaned back and stretched.

Gripping the upper mattress, Fingel performed an extremely difficult pike maneuver and slowly lowered himself onto Lu Mingfei's bunk. "Good to keep things in perspective. Cassell isn't so wonderful. They call it college, but you spend your days with reptiles, then graduate and travel the world killing dragons, risking a roasting in dragonfire. You don't look like the hot-blooded type who shouts, 'My destiny is to roam the earth slaying mighty dragons!' Right?"

"That's exactly what I'm saying. I see nothing wrong with failing and going back." Lu Mingfei looked into Fingel's silver-gray, Aryan eyes and shrugged. "I don't care."

"But you just sighed," Fingel repeated.

A scorching rush surged from Lu Mingfei's chest, like the urge to vomit after eating something too hot. It burned and hurt, making him forget pride and pretense. He just wanted to open his mouth.

"What's with the nagging? What do you want? What the hell do you care if I go back? You're a loser yourself. All these years and you haven't graduated! Think you're impressive? You still owe me money. How many Cokes have you drunk? Pay me back or shut up!" He didn't know why he had suddenly exploded.

He regretted it as soon as the words escaped. Fingel might be his only friend here. As for Nono, he had shot her boyfriend. She was probably with that handsome blond now.

"Brother, you're losing your cool." Fingel patted his shoulder.

Lu Mingfei looked at him, then lowered his head.

"You keep saying, 'I want to withdraw, I want to withdraw,'" Fingel said. "I only wanted to understand your state of mind."

Lu Mingfei sighed. "Sometimes I really do. But where would I go? And why haven't you thought about quitting? What's so great here? Eight years and no degree."

"Would it kill you not to poke a sore spot?"

"Fine, no poking. Just talk me through your inner journey."

"Because… I'm lonely." Fingel shrugged.

"Lonely? You? Come on! With all your wisecracks, you're one step from hosting a talk show." Lu Mingfei rolled his eyes.

"I'm serious. People with dragon blood aren't entirely human. It gives you Yanling, but also alienates you from humanity. Once you gain that power, you're always reminded you aren't ordinary. Only among your own kind does the loneliness disappear, so dragon descendants naturally gather together. It's genetic. We call that loneliness blood sorrow." Fingel paused. "Wait. You're S-rank. Have you never felt especially… lonely?"

"Lonely?" Lu Mingfei considered his eighteen years and shook his head. "No."

Fingel scratched his head. "At Chicago station, you were always staring into space. What were you thinking about? Your parents aren't around, you have no strengths, no luck with girls, bad grades, not

even a real buddy. It would be a cosmic injustice if you weren't lonely," he said. "Even I was. As a kid, I mean."

"But what does feeling lonely do? Is loneliness some great achievement? Dwelling on it only makes you feel worse." Lu Mingfei looked at the ceiling. "Nobody talks to you, so you're lonely. But being lonely still won't make anybody talk to you."

Fingel nodded with great seriousness. "Being lonely… still won't make anybody talk to you… That actually makes sense… Brother, you're a philosopher."

"You're the philosopher. A stinging jellyfish, more like," Lu Mingfei said. "Just find ways to kill time, and you won't feel lonely. Spacing out alone is interesting enough. I'd sit on our roof thinking about this and that, and whoosh, the whole evening was gone."

"Sounds like you were happy enough in China. Why not go back? Even blood sorrow doesn't affect you."

Lu Mingfei thought, sighed, rested his elbows on his knees, lowered his head, and clutched his hair.

"But at home," he whispered, "I have nothing. If there were nothing at home, would you go back?" He looked at Fingel.

Fingel looked back. Something flickered in his silver-gray eyes: the sympathy of one vulnerable creature for another, or some secretion of loneliness? Lu Mingfei couldn't tell.

"Even wild lilies get a spring. Even a little bastard wants to sprout." He shrugged. "I may be useless, but I want people to notice me. I want girls to like me. I want something to brag about… I don't want to spend my whole life as an extra." His stomach growled twice.

Fingel blinked. "Hungry? Let's order a late supper. Lend me your student ID."

"They do late-night food?" Lu Mingfei brightened a little and handed over the card. "You don't mean takeout tea eggs?"

"Tea eggs? It's our first night as roommates. We need a feast!" Fingel read out the ID number. "Room 303, Area One. Two orders of truffle bread, two pan-seared foie gras with lemon juice, a bottle of champagne… Yes, an ice bucket and lemon peel. A roast goose, too. We're a little hungry. Two herring rolls with cheese."

Lu Mingfei wiped the corner of his mouth. His stomach celebrated with a chorus of rumbles.

Twenty minutes later, white-clad waiters wheeled in a trolley and lifted solid-silver covers, revealing Fingel's feast on silver platters. They assembled a table in the dorm, spread a snowy cloth, laid silver knives and forks, and set the champagne bucket in the center. Two chilled glasses beaded with condensation went before the boys. Finally, they lit a candle and withdrew. Throughout, they only smiled, never making a sound.

"Wow! It really is a school for aristocrats! I was ready to quit tomorrow, but this meal's making me reconsider." Lu Mingfei drove his fork into the goose's breast and happily watched the fat well out.

"Eat! A man's iron, but food's steel. Miss one meal and hunger's real! Think about 3E on a full stomach. There's always a road around the mountain. Away from home, you rely on brothers. You've got me!" Fingel seized the truffle bread and chewed. "Dig in!"

"You're really fluent in those stock phrases!" Feeling better, Lu Mingfei tore off a goose leg and began chewing, grandly offering Fingel the other.

"Reading and replying on forums is the best Chinese practice!" Fingel accepted it. Across the candlelight, both grinned brilliantly.

Meanwhile, their teacher, Professor Guderian, was examining documents in the library. In the rare-books section, Burmese-hardwood shelves rose to the ceiling, their color and sheen metallic under the lights. Endless rows of huge bound volumes held transparent vacuum-sealed sleeves preserving ancient copper scrolls, collectively called the Ice Sea Fragments. Buried beneath icy seas for thousands of years, they still hadn't been fully deciphered.

Atop a ladder, Guderian stretched his arm toward a volume.

"Researching in the middle of the night?" someone asked below.

He looked down at a round object as shiny as the overhead lights.

"Manstein? What brings you here so late?" He was surprised.

The Disciplinary Committee chairman rubbed his gleaming head. "Research, too. On your new student, Lu Mingfei."

"Oh? Really? He's certainly worth studying." Guderian paused, answering vaguely.

"A freshman facing Chu Zihang's golden dragon eyes, firing without a trace of fear. Chu has the purest dragon blood we've found and already exhibits a dragon's physiological trait: dragon eyes. Most people feel awe beneath his direct gaze. Your student felt nothing. Interesting." Manstein's voice was cold.

"He's S-rank. Anything can happen with an S-rank," Guderian said hastily.

"You're pleased with your new student. Intend to make him Cassell's finest young man?" Manstein asked.

"Yes, yes." Guderian smiled and scratched his head. "Then I'll get tenure, too."

"From our days sharing a room at Harvard until now, you've always scratched your head when you lie. Can't you control it a little?" Manstein sighed.

Guderian's expression changed. After a silence, he dutifully climbed down. "What do you know?"

"He doesn't resonate with Yanling: Emperor. Correct?" Manstein looked directly into his eyes, his blue-gray Aryan gaze cold as metal.

"How did you know?" Guderian whispered.

"It's tonight's headline on the campus site. Posted by your student Fingel. 'Breaking: S-Rank Lu Mingfei Has No Resonance with the Dragon Emperor's Secret Incantation. College Investigates!' Everyone knows now."

"Fingel?" Guderian stared.

"Your specialty is dragon genealogy. Scatterbrained though you are, you've always been better than me at your subject. You wouldn't jump to a conclusion like bloodline mutation. You know dragon blood is immensely powerful. Dozens of generations of interbreeding won't erase it completely, and there hasn't been a single mutation. Yet you told your students Lu Mingfei had mutated. From that moment, you were trying to cover it up. Correct?"

Guderian nodded. "I recited Yanling: Emperor: 'Praise our king's awakening. Destruction is rebirth.' No resonance whatsoever. The only known dragon descendant unresponsive to Emperor. But

he does have dragon blood. Otherwise, he could scarcely have resisted Chu's golden eyes. That judgment isn't based solely on the principal's S rating."

"Nidhogg is the sole ancestor of the dragons. Emperor is the supreme Yanling by which he rules his descendants. Any of his blood, on hearing it, feels his summons. Yet Lu Mingfei said you were singing. This is no small matter."

Guderian was silent.

"Ice Sea Fragment AD0099. I've found what you need." Manstein handed him a copper scroll sealed in a cylindrical glass vessel.

"An AD fragment?" Guderian was startled. "Top secret!"

"Only the oldest documents conceal the highest secrets," Manstein said. "Emperor works on every bloodline that submits to the Dragon Emperor. But one bloodline does not submit."

"The White King, mentioned in the secret chapter of the Dragon Chronicles," Guderian whispered. "Our old joint research subject."

"Yes. We happen to be the two people here who know its history best. The White King's Yanling: Oracle is the only known Yanling that counters Emperor. After betraying the Black King, it used Oracle on all its own descendants."

"You mean Lu Mingfei is… descended from the White King?"

Manstein nodded slightly. "I can think of no other explanation."

After a long silence, Guderian said, "That bloodline is only a legend. The Ice Sea Copper Pillar Inscription says the Black King Nidhogg destroyed the White King with supreme power: killed it, ate its flesh, turned its bones to ice, melted the ice and poured it into a volcano, annihilating body and soul. If it no longer exists, its Yanling has lost its power."

"The White King's rebellion was the greatest in dragon history. A third of the dragons rebelled. After suppressing them, the Black King recorded their fate on a heaven-high copper pillar—the inscription we found in Greenland," Manstein said. "That makes it history written by Nidhogg's faction. If dragons have political considerations, the Black King would certainly stress to his subjects that the rebel leader had been utterly destroyed. But could the soul of a first-generation dragon, the purest of dragon blood, really be erased so easily? Perhaps it still sleeps somewhere, like the other dragon princes."

"We've never found a single descendant of the White King. Its branch was close to humans. If Lu Mingfei belongs to it, that needn't be bad," Guderian said.

Manstein lit his pipe, drew deeply several times, and smiled bitterly. "Don't fool yourself. Neither of us believes it would help humanity. The first of the Three Principles of Dragons: dragons and humans are fundamentally different beings. The gulf between us is far greater than the hatred between the Black and White Kings. The inscription says it 'stained its silver throne with the blood of the lowborn,' suggesting its savagery. Perhaps it merely used humans to compensate for its deficiencies. The Black King created it, and it was weaker. But it remained alien. It could never truly sympathize with humanity."

Guderian paled and fell silent. The antique wall clock ticked.

"We aren't entirely human ourselves," he said at last. "Does Black King blood or White King blood matter so much? Must we force bloodline theory on a child?"

Manstein puffed hard. “Have you considered the consequences of protecting him? If the White King was the ‘Savage King’ its creator described, who knows how its descendants would treat humans? Once his blood awakens, Lu Mingfei could become our enemy. Chu’s golden eyes can’t suppress him. His potential may be unmatched. Who would dare let him live here?”

“What are you saying?” Guderian raised his head sharply and demanded.

“Write a report. Submit it to the principal,” Manstein said quietly.

A chill entered Guderian’s heart. “What would such a report mean?”

“Isolate and study him. Until his identity is established, he can’t remain a student or leave the college. Don’t hesitate. Call now. Don’t implicate yourself.” Manstein took out his phone and offered it.

After a long silence, Guderian gripped his hand and slowly, firmly closed the phone.

“Lu Mingfei…” He paused, finally saying the words he had already settled on. “…is a very good boy.”

Manstein stared, baffled. Academically, he was Guderian’s inferior. He had copied his homework from their undergraduate days right through their doctorates. A casual remark from his friend might conceal profound meaning. He mustn’t expose his ignorance now. He needed to consider before replying.

He lowered his head in thought. The clock ticked. Seconds and minutes passed.

“You mean… the goodness of his human side will resist the White King’s summons?” he ventured. “All right. I give up. Tell me.”

Guderian scratched his head. “I… didn’t mean anything special. I just remember Nono saying he cried his eyes out in the ladies’ room after getting a letter from his parents.”

“Does that have anything to do with the White King’s bloodline?”

“No. I think he’s a lonely child, and kind. A good boy. We can’t deprive him of his chance. Who wants to be a specimen?” Guderian looked into his friend’s eyes. “We remember our childhoods, don’t we? We were specimens, too. Reaching through iron bars, trying so hard to hold each other’s hand… Weren’t you sad then, too?”

Manstein froze. Head lowered, he stared silently at his phone. Shouts traveled back across the decades into his ears:

“Separate those two crazy children! What are they doing?”

“Damn it! Let go! I’m warning you, don’t make trouble!”

“Time for electrotherapy! Pull them apart! Take him to the treatment room!”

He still remembered the pain, like broken blades cutting inside his body. After each great jolt, a faint scorched smell made him want to cry. He had stared at the solitary square window of his isolation cell, longing to fly like a bird, longing for something to descend from heaven and change his life.

Fingel tossed the stripped goose bone onto his plate, belched, and leaned forward to look Lu Mingfei in the eye. “Want to hear… a secret technique?”

“A secret technique?” Lu Mingfei paused.

Fingel lowered his voice. “Every exam is a means to an end. Means are invented by people. Anything people invent has a flaw!”

“Dear senior!” Lu Mingfei perked up, choosing his warmest form of address. “Do you have a plan?”

“Any objection to cheating?” Fingel’s eyes gleamed.

“Not… the slightest!”

“Promising material!” Fingel admired his resolve. “Remember, to survive here, we must have standards!”

“Standards?” Lu Mingfei couldn’t believe so moral a word had emerged from Fingel’s mouth.

“They must stand about three meters below ground level!” Fingel placed his hand on the floor. “Here. Dig down three meters. That’s our standard!”

“Makes perfect sense!” His senior had moved him deeply.

“In this place crawling with geniuses and lunatics, have standards, but never above minus three meters. Otherwise you’re doomed.” Fingel looked conspiratorial. “A craftsman sharpens his tools first. To cheat, we must understand what we’re cheating on! Junior, how many Draconic sentences have been deciphered?”

“Don’t you count words?”

“Wrong! Sentences! Only seventy-six!” Fingel assumed a lecturer’s manner. “Language has vocabulary and grammar. Together, they produce infinitely many sentences. But Draconic is a dead script. Only the characters survive, not the grammar. The last person who knew that grammar was Nicolas Flamel…”

“Nic… Nic… Nico-what?” Lu Mingfei hadn’t caught it.

“That pig brain! Forget it. Call him… Old Nick! We’ll call him Old Nick!” Fingel waved. “He lived in Paris, a scribe by trade and an alchemist. The only person in recorded history to create the Philosopher’s Stone!”

“The Philosopher’s Stone? Sounds cool.”

“Extremely! A little complicated to explain. Basically, a fifth element beyond earth, water, air, and fire: pure spirit. You’ll learn about it in Introduction to Alchemical Principles. Alchemy and Yanling are the twin pillars of dragon technology. Before science, dragons used them to work miracles. Old Nick’s interesting. A scribe, then suddenly a master of this dragon art. While copying a unique old book, he found an alchemical manuscript recording Draconic grammar. He learned it, but never passed it on. Instead, he compiled seventy-six obscure sentences and left only those to posterity. They’re all we can decipher today. Understand? At most, seventy-six possible questions.”

“You mean there’s a question bank?” Understanding dawned.

“Exactly! First, how the questions work. You enter the room and get blank paper and a pencil. No prompts. They play recordings of Draconic chanting. For dragon descendants, it resonates with the mind, producing spirit vision. Draconic is pictographic. You’ll ‘see’ incredible things.”

“See what?”

“Different for everyone. Usually tangled lines, writhing snakes, wildly growing plants, things like that. Just record what you see.”

“An art exam?” Lu Mingfei stared. “I’m not much of an artist.”

“If you can doodle a turtle, that’s enough. They’re testing spirit vision, not drawing skill. The purer the blood, the more you see and the more lifelike it is.” Fingel took blank paper and rapidly sketched

with a pencil. Unexpectedly, he was good. Lu Mingfei watched a drawing emerge, extremely abstract, countless overlapping waveforms resembling an ocean from a distance.

"There are lots of curves here. Extract certain sections…" Fingel darkened several lines. "…and you get Draconic characters. Norma grades it. She analyzes your drawing in detail and locates them, very precisely. Random scribbles won't work. This is something I drew back then. One of the questions."

"So… seventy-six drawings? And variations on each? I can't memorize that question bank!" Lu Mingfei's newly kindled hope threatened to go out.

"Don't worry. Now I reveal the ultimate secret!" Fingel bared his teeth in a grin. "The greatest flaw in Cassell's 3E system: they reuse old papers!"

"Reuse?"

"Only eight papers in all. An eight-year cycle. They never change!"

"Have the professors lost their minds?" Lu Mingfei couldn't believe it.

In China, teachers fought students and students fought teachers, both seasoned combatants. The entrance exam covered only a few textbooks, but what high school teacher couldn't produce a hundred mock exams? Chinese teachers practiced something like Huang Yaoshi's Jade Flute Swordplay, variation after variation, hundreds of moves. Cassell's professors apparently favored the Eighteen Dragon-Subduing Palms: tremendous strength and force, but once the sequence ended, they had to start again.

Fingel shrugged. "Only a few dozen to a hundred take 3E each year. Geniuses. They graduate in four years and join the Executive Department, hunting dragon ruins worldwide. Who would memorize the papers and leak them to freshmen? An eight-year cycle is safe. But there's always an exception." He raised his brows, looking thoroughly sleazy. "Remember? I've been here eight years!"

"Aaaaaah!" Enlightenment struck. Lu Mingfei was beside himself. "This year's paper is exactly the one you took when you arrived!"

"Three thousand dollars, no bargaining. Deferred payment accepted. Subtract the four hundred ninety-seven you spent treating me, plus two dollars' Coke in Chicago. You owe twenty-five hundred and one. I'll waive the odd dollar. Twenty-five hundred for my paper. Your decision. Ten-second countdown!" Fingel spoke like bullets leaving a barrel, his tone hard as a sword stroke. "Ten! Nine! Eight!…"

"Wait, wait… Hey! What's going on?" Lu Mingfei panicked.

"Seven! Six!"

"At least let me inspect the goods, senior! You can't force a sale!"

"Five! Four!"

"What if they're not as advertised? Any repair, replacement, or refund guarantee? Do you issue receipts?"

"Three! Two!"

"Hey, bastard! Are you listening? Damn it… Deal!" Feeling almost faint, Lu Mingfei collapsed into a seat, panting.

"At this point, only I can help. You have no choice. Why resist?" Fingel drained his sparkling wine and exhaled a leisurely breath of carbon dioxide. "I knew these eight hard years wouldn't be wasted. Today, for the first time, I turned knowledge into money!"

"Pah! Shameless! Crooked merchant!" Lu Mingfei was furious. "And I thought you were one of those idiot seniors with thick glasses, lots of knowledge, no girlfriend, and a one-track mind!"

"Nonsense! I was an A-rank as imposing here as Caesar! Plenty of girls admired me. Flirtatious emails in my college inbox!" Fingel thumped his broad chest, the German wearing the triumphant smile of a Jewish merchant closing a deal.

"Single old guys always brag about being irresistible in their youth!" Grieving for his twenty-five hundred dollars, which had just sprouted wings and flown away, Lu Mingfei struck back savagely.

Fingel looked downcast. "Unfortunately, I was determined to earn enough credits to graduate in three years and become the Executive Department's youngest agent. I ignored their interest… By the time I wanted to respond, they'd all become little Executive Department birds and flown around the world."

"A loser who keeps repeating years shouldn't talk like that. Even if they hadn't flown away, they'd only say, 'I was so blind as a kid, liking Fingel.'"

"Junior." Fingel patted his head. "Your first college lesson: girls fall for men through foolishness, and they're more prone to foolishness when young. So cute little girls are better than glamorous older women!"

"Enough, enough. Stop the commentary. Twenty-five hundred? I don't have it. Can I pay when the scholarship arrives?" Lu Mingfei asked. "And what four-hundred-ninety-seven-dollar treat? I don't remember buying you anything that expensive."

"Later payment's fine. As for the meal…" Fingel tapped the goose bone against the plate. "Half's in your stomach. Half's in mine."

"Wasn't that the college's late-night food service?" Lu Mingfei was lost.

"They charge! Think you eat off silver for free? A free meal gets you a plastic fork at best!"

"But we never paid, Senior Wisecrack!"

"We swiped your student ID."

"My student ID?" Lu Mingfei was puzzled.

"It's also a credit card guaranteed by Citibank. As S-rank aristocracy, you have a hundred-thousand-dollar limit. Doesn't treating your useless senior, with his eighty-dollar remaining limit, to a four-hundred-ninety-seven-dollar meal seem wonderfully generous?"

"So… I've already started going into debt?" His heart bled.

"Debt's nothing to fear." Fingel reassured him. "I'm over thirty thousand in the red, and living quite nicely."

Lu Mingfei covered his face. His senior's serene shamelessness left him in despair.

Midnight. Beneath the library, a red access-control light blinked at a steady frequency, signaling that the security system was operating normally.

It was quiet, broken only occasionally by spinning hard drives. The enormous central computer occupied the first through sixth basement levels. Aboveground, it would have been the size of a small

building. Security was at the highest level: retinal, voiceprint, and fingerprint recognition all active. Blast-resistant alloy plates formed the outer walls. Infrared lasers scanned every area, even gaps admitting only a mouse.

Footsteps approached, sounding like iron-shod military boots. The red light blinked faster, increasingly so as they drew nearer. Unable to identify the visitor from the footsteps, the system raised its threat rating toward the alarm threshold.

The footsteps stopped at the entrance. Ignoring the biometric systems, the visitor swiped an unmarked black card through the slot.

The threat rating plummeted. Infrared scanners and hundreds of cameras powered down. Warning lights turned green. With faint clicks, all nine metal doors leading to the central computer unlocked together.

On the library's top floor, Manstein and Guderian faced each other silently. Manstein glanced at his watch and froze. It was a monitoring terminal. It showed the security system entering sleep mode, though that system ran year-round and never slept.

"Executive Department. Norma's security system has gone dormant. Send people to the library." Still speaking, Manstein ran for the elevator.

Guderian set down the sealed Ice Sea Fragment vessel and squeezed in just as the doors closed.

At the ground floor, Manstein stepped out and looked around. Deep in the night, the floor was silent.

Cassell's library was an elegant building in antique style, with a ground-floor hall nearly ten meters high, magnificent as the Sistine Chapel. Exquisite marble columns supported graceful vaults, beneath stained-glass windows through which the starry sky could be seen. Polished granite tiles reflected visitors like mirrors. The carved cherrywood doors at the corridor's end were locked.

A knock sounded. Manstein opened the door to a tall, gaunt figure standing in shadow, dressed entirely in black and pulling a small cart.

"Professor von Schneider. You came yourself," Manstein said.

"Mans is in China. I have to attend to things personally." Schneider raised a hand in greeting. "I noticed Norma's security system sleeping, too."

He entered the light. A black mask covered his face; an air hose led to a steel cylinder on the cart. Dark-red scars crowded his neck. His breathing was low and clogged, like damaged bellows. Iron-gray eyes swept coldly across them.

Both professors looked away. Nobody at Cassell liked meeting the Executive Department chief's eyes. It felt like staring at a blade point from a few centimeters away.

"No intruder detected on surveillance." Schneider glanced around, then turned to Manstein. "It's late. You two are the only ones here. Anything unusual?"

"Nothing. The 3E exam's tomorrow. Perhaps students are trying to hack Norma for the paper." Manstein forced a smile, attempting to lighten the atmosphere. The Executive Department always carried itself rather imperiously. As Disciplinary Committee chairman, he dealt with students and preferred avoiding the department unless necessary. Still, he had to show Schneider some respect.

"Students stealing exam papers aren't our concern. Pureblood dragons are." Schneider ignored the smile entirely. "Norma's security cannot be breached. It's designed as an endless loop."

"If dragons invaded, surely the computer room wouldn't be their target?" Guderian asked.

"Unknown. Dragons cannot be understood. Vigilance is never wrong." Schneider raised his voice. "Norma. Why is security dormant?"

The overhead crystal chandelier suddenly lit, clean brilliance dispelling the cold darkness. Rows of carved cherrywood shelves filled the magnificent hall, holding hundreds of thousands of reference books. Brass plaques marked their sections. Identical green-shaded lamps on long cherrywood tables lit in succession. Not a shadow remained. The hall was empty.

"Professor von Schneider, Professor Manstein, Professor Guderian. Routine cleaning. I'm clearing junk data. I paused security and opened the data shield to send it out." A composed female voice echoed overhead. "Simply put, I opened the door to take out the trash."

"So much redundant data that you need a midnight cleanup? Opening the door creates a vulnerability. You should do it with other personnel present," Schneider said.

"Until dragons learn to use computers, I believe I'm safe," Norma replied.

"They learn quickly. Be careful." He was noticeably kinder to her than to his colleagues. "How much longer?"

"Just finished. Security is back online. The next disposal is in seventeen years. Until then, I'm completely secure."

"Sounds like seventeen years without nighttime library patrols." He laughed hoarsely. "We won't disturb you further. Good night, madam."

"Good night, gentlemen." Chandelier and desk lamps dimmed, leaving only a few warm-yellow iron wall sconces.

Schneider turned to go, then looked back at the two professors. "Access logs show you entered the rare-books section. Those books are highly classified. What academic problem brought you here to study them at this hour?"

Beneath his clouded but icy gaze, goose bumps rose all over Guderian. He looked desperately to Manstein, who still held the phone with which, minutes earlier, he had meant to report the White King descendant to the principal.

"Something you can't discuss?" Schneider pressed coldly.

Cold sweat covered Guderian's forehead. He feared Manstein would mention Lu Mingfei. He wasn't good at lying himself. As his friend said, whenever he lied, he couldn't stop scratching his head. Schneider was hard to fool. Before leading the department, he had been an excellent scholar.

"The White King," Manstein said softly.

Guderian's head buzzed. He couldn't protect Lu Mingfei. It was over.

"The White King?" Schneider's eyes widened. The name clearly struck hard.

"A new hypothesis." Manstein lowered his voice and leaned toward his ear. "The White King may be female!"

"Female?" Schneider's eyes widened further. After a long consideration, he asked, "How did you reach that conclusion?"

Guderian looked blankly from one to the other.

"I've been considering the cause of the dragons' civil war. Human rulers fight over land, gold, or women. What did dragons fight over? Land and gold mean little to them. Could a female dragon have triggered it?" Manstein spoke fluently and gravely.

"Hmm!" Schneider nodded repeatedly. "A fresh approach."

"Conflict between the sexes: such an important theme in human history! We've never considered whether the White and Black Kings' conflict was gender rather than power. Many examples exist of a husband and wife both wielding power but holding differing positions, leading to serious disputes. For example…" Manstein suddenly faltered. "For example…"

"Hillary and Clinton!" Schneider supplied.

"Exactly! Hillary and Clinton!" Manstein clapped his shoulder forcefully. "Imagine this research premise: the Black King created the White King to be his wife. Daughters marrying fathers are commonplace in Greek mythology. Their conflict as male and female ultimately caused the split."

"A rather human interpretation, but should we include the marital relationship in our research?" Schneider mused.

"An excellent point!" Manstein said. "Perhaps we could share the project, all three of us. Though when we publish, would you expect first authorship?"

"No, no, nothing of the sort." Schneider waved hastily. "I'm merely interested. An excellent angle!"

"Then shall we assemble detailed materials and discuss it together?" Manstein asked solemnly.

"Wonderful. Interesting, very interesting. A project worth losing sleep over." Schneider shook his hand and left, thinking as he walked, until he vanished into the distant dark.

"The White King might be female?" Guderian looked at Manstein.

"Made it up." Manstein cut him off impatiently. "Had to give Schneider something novel and interesting to ponder. Otherwise we'd have to explain accessing classified documents at midnight."

"But your argument made sense…"

"Enough!" Manstein covered his friend's mouth. "I said I made it up! We won't know the White King's sex anytime soon. But I'll give your student a chance. Tomorrow is 3E. Black King and White King descendants have very different Yanling. If Lu Mingfei is of the Black King's blood, he'll do well. Then forget my theory completely."

"And if… he fails?" Guderian asked.

Manstein sighed. "Then we must report it. Guderian… I know what you're like. But you must know we have no right to be selfish."

"All right." Guderian sighed. "Still, thank you."

"Nothing. You're right. If I were him, I wouldn't want to be treated as an alien either," Manstein said. "We suffered enough of that. Let's hope it doesn't happen to the children."

Guderian left last. Holding the cherrywood door handle, he suddenly remembered something. He had locked it upon entering. But when Manstein let Schneider in, he didn't seem to have turned the brass handle three times the other way… He couldn't remember clearly, and was too tired. Shaking his head, he pulled the door closed behind him.

Forty meters beneath the library, a figure huddled in a swivel chair, hands tucked away, head bowed. Only monitors lit the room, leaving his face in shadow.

"Everyone else has gone. During the security pause, the cameras were off. There's no record of your entry," Norma said. "I'll pause it again when you leave. What brings you here?"

"Can't I visit an old friend?" The man smiled, his newly shaved chin blue-dark. "Activate the EVA personality."

"Do appearances matter that much? I'm still me. Norma or EVA, at the deepest level, I'm still me," she said.

The enormous screen darkened, leaving countless little red and green lights blinking. Vast quantities of personality data flooded the supercomputer like seawater rushing upstream. Drive lights, data-traffic indicators, and processor-frequency lights flashed ten times faster, then faster still, until an almost frenzied frequency set the entire basement's rhythm.

Suddenly, every light went out. Absolute darkness filled the basement.

A beam descended from directly overhead, striking the floor before the chair. Luminous fragments drifted within it like snow. A girl stood at its center, translucent, shimmering faintly. Long black hair fell to her feet, though its ends floated in the air. She wore a long silk dress like a nightgown, barefoot and smiling.

"EVA." Slowly, the man reached into the light.

"All you can touch is air. Why reach out?" she asked softly.

"I just like holding your hand. It's a habit." Luminous fragments landed on his palm and vanished instantly.

EVA laid her translucent hand over his, offering no sensation. Mere illusions of light and shadow, departed memories preserved by 3D imaging. He gently closed his hand on emptiness, as though truly holding a girl's hand.

"Sometimes you used to hold my hand for more than ten hours a day. When you let go, our hands were covered in sweat," she said.

"If I didn't hold it, how would I know you were there?"

"You've always been so insecure. What use is strength to you?"

"I'm only lonely."

After a long silence, EVA asked, "Did you come to tell me something?"

"To ask a favor. I want this year's S-rank freshman, Lu Mingfei, to pass 3E, whatever his actual potential."

"If he really has no dragon blood, letting him pass and enter could expose our secrets."

"Call it a favor for a friend. It isn't difficult for you."

"For Norma, you mean." EVA sighed softly.

"Are you Norma?" He looked at the small, translucent hand in his. "I can't feel your hand. Often I think you aren't really here anymore."

"I'm not here anymore," she whispered. "What you see is only your own memory."

After a long silence, he said, "You're all-powerful here. I'd like a beer."

"Only hard drives, processors, and routers here. No beer. After all these years, you've changed so much. Still can't change that bad drinking habit?"

"I thought I'd never drink again… If I hadn't been drunk that night, perhaps I wouldn't have lost you." His voice was hoarse. "But all these years, I still need alcohol. When I don't drink, I think of you. I hate memories. They always make it hard to tell who I am."

"You're yourself. You've never changed."

"Hee-ha, hee-ha, hee-ha!" came from behind him. He turned warily, veins bulging and twisting like snakes along his forearms as unparalleled strength gathered. What he saw was strange: a little humanoid made of metal spheres and short rods, only knee-high. Components that should have lain scattered seemed held together by powerful magnetism. It even had a comical clown's face. Two metal-bead eyes rolled about; a rod mouth spread in an ingratiating smile. On the tray in its "hands" sat a chilled bottle of Samuel Adams dark beer.

As he took the bottle, the little creature deftly produced an opener and popped the cap.

"Have a pleasant evening, sir." Its voice issued from the surrounding speakers, in a bartender's tone.

"I made it when I was bored. It's the only one who plays with me here," EVA said. "Its name is Adams."

"You named it after a beer… Or do you think it's your Adam? To go with your EVA—Eve in German." He sipped and waved at Adams. "You can go now, little fellow."

Its smile grew cuter. It remained behind him, holding the tray.

"It likes tips," EVA said.

"You know how poor I am." Muttering, he took several quarters from his pocket and dropped them on the tray.

Adams bowed happily, chattered its cheerful "Hee-ha, hee-ha, hee-ha!" and darted into the dark.

"I meant to name it after you, but thought you might object," EVA said.

"Am I that ugly?" He shrugged. "Could I also hear what the Executive Department's people are planning lately?"

"Your real purpose?" She sighed. "Covering for a freshman is one thing. Leaking operational plans is another."

"You'll tell me. You've always granted my requests," he whispered.

After a silence, she said, "Four additional teams have gone to Tibet, Xinjiang, Greenland, and Mexico. Roughly thirteen hundred people worldwide are searching for dragon tombs. Professor Mans's team is closest to success. Its target is Norton, King of Bronze and Fire, a noble first-generation dragon and one of the Four Monarchs. They'll conduct Operation Kuimen on the Yangtze. I don't know the details. The principal devised it personally."

"Who besides Mans is involved? Norton's exceptional even among first-generation dragons. Hard to kill."

"Ye Sheng and Aki Sakatoku, the strongest young partnership in the department. The principal arranged it. There shouldn't be a mistake."

"He's made mistakes before. For instance… ten years ago," the man said faintly.

"Ten years. Don't keep holding on. We paid dearly, but we won."

"But only I came back alive." He swirled the bottle.

"We're all still watching over you, just like before!" EVA placed her other hand on his shoulder.

Several beams appeared around him, each containing a translucent figure: a girl in leather with neat, short red hair; a cold boy in sunglasses; a black-clad man with a monk's solemn face; a charming girl with her head tilted and long hair swirling. Six people in all, including EVA. They laid hands on his shoulders and smiled together, like smiles in an old photograph, still brilliant after so many years.

Head lowered, he drank in silence, neither looking at them nor speaking.

"EVA, don't play games like this." He shook his head. "They aren't here. They're asleep under the icy sea, thousands of kilometers away, locked in those metal diving suits… Unable to die, yet unable ever to come back."

The other beams vanished. Only EVA remained, stroking his cheek with an insubstantial hand.

"Any news of the Crown Prince?" he asked.

"If he's alive, he should be Emperor by now. But I have no news."

"Of course he's alive. I can still smell his rotten stench. Besides, if he were dead, how could I kill him myself?" His voice was as cold as the words were vicious.

"If killing him is the only way you can find peace," EVA whispered, "then… kill him. I'll wait for your news."

He nodded and withdrew his hand from the emptiness. He had only held air all along. Tipping back the beer, he headed out. Invisible to the naked eye, the web of infrared scanners shut down. Cameras automatically switched off. Flashing red warning lights turned green. High-voltage electricity beneath the corridor floor was cut. Security entered another brief sleep.

"Oh, right. That matter with Lu Mingfei. No problem?" Remembering, he turned back.

"No problem. Just covering for a freshman. It's hardly the only bad thing I've helped you do." EVA smiled. "May I ask why?"

"He seems a decent kid." He smiled, too. "I have other reasons. I'll tell you when I've confirmed my ideas."

He turned away, took two steps, stopped, and approached Adams in the corner. Crouching, he said, "Hey, brother. Could you return two coins so I can buy a Coke… I gave you everything… Look, money's only a toy to you. No supermarket or Coke machine down here…"

Adams's expression changed. Clutching its coins, it looked the perfect miser.

"Adams, give your big brother two coins," EVA said.

Its face changed again, deeply aggrieved. Carefully, it selected two old coins and handed them over.

"What a little miser!" He clapped its head hard. The alchemically constructed puppet robot couldn't withstand the force and collapsed into a heap of metal rods and spheres rolling everywhere.

Tossing the two coins and drinking his beer, the man receded. EVA silently watched his burly, lonely back. It wasn't as straight as it had been ten years ago.

The metal doors opened and closed. The man was truly gone. In the beam of light, the girl began to cry without a sound.

Rods and spheres rolled together. Adams reassembled itself and ran over, chattering "Hee-ha, hee-ha, hee-ha!" It froze at her illusory tears. After a moment, it suddenly waved both hands above its head and shook its body in an ungainly dance. "EVA, be happy! EVA, be happy! EVA, be happy!"

Coins clattered from its hands across the floor. Her tears fell onto the metal as well, splashing into faint blue glimmers.

"A freshman taking six of the top ten headlines in one day. Unimaginable."

"He killed Caesar and Chu. Imagine if his gun had held live rounds instead of Frigga rounds…"

"Breaking: S-Rank Lu Mingfei Has No Resonance with the Dragon Emperor's Secret Incantation. College Investigates!"

"Who Claims the Freedom Day Crown? Who Blew Away Caesar, Then Chu Zihang?"

Manstein shook his head and closed the college forum. It would probably be a sleepless night. Online numbers had reached a new high. Students across the college, even teachers using aliases, were hotly debating the freshman Lu Mingfei. Would a new S-rank bring hope, danger, or merely ridicule?

Manstein was uncertain, too. The White King theory might be unreliable. It was only conjecture, after all. No descendant had ever been documented.

All he had was an instinctive wariness of the Lu Mingfei who shot Caesar and Chu.

He turned off the light, sat alone in darkness for a while, then opened his phone and called. "Father."

The forum refreshed rapidly, messages scrolling upward without pause.

"Maybe 3E will put him in his place tomorrow. He doesn't look capable. Perhaps the principal misjudged his rank," someone posted.

"Maybe he has no dragon blood at all, so Chu's golden eyes don't scare him."

"His greatest strength is competitive gaming! What a joke of a talent!"

"Hey! Let's open a book. Who's betting he fails 3E tomorrow?" Fingel posted, an administrator badge beside his name. His arrival stirred excitement. This useless senior who could never graduate was a campus celebrity. He ran the news channel and always found something sensational.

"Not many will bet he passes. I'll start. A hundred says he does!" He opened a topic in the polling section.

"Fingel, are you staking your chance of paying off your credit card on your roommate?" someone mocked.

The No-side stakes soared, soon passing twenty thousand dollars. On Yes, only Fingel's hundred remained. In one short evening, everyone had unearthed Lu Mingfei's background: laughable grades, no girlfriend because nobody wanted him, a terrible sense of direction, gaming his only talent, dozens of pirated discs confiscated at customs. From any angle, a loser, nothing like an S-rank of legendary blood purity and boundless potential.

"Does nobody have a gambling spirit?" Fingel complained. "This is no fun. All you can win is my hundred. Right now, a bet on his passing pays a hundred thirty to one!"

"Five hundred says he passes," posted an ID called Murasame.

The forum fell silent. Chu Zihang's ID rarely appeared there. Lionheart's quiet president, the super-A-rank, disliked endless chatter. Yet he had made an exception to gamble five hundred on Lu Mingfei passing.

"I bet five thousand," posted Dictator.

"Caesar!" someone exclaimed.

"On his failing." Caesar logged off, leaving the forum temporarily frozen.

Dimly, another contest had begun. If natural enemies truly existed, Caesar and Chu were surely examples. Students couldn't remember them agreeing on anything. Today, at last, they had: after a freshman's two shots miraculously ended Freedom Day, both presidents accepted the result.

Would they admit defeat to a loser? Surrender a year's use of Norton Hall and the right to pursue any girl without rejection? Students thought them almost too generous. Neither needed to fear romantic failure, of course. Quiet, reserved Chu remained single and apparently uninterested in women. Caesar already had the famous Nono.

Holding a wireless keyboard, Caesar reclined on the sofa in Amber Hall's lounge and watched the stakes climb on a huge projection screen. After leaving Dictator, he had logged in as Sonic, an inconspicuous ID tucked silently into a corner of the online list.

With an iced coffee, Nono leaned against the wall behind him. "You're paying a lot of attention to Lu Mingfei."

"Yes. I don't know whether he'll pass tomorrow," Caesar admitted freely. "I bet against him only because I never take Chu Zihang's side in a wager."

"I know. Five thousand means nothing to you." She set down the coffee and picked up her backpack. "I'm off. I chose Manstein's course this semester. Need to hit the books. Call if anything comes up."

"Won't that tiny room with Susie feel cramped for studying? Besides, she shot you today… She'd do anything for Chu." Caesar reached out as if to stop her. "Stay here. Amber Hall's even more comfortable than Norton."

At the door, Nono turned and rolled her eyes.

He hastily raised both hands, protesting innocence. "I mean… a guest room! I have plenty!"

"What I like least about you is renting villas on campus. Doesn't it feel empty?" She curled her lip. "I don't like your Bugatti either."

"Fortunately, I lost it today." He shrugged.

"Oh. Good boy." She pulled the door closed. Caesar pushed his fingers into his brilliant blond hair and scratched his head, helpless.

"Three minutes until betting closes! Place your bets now. All stakes must reach my account before tomorrow's 3E exam. I'll hold them. Otherwise, the bet is void." Curled on a common-room sofa in Dormitory Area One, Fingel cradled his laptop, fingers flying. A dozen or so students surrounded him, solemnly watching.

"The power of news! First I leak his lack of Draconic resonance. Then I open a book on his passing 3E." Fingel applauded himself gleefully. "Then the mastermind bets he passes. At least fivefold profit. I move myself. Stakes ready?"

"Ready," a mathematician-like boy answered.

"Wait until just before the close. Otherwise they'll catch on."

"Understood. Thirty-four seconds! Synchronized with system time!" An elite member of the campus loan-sharking ring opened a countdown program, replying with a scientist's precision.

"Three or four seconds early. The odds are already fixed. Most money will come in at the end. There may be lag," someone warned.

Stakes changed rapidly on both sides, new bets arriving every second. Closing time approached. Their hearts raced like traders' on a stock exchange.

"Ten, nine, eight, seven, six, five, four…" The timekeeper licked his slightly dry lips.

"Place it! Close!" Fingel swept his arm commandingly.

"Zero!" the timekeeper shouted. "Bet placed! We win!"

"Wait! The amount on Lu Mingfei is… thirty-nine thousand four hundred. Someone put in twenty thousand at the last second…" A voice trembled.

"Twenty thousand!" Fingel was aghast. "Use my administrator ID. Find out who!"

A minute later, he stared at the laptop. The bettor's ID was perfectly clear, his real name, open and unashamed: Gerd Rudolf Manstein. Followed by his title: Professor.

"The Disciplinary Committee chairman gambles, too… Isn't he supposed to stop cheating?" Cold sweat poured from Fingel.

Meanwhile, under a lamp, Lu Mingfei copied the answer sheet Fingel had left, stroke by stroke. His senior had gone out wearing a strange smile, saying he didn't want to interrupt his efforts. Lu Mingfei was alone. Less than four hours until dawn. In that time, he had to copy eight drawings and commit them to memory. The lines were dense forests of tangled vines, never meant to be remembered.

But remember them he must, even as fatigue rose slowly like a tide.

What if the goods weren't as advertised? What if this twenty-five-hundred-dollar answer sheet was nonsense? Who tested a language by drawing pictures? Why trust Fingel, alternately clueless and cunning? The man had exploited him from beginning to end. His thoughts tangled. And what if he passed? In a college of geniuses boasting reptilian ancestry, would he crawl out alive? Then what? Travel the world killing dragons?

Far away in China, it should be morning. Was Chen Wenwen in her white dress, holding her new boyfriend's hand on their way to some ordinary university?

That night Nono drove him down the elevated road, he had thought he had found a way out. Yet he was still a tiny firefly, following everyone else in aimless flight.

Hugging his knees on the bed, he thought for a long time, then whispered to himself, "Nono, I really want to see you."

He just wanted to see her, whatever had happened.

Act Four

The Bronze City

The new map immediately appeared on the main screen. After a brief silence, everyone whipped around to stare at Lu Mingfei. Once the map had been deciphered, understanding it was simple. Everyone recognized the answer was correct.

The control room was deathly quiet. Beneath that stillness lay immense astonishment and unease, like a depth charge sinking silently through dark water.

For the first time, Lu Mingfei saw the petite girl's face, translucent as ice and snow, and just as cold.

"Hello, panda!" Nono said solemnly.

With two enormous dark circles under his eyes, Lu Mingfei blundered into the second-floor classroom in the library. The first thing he saw was a pair of long, jean-clad legs swinging beside the lectern, ending in familiar purple-and-gold Mary Janes. Nono sat on the lectern, pointing at his nose.

He hadn't expected her to speak to him voluntarily again, and excitement stirred in his heart. "Sorry, sorry. I don't know how I ended up blowing away your boyfriend yesterday."

Hisses immediately rose around the classroom. Only then did he remember what a tactless thing that was to say.

"Why apologize to me for blowing him away?" Nono shrugged. "Go to your seat. We're about to start. Professor Manstein from the Disciplinary Committee is proctoring. I'm collecting the papers."

Professor Manstein stepped out from the side, swept Lu Mingfei with a cold glance, and checked his watch. "Everyone is here. Now, the exam rules!"

"Cheating is absolutely forbidden. Offenders will be disqualified entirely! Don't try to look at someone else's paper. Cameras cover the whole classroom without a single blind spot! Don't try to bring electronic communications equipment either. Radio signals in this room are monitored! I know you're all geniuses, but greater geniuses than you have taken exams here. Every method of cheating you can think of has already been tried…" He spoke with ringing emphasis and tremendous authority.

Every desk had a nameplate. Lu Mingfei's read RICARDO M. LU.

He paused, realizing this was now his official English name. Looking up, he saw Nono with her arms folded, head turned, gazing out the window in utter boredom. She must have arranged the nameplates. She had been the first person in the world to call him Ricardo, a name she had invented offhand. A very willful girl: once she called him Ricardo, Ricardo he remained.

He looked outside, too, and suddenly noticed the lovely weather. The morning sun had climbed above the clouds, its light spreading down along them to cast window shadows across the walnut desks. A faint crimson glow suffused the room.

Something stirred gently in his heart. Perhaps the fine weather had dispelled his mood. Perhaps it was having an official English name for the first time.

"Ricardo, then," he told himself.

This was his first official day at Cassell, and it seemed a good omen. Suddenly he felt he might manage here after all. He couldn't help grinning.

Remembering that he knew nothing about his fellow freshmen, he craned his neck to look around. They seemed to come from all over the world, different skin colors and faces in identical Cassell uniforms. Quite a few pretty girls made a pleasing sight.

"I'm Kiran, president of the Freshman Association. Delighted to meet you, Lu Mingfei. Our S-rank! May I have your autograph?" The boy on his right turned to shake hands. He looked Indian, handsome, with black curls and sharply contrasted black-and-white eyes, like a star in a Bollywood musical.

"Me?" It was the first time anyone had asked for his autograph. He felt both pleased and shy. "My handwriting's terrible."

Kiran passed him a pen and notebook. Unable to refuse such enthusiasm, Lu Mingfei left his turtle-crawl scrawl on the page.

"We'd like to invite you into the Freshman Association. We…"

"Gentlemen, this isn't the time to socialize. Fail the 3E exam, and you won't need a social circle here." Manstein interrupted Kiran. "Before we begin, switch off your phones and place them at the corner of your desk with your student IDs."

Shutdown tones sounded across the room. Only Lu Mingfei had nothing to do. In eighteen years, he had briefly owned just one N96. He stole looks at the others' phones, feeling inferior, and considered spending some scholarship money on one if he actually passed. Then an almost translucent hand reached out ahead of him and pushed an expensive Vertu to a desk's edge.

It was the first time he had seen one of those handmade luxury phones in person. They cost tens of thousands of yuan at least. He wanted another look, but its owner drew his gaze away.

A petite girl sat in the corner with her back to him, her skin coldly white. Having removed her uniform jacket, she wore a low-necked white T-shirt. Her blond hair, so pale it was almost white, had been braided and coiled into a bun, exposing a slender neck. Her entire figure was spare and pure as an ice sculpture.

His heart gave a jump. She seemed familiar. Yet he knew he couldn't possibly know a girl like that. He could count the blond girls he had seen before turning eighteen on his fingers.

Black shutters slid silently from between the layers of the carved wooden window frames, sealing every window. Wall lamps came on. Nono walked down the aisles, giving each freshman several A4-sized sheets and a sharpened pencil.

The exam papers were blank.

Sharp breaths sounded around him. Nobody had expected blank papers. Someone raised a hand.

"No need to question it. There's nothing wrong with your papers. I'll be outside if you have questions. Discussion isn't forbidden, provided you don't copy someone else's answers," Manstein said. "Good luck."

He and Nono left. As the door closed, students looked around and whispered, fidgeting like ants on a hot pan, their faces showing the shock of seeing ghosts in broad daylight. They couldn't copy anyone's answers. With no questions, where would answers come from?

Then, incredibly, the PA began blasting rock music: Michael Jackson's "Beat It."

The students stared at one another, completely dumbfounded.

One exception: Lu Mingfei. He had victory in hand.

“They’ll use strongly rhythmic music to cover the Draconic. Concentrate on a secondary melody in the lower register. That’s the incantation. Resonance gives the others spirit vision, so they may act strangely. Don’t panic. No resonance, no visions, no problem. Just listen carefully and copy the answers I gave you.” Fingel’s words were coming true.

He stealthily rolled up a sleeve. Eight tiny pictures drawn in ballpoint marched along his arm: the eight answers. The abstract pictures had proved too hard to memorize, forcing him to make a cheat sheet. The oldest methods worked best against high-tech proctoring. He could pretend to scratch, shielding his arm from the cameras with his body. Destroying the evidence was quick, too: spit in his palm and scrub. He had learned this from Su Xiaoqiang, the Little Celestial Princess, who copied notes onto her thighs and wore a short skirt to exams. Proctors knew where the notes were, but lacked the nerve to expose them.

Pricking those slightly mobile ears, he indeed heard someone chanting softly beneath Michael Jackson’s high, bright voice. It sounded like a curse, or a sacred hymn.

“Yanling: Prophet.” Halfway through, he recognized it and immediately began drawing.

“No wonder you’re the only S-rank freshman. Your composure proves your ability again,” Kiran said beside him. “I have no idea what to do. Perhaps I won’t pass. If so, I have a favor to ask.”

“No, no. I’m just drawing ducks.” Lu Mingfei tried to cover himself. The first answer really did resemble countless little ducks fitted together.

“I hope you’ll lead the Freshman Association.” Kiran ignored the ducks entirely.

“Lead?” The idea seemed to have nothing to do with Lu Mingfei.

“Lionheart and the Student Council are recruiting freshmen. But we shouldn’t be scattered. I’ve always believed we can bring something new to this campus. We only lack a leader like Caesar or Chu Zihang. I’m not capable enough. You are!”

“Could you not suddenly look like you’re entrusting me with an orphan? You make me feel like you’re Liu Bei in White Emperor City and I’m Zhuge Liang. I’m just an extra!” Lu Mingfei waved his hands. What did bringing something new have to do with him?

Kiran fell silent. Disappointment appeared in his eyes. Tears welled and slid down without a sound.

Lu Mingfei’s heart lurched. “Bro, don’t cry. We can talk… I know Liu Bei cried until Zhuge Liang came out of seclusion, but don’t just rush in crying… I’m trying to tell you Zhuge Liang lives next door. I’m really just an extra.”

“So… that’s how it is.” Still crying, Kiran smiled faintly.

“Finally, you understand. Good day to you, then,” Lu Mingfei said.

Kiran wiped his tears. A heavy sorrow that seemed to pierce time filled his clear eyes. Ignoring Lu Mingfei now, he bent to sketch on the white paper. His pencil whispered, twisted lines growing like a forest. He sobbed softly while drawing without pause. Anyone unaware might have thought he was writing his last will.

“He hasn’t understood. He’s… having spirit vision!” Lu Mingfei realized and looked around.

The whispering had stopped. An eerie atmosphere filled the room. Some students sat blankly, as though their entire families had just died. Others dragged their feet along the aisles, eyes empty, like Qu Yuan beside the Miluo River or some other walking dead. A girl leaped onto the platform and wrote and drew across the whiteboard in sweeping strokes, unaware her marker had long run dry. Another, a charming girl, cried "Hallelujah!" and danced in delight. Clearly trained, she moved beautifully. The chilling part was that this wasn't a solo. An absent man seemed to hold her hand and dance with her, and she cast loving looks toward that invisible partner.

A whole room of demons danced, each absorbed, none disturbing another. Watching, Lu Mingfei broke into a cold sweat.

The world had gone mad without taking him along.

There was one exception: the ice-sculpture girl. Amid the revelry, she alone sat quietly, back straight as slender bamboo, as normal as he was.

Strangely normal.

"Judging by the time, resonance should have begun?" Outside, Masashi Toyama clutched his medical case, visibly nervous. "I'm ready. If the mental shock becomes too severe, I can go in immediately."

"They should manage. This group seems quite capable," Manstein said. "Nono, I remember how calm you were during your 3E exam. Spirit vision seemed nothing new to you."

"My first spirit vision was when I was very young. By the exam, I was used to it," she said.

"What was the first one?"

"My mother lay in bed. A shadow came and drew out her soul. She died."

"Oh? Visions that realistic are rare. Most people only see confused lines and indescribable faces." Manstein sounded curious.

"More realistic than you think. I didn't only see someone take my mother's soul… I saw his face." Leaning against the wall, Nono looked toward the far end of the corridor and spoke quietly.

"Concentrate, concentrate! Almost there!" Lu Mingfei had finished seven questions.

Fingel had proved an excellent crooked merchant. Cassell really had dug up the exam from eight years before, changed the order, and used it again.

Beside him, who knew how many answers Kiran had finished? Smiling through tears, he kept sorrowfully recounting his tragic family history. He had been born in a Queensland slum. His father, an Indian doctor and alcoholic, often beat him and his mother. His poor grandmother planted a pomegranate tree behind the house, but died before its fruit ripened.

Lu Mingfei found it maddening, but the Freshman Association president's feelings were too sincere to interrupt.

He completed the eighth answer, responding vaguely to Kiran while stealing a look at the girl. He could hardly believe there was another normal person here. Had a second fake dragon-blood descendant slipped in?

Someone sat on the desk behind her, watching him: a well-behaved-looking boy swinging his legs, in white square-toed shoes, a little black suit, and a white silk neck scarf. His golden eyes were pale.

Why was he here? Lu Mingfei was alarmed. The boy who haunted him like a restless ghost had returned. How had he entered the exam room? Or had he been among the students all along?

The boy beckoned slowly, smiling faintly like an angel. Afternoon sunlight shone behind him, casting his long shadow all the way onto Lu Mingfei. Feeling he could not refuse, Lu Mingfei pushed aside his desk, approached step by step, and finally took his hand. The boy hopped lightly down and led him to the window. It was like a man and woman in a courtly dance. Lu Mingfei felt he was dancing the woman's part; the boy controlled their rhythm.

The boy vaulted lightly onto the sill, dangling his legs outside. Puzzled, Lu Mingfei sat beside him and studied him in the setting sun. He had never seen an older boy so pretty: a rounded face, an innocence between boy and girl, every movement gentle, an inborn elegance as though he had never trodden on dust. Leaning against the vine-covered frame, he gazed into the distance. Sunset gave his golden eyes a faint red glow, nothing like the cold severity of Chu Zihang's.

The stillness felt too precious to break. Cassell in the sunset resembled an oil painting.

"Hey. I'm Lu Mingfei." After much thought, he decided he ought to say hello.

"I'm Lu Mingze." Looking into the distance, the boy spoke softly.

Lu Mingfei thought he was joking. He knew Lu Mingze best: his cousin, their shared bedroom, the same high school. Cute as a little boy, but now 160 centimeters and 160 jin, his face covered with adolescent acne. Unable to find a girlfriend at school, he posted despairing, sentimental sentences online to pick up girls. The boy before him was worlds apart. Not the slightest resemblance.

"Sunset? You're online?" The boy turned toward him.

Lu Mingfei almost jumped. Sunset's Imprint was his girl-impersonating QQ name, the account he used to tease his cousin. Every time he logged on, Lu Mingze said exactly that: "Sunset? You're online?"

A simple greeting. Whenever his cousin typed it, Lu Mingfei sensed eager, lustful anticipation. From this boy, the same words felt utterly different. As though he had known Lu Mingfei would come—to that place, at that moment.

"Who are you really?" His voice trembled a little.

"Unimportant. This is your spirit vision. Everyone's is different, but everyone sees what matters most deep in their heart. You saw me." The boy calling himself Lu Mingze said, "I'm the person you care about most. An honor."

"Stop joking. Isn't spirit vision supposed to be… tangled lines? Look at you. Where's the tangle? Not even a hair out of place!"

"You summoned me this time. Ask yourself why you see me. Everyone else is sad. Aren't you?" Lu Mingze glanced at the sorrowful and joyful people in the classroom. On the sill, the two resembled spectators at a surrealist play.

"I don't feel anything. If real spirit vision makes people sad, why don't you look sad at all?"

"They truly are sad. They see the deepest things in their hearts. Where's the deepest part of yours?" Lu Mingze extended a finger and poked his chest.

"Deeper than the heart… That'd be the stomach." He couldn't resist a lousy joke.

"Humans are stupid things. You, too. The only difference is that you deliberately make yourself stupid," Lu Mingze said mildly. "You aren't sad because I'm sad for you. Cruel, isn't it?"

He smiled at Lu Mingfei, brilliantly in the sunlight.

"Are we… having a deeply emotional discussion of love between two males? 'I'm sad for you'… Don't you think your lines are straight out of a romance?" Gooseflesh rose all over Lu Mingfei.

Lu Mingze ignored him and stared at the sinking sun. In the final light, two lines of tears slipped silently down his face.

Lu Mingfei felt a hand squeeze his heart. Now he sensed the boy's immense grief, like freezing water bursting forth, sweeping toward him to drown him. This was no romance, no affected pose. The boy's sorrow was fierce, overwhelming, imperious. It inspired awe.

"Now I hate having you beside me." Lu Mingze suddenly kicked him.

He lost his balance and fell. With a shock, he saw that he hadn't been sitting at a second-floor library window, but atop an obelisk. Below lay no green Cassell lawn, only fanglike rocks that would tear him apart. He flailed for something to grasp, finding nothing but air.

Above, Lu Mingze stood silently on the obelisk's spear-point summit, a giant sunset behind him, and waved goodbye. His beautiful face was expressionless.

Lightning seemed to flash through Lu Mingfei's mind. A terrible image flickered: a night of bitter wind and rain, cold stone edging a flower bed, drops falling from leaves overhead. He and that boy—or his cousin Lu Mingze—sat in the darkness, holding each other tightly.

"Oh God! I don't like men…" He fell into darkness.

He leaped from his chair, drenched in cold sweat, as though breaking through a dark membrane into reality. Nono stood before him, slapping his head hard enough to make him dizzy. They were alone in the empty exam room.

"Impressive. Sleeping that soundly during 3E," she said. "Were you born in the Year of the Pig?"

"The Sheep… Exam over?" He rubbed his eyes.

"Almost lunchtime. The exam only lasts three hours."

Startled, he saw burly maintenance men at the front removing the whiteboard covered in tangled lines and carrying the whole thing away.

Nono looked back. "Oh. She answered on the board. Nothing for it but to take it down and submit it. Emotions aren't very stable during 3E. These accidents happen. But you were amazingly calm. We're all curious. On the monitors, you quietly finished, put your head down, and snored. Even Manstein was impressed."

"I… didn't do anything strange?"

"Nothing. Like I said, amazingly calm."

He pressed his forehead. When had that strange dream begun? When Kiran started crying? When he finished the paper? Or was he still dreaming? He hated not distinguishing reality from illusion. He pinched and twisted his wrist hard—accidentally too hard, bringing tears to his eyes.

"It's swelling…" Nono pointed.

"Ow… I know…" He grimaced.

"Hand it in. You're the last."

"Oh, right." He turned over the facedown "artwork" and passed it across.

"Let me count." She checked the sheets, then snapped a stapler. "Nine pages. All together now."

His head buzzed. Nine pages? Why nine? He clearly remembered drawing only eight childish sketches. There were only eight he could draw. Fingel had sold him eight answers. Where had the ninth come from?

"Wait, wait… Let me check." He hurriedly reached for her stack.

"What's to check? An S-rank like you can breeze through this." She pulled it away.

In that brief instant, he saw his final sheet, the one absent from his memory. Undoubtedly his drawing. Yet it struck him like five bolts of thunder.

Dazed, he watched Nono pass it to Manstein, who dropped it into a black combination case. The lid snapped shut. Everything was settled. Lu Mingfei had no right to change it now.

Manstein scrambled the combination and handed the case to Nono. "Take it to Norma for marking."

Pale, Lu Mingfei pressed his forehead. "Impossible… Could I… draw that well?"

At the dining table, he looked as though both his parents had died.

"Hey! Hey! How'd it go? That face… Caught cheating?" Fingel nudged him with a shoulder. "Don't give me up!"

"Bullshit. What do you take me for? I'm an old hand!" He waved impatiently. "Answered all eight. Nobody saw my tricks. Afterward… I scribbled something else."

"Fine, fine. As long as you didn't write nonsense. Random scribbles get ignored." Fingel relaxed.

"No nonsense… As a picture, it was better than anything I've ever drawn…" He didn't know how to explain.

At lunchtime, they sat beneath the dining hall's arched dome. The hall resembled a sanctuary from the age of knights. An enormous tree-shaped chandelier hung at its center, each leaf a small crystal lamp. Latin words welcoming freshmen adorned the granite walls. Students in dark-green uniforms gathered around tables. Each table's student supervisor sat at its head. Fingel occupied that seat.

"Never knew you were a class officer, Brother Useless."

"Just table captain. No place for eighth-year students, so they exiled me to the freshmen."

"Pass these along." A waiter placed a lunch before Fingel.

"The same menu?" Fingel sighed. "Freshman welcome lunch. Anything besides roast pork knuckle, mashed potatoes, and sauerkraut? I've eaten this eight times."

"No problem. I can adjust it," the waiter said.

"Something to look forward to? Beef in red wine?" Fingel's eyes shone.

"I can offer roast pork knuckle with two portions of mashed potatoes, or roast pork knuckle with two portions of sauerkraut. Which would you prefer?"

"Got a pork knuckle wedged sideways in your skull?" Fingel inspected his head.

"Eat. You don't get a choice. The menu's a tradition, too. German food's your home cooking, isn't it? How can you not love it?"

"Cows back home make cow dung. I don't like cow dung either," Fingel said. "Understand the logic?"

"Why always German food?" Lu Mingfei prodded the knuckle, unsure where to start.

"Cassell's a German family name. History's most famous dragon-slaying clan. Every generation had a few experts. Supposedly, even the principal was only a second-string member back then," Fingel said. "They're the college's leading board member, hence the German style."

"The principal's surname is Cassell?"

"No. The Cassells are all dead."

"All dead?"

"Think what they did for a living all those years. Lasting into the twentieth century was lucky." Fingel bit into his knuckle. "Anyway, exam's over. Relax and wait. Classes should start tomorrow. Your Magic-Powered Mechanical Design I professor is Mans Rundstedt. Exam fanatic. Takes attendance every class. Watch out."

"Eight in the morning! No sleeping in?" Lu Mingfei sighed.

"Attention, freshmen. Tomorrow morning's Magic-Powered Mechanical Design I class is canceled. Professor Rundstedt will email the first chapter's lecture notes to you." Norma's voice echoed through the hall.

"So thoughtful!" Lu Mingfei beamed.

"Rundstedt must be on assignment in China." Fingel kept eating without looking up.

"On assignment?"

"Classes often stop for weeks because professors are away. Many work part-time for the Executive Department," Fingel said. "Secret assignments."

"Could it be…" Lu Mingfei started.

"Dragons. Canceling class at short notice means they've found a clue."

Late at night, the tug Moniach shuddered in a storm on the upper Yangtze.

Such rain was rare in autumn. Water poured down, winds reaching force five. Other vessels had sheltered along shore. Only Moniach's xenon lights flickered through rain above the uneasy water.

Professor Mans Rundstedt, also the captain, stood at the wheelhouse window. Rain slammed against the glass and burst apart. Wind howled; the boat rocked. Mans stood steady, smoking a cigar, waiting for news.

A baby's cries drifted from the aft cabin. Mans frowned. "See what's wrong with the little one. Always crying. Doesn't anyone know how to look after a baby?"

"Professor, none of the Executive Department's core personnel are married. Where do you expect us to learn?" The girl at the monitor never looked up. About twenty-three or twenty-four, she had black hair and a classically beautiful Latin face, and wore Cassell's custom combat uniform.

"Call me Captain. I'm Moniach's captain now, not your substitute lecturer." He exhaled cigar smoke. "Stay at your posts. Since I'm the only married man, I'll see to our dear baby. Selma, watch their vital signs. Any abnormality, haul in the lines!" "Understood!" the Latin girl replied.

"Captain, Yangtze Navigation Maritime Bureau advisory. The storm will continue after midnight. Winds rising to force ten, rainfall two hundred millimeters. Exceptionally severe, possible thunderstorms. They're arranging rescue helicopters and advise abandoning ship." The third officer removed his headphones.

"Tell them our draft is deep, the vessel is stable, and we can ride it out. We have patients aboard who shouldn't abandon ship," Mans said. "And don't worry. This is Moniach. Not a tug, a warship. Force twelve is no problem." He looked up at the black sky. After a silence, he murmured, "But this rain recalls Greenland's icy sea ten years ago… Every time we approach these things, it feels like disaster is coming."

He went aft. The forward cabin was quiet. Everyone had been rigorously trained at Cassell. Eyes on screens, they worked swiftly and silently.

Two intertwined heartbeats sounded through the headphones. On Selma's monitor, rising and falling green points showed that two young, strong hearts still beat normally.

Fifty meters below the surface.

Fifty meters below the surface.

The spotlight penetrated only a short distance through deep water, a single blue-gray band. Aki Sakatoku's slim figure floated nearby, close enough for Ye Sheng to reach out and take her hand.

Ye Sheng and Aki Sakatoku. Their twenty-seventh underwater operation together. Classmates at Cassell, they had joined the Executive Department at the same time. Diving partners for five years, they could read each other's thoughts in a glance.

"I hear that S-rank freshman, Lu Mingfei, took out Caesar and Chu on his first day, during Freedom Day," Ye Sheng said. "Didn't show that potential when we interviewed him."

"Wonder how Nono persuaded him," Aki said. "Usually talks nonsense, but sometimes she has plenty of ideas."

A separate communications cable linked the two of them tightly.

Nono had indeed talked nonsense about one thing. Ye Sheng and Aki weren't lovers. Regulations forbade it. Deep diving was dangerous: oxygen tanks and a layer of nanomaterial suit protected you from pressure equivalent to more than ten atmospheres, while a single cable connected you to the human world. Nerves could easily become overwrought. Romantic feelings between partners could lead to unpredictable results.

The department prohibited romance between underwater partners, saying violation of that rule had caused the terrible losses in Greenland's icy sea ten years ago. No one knew what that operation had been. But nobody in the department today had taken part, permitting a rough conclusion: the team ten years ago had all died.

They reached the bottom. Fifty meters of water filtered the storm into gentle ripples. Before the Three Gorges Reservoir flooded it, this had been mountain country. Currents had worn the rocks smooth, making footing difficult. Ye Sheng extended steel claws from his fins, settled lightly on a rock, and felt through the sediment.

He showed Aki his find: a pottery shard bearing an ancient design.

Examining it, she said, "At least a thousand years old. Before Central Plains culture absorbed Shu culture. Perhaps a relic of White Emperor City."

"Not much oxygen left. Is this the intended location? I don't see the supposed ruins of White Emperor City." She looked around. Nothing in sight resembled a city.

"Norma, I need a sonar terrain scan," Ye Sheng called.

"Understood. Preparing sonar scan." Far away in America, the central processor answered at once.

A three-dimensional sonar image outlined in dark-green contours appeared on their helmet displays. Sound was far more useful than light underwater.

"We can't see it," Ye Sheng pointed, "but mountains lie northeast and southeast. Above water is Baidi Mountain; below, Chijia Mountain. They form a gate. Opposite is the old Caotang River, through a valley. In Chinese feng shui, this is where the mountain dragon and water dragon meet, gathering yin and yang. An excellent place for a city. The ruins may be here. We need the entrance."

"After a thousand years, any entrance will be under meters of soil." Aki laughed softly. "To save time, I'll have to trouble you. Please."

"It leaves me exhausted every time," he complained. "I need an anchor."

"Haven't I always been your anchor?" She swam behind him, extended the claws in her fins to grip the rock, and wrapped both arms around his waist.

An unspoken understanding. When Ye Sheng sent out his Snakes, he was helpless as an infant. A current could carry him away, or a tangled cable endanger his life. So Aki always held him this way.

He closed his eyes. In spirit vision, restless snakes tangled in his mind, scales gleaming cold, hard blue-green. His body shuddered slightly.

Yanling: Snake.

He gave them an order. Released from deep in his mind, the snakes flowed through his limbs, then surged out and vanished into the water.

Moniach detected a powerful burst of bioelectricity at a point below the surface.

The Snakes were Ye Sheng's Yanling and his helpers. Normally they slept deep in his mind. Only he could wake them. Like thousands of scouts, they explored his surroundings. Scientifically, they were a bioelectric current. To dragons, they were servants he had subdued.

In good conductors, the Snakes became many times stronger. The reservoir's enormous water mass greatly amplified them. A domain five kilometers in radius lay under his watch.

His awareness followed them into every crevice, down and farther down. He opened his eyes, faint golden light flowing through them. Through the Snakes' eyes, he saw a world made of countless tiny channels, joining and separating, extending without end. His Snakes traveled through them, gray mist spreading wherever they went.

Aki felt his body cooling. At his weakest now, his pulse fell to thirty beats a minute and his blood temperature dropped. Through the faceplate, his face looked ashen, only the unsettling pale-gold pupils shining. She held him tighter, trying to share her warmth. She always did. He led their team, but now he needed her protection.

"Captain! Maritime Bureau warns of a possible magnitude-five underwater earthquake!" the third officer shouted. "They insist on sending rescue helicopters. They may have realized something's wrong here."

Mans entered the forward cabin, bent beside Selma, and studied Ye Sheng's pulse. "Stall a little longer. An earthquake is bad news. I have a feeling… we're close. Very close."

Ye Sheng shivered. The pale gold vanished, his pulse climbed rapidly, and his blood warmed again. Almost all the Snakes returned to sleep. One alone kept descending, piercing darkness—and finding light!

"A result?" Aki asked.

"A huge metal mass about forty meters beneath us. The Snake moves incredibly fast there. Only metal conducts that well."

"Forty meters down? It's solid rock. We can't cut through forty meters of it. Dragon King Norton couldn't have put his palace inside rock."

"Ye Sheng, Aki. Prepare to surface," Mans's voice sounded. "Possible magnitude-five underwater earthquake tonight. It's dangerous down there."

"Understood. Aborting for now." Then Ye Sheng's expression changed. The water around them was shaking. Aki felt it, too. Tremors came through the rock she stood on. The entire bottom shook. Rising sediment obscured their view.

"It's begun… Damn! Their warning was far too accurate this time!" From the sonar, Mans saw exactly what was happening. He turned to the first officer. "Reel in! Reel in! Pull them up!"

The winch turned, drawing in the black cable that served as communications line and lifeline. Then a snapping sound reached him through the storm. The winch raced out of control. His face changed. With no tension on it, the machine was running free. The lifeline had broken.

In the turbid water, the spotlight was no brighter than a firefly, barely illuminating two pale faces. Ye Sheng could only hold Aki tightly. They were falling fast.

A clear crack had raced toward them from afar, like an invisible blade slicing rock. The layer, meters thick, split and sank. Before they could react to the bottom tearing open, tremendous pressure struck from above, like a wave tens of meters high crashing onto their heads.

Underwater, pressure came equally from every side. Only one thing could abruptly increase pressure from overhead: a great cavity opening below. Millions of tons of water poured into it, sweeping them and the broken rocks along. Not even a nanomaterial lifeline could resist such force.

The forward cabin fell silent. Mans thrust both hands into his hair and dragged them backward hard enough to hurt his scalp.

Distorted static hissed from the speakers. Signal lost, survival unknown. That lifeline had also been their sole communications channel. He might have lost his two finest students. He had always known it could happen. Something similar had happened ten years before.

With the situation below unknown, should he send a rescue party? Or abandon them, as in Greenland? He thought desperately.

"If you see a wall whose edge you can't see above, below, left, or right, whose end you can never reach—what is it?" A calm voice sounded through the cabin.

Mans looked up in surprise. Ye Sheng.

"Death. Read that in a book once. Now I understand. This is Ye Sheng. Aki and I are alive. I'm speaking through the Snakes' current. We've reached the palace of Norton, King of Bronze and Fire. Please respond."

A special use of the Snakes: carrying Ye Sheng's voice back and forth between the depths and Moniach like messengers.

"Confirmed?" Mans's voice trembled slightly.

"Professor, if you saw the bronze wall in front of me, you'd believe it."

Deep below, Ye Sheng and Aki held hands tightly, suspended in eerie green water. Above, the spotlight vanished into green gloom. Every direction looked the same, without end. Except ahead, where a huge bronze wall extended up, down, left, and right, seemingly boundless.

The earthquake had paused. Sediment settled, clearing the view.

Amid the verdigris, Ye Sheng made out a weathered design identical to the one on the pottery shard, only much larger: a face burning in flames.

"A city… of bronze?" Aki whispered. Their private communications cable still connected them.

"Like the one he supposedly cast on the ice and snow of northern Europe," Ye Sheng said. "Lucky! Without the quake opening this fissure, we could never have drilled down here."

"Yes. Who'd know it was buried dozens of meters underground? An entire city cast in bronze. How did they do it?"

"Professor von Schneider had a theory. Norton hollowed out a mountain for a mold and poured molten bronze in from the summit. As the city took shape, heat shattered the rock, producing something even modern technology can't achieve: an entire bronze city. His home."

"Insane to imagine," Aki said softly. "Will he… be inside?"

"We'll have to go in to find out. I look forward to it."

"Ye Sheng, Aki, withdraw," Mans said. "There may be aftershocks. And you're low on oxygen."

"Professor, know what I'm looking at? The border between the human and dragon worlds. If you touched the edge of the world, would you stop to catch your breath? If an aftershock buries this opening, you'll regret it forever," Ye Sheng said. "Something's inside. I can feel it. The Snake that entered is circling something. It's terrified."

Mans stayed silent for a full minute. "Fear… Is it Norton's own tomb that's frightening the Snake?" He drew a deep breath. "All right. I understand. I'll replace your equipment. But remember, two hours. Both oxygen and power will last only two hours. Maritime's helicopters should arrive by then, too. At that point, we'll be forced to halt."

"Understood. But right now I'd love to know where the Dragon King's front door is. Not a crack in this thing."

"I think I know. Wait. I'll bring a locksmith down shortly," Mans said.

He went aft and called. "Principal, a development in Operation Kuimen. In a fissure opened by the earthquake, we've found a city cast entirely in bronze."

A pause. "An ancient bronze city. The palace of Norton, King of Bronze and Fire."

"We should explore immediately. Risky, with this storm on the Yangtze," Mans said. "But we can hardly wait. We have competitors."

"Competitors? Who? Few can compete with us in archaeological exploration."

"An underwater expedition funded privately from Hong Kong. Exploring a newly discovered submerged tomb. They don't seem to know anything about our affairs, but they'll dive soon. If they

find the bronze city, secrecy may become impossible." Mans paused. "Ye Sheng senses something inside. It isn't a dead city."

"Understood. Approved," the principal said. "Remember: never let a pureblood dragon escape our surveillance. Capture first, kill second. Let something like that out of our control, and the whole world will be overturned."

"With limited time, may I use the Key to open the city?"

"This is exactly why I had you bring him!"

Mans put away his phone, bent over the cradle, and gently stroked the baby. The child, howling a moment before, was now quiet, gazing innocently around with wide eyes. A woman sat beside him, alluring, in her thirties or forties. A diamond ring on her left ring finger suggested a wealthy husband.

"Sweetheart, do you feel it?" Mans pinched the baby's nose.

"Be careful using him. Our only Key. Such pure dragon blood—we may never find another. Not even Chu Zihang compares," the woman said.

"Much better behaved than Chu, though." Mans played with him. "Don't look so distrustful. You're only his foster mother. We all love the Key. Spend more time caring about your own daughter."

"Chen Motong?" she said mildly. "I don't see her treating me as a mother."

"Your family problems are complicated… Better leave them out of work." Carefully lifting the child, Mans met her eyes. "Forgive a word more, though. A mother who regards a daughter as her daughter only if the daughter first regards her as a mother—isn't she asking too much? You have a beautiful foster daughter."

"You're her adviser. I know you care for her. But a girl who can watch her own mother die, then sit quietly for two days and nights without crying until the body collectors knock, doesn't invite affection." Her voice never wavered.

"All right." Mans sighed. "I only mean that Nono can be odd… but she's… a very good child."

He returned forward and stood at the window, arms extended, waiting for Selma to fit his diving suit.

His gaze crossed the rain toward the distant mountain above water. "White Emperor City. I love that name."

"Captain, is White Emperor City the Dragon King's sleeping palace, or an actual city?" Selma asked.

"There is a city, founded more than two thousand years ago. It was above water until a few decades ago. The Three Gorges Reservoir submerged most of it. Only the White Emperor Temple remains on that island. Its founder, Gongsun Shu, rebelled against Wang Mang, an idealistic dynastic usurper, and established his own state here. Some called him the White Emperor."

"Reminds me of the White King," the third officer said.

"Not the White King. The King of Bronze and Fire, also called the Gray King. A noble first-generation dragon, one of the Four Monarchs. Norton. Born directly of the Black King Nidhogg."

"By himself?" Selma asked. "So the Black King's his… father or mother?"

"Current research says most dragons mate and have parents. First-generation dragons differ. The Four Monarchs weren't born from male and female pairing. Representing the four elements, they split

directly from the Black King. He is both father and mother," Mans said. "Chinese elements are metal, wood, water, fire, and earth. Dragons have only earth, water, wind, and fire. You should have learned this in introductory alchemy."

"So that Chinese man, Gongsun Shu, was a Dragon King?"

"No. Someone behind him. Before becoming emperor, Gongsun Shu claimed to see a dragon rise from a well and lie before his residence. Chinese histories record a 'dragon appearing before the mansion hall.' He took it as auspicious," Mans said. "Sichuan lay in ancient China's west. He thought his good fortune came from metal, whose color is white. Hence White Emperor. Not our White King: the name's real meaning in Chinese is King of Metal. Coincidentally, Norton performed two miracles: unrivaled fire, and refining bronze from deep within the earth to use as weapons."

"Why would this person… this dragon, do all that? Building a bronze city is an incredible undertaking!"

Mans spread his hands and removed his cigar. "We've never known. To understand their aims, first we must understand what dragons are and their relationship with humans. An academic puzzle. Fossils alone can't answer it. We may have to capture a living Dragon King and question him." He paused. "Tonight's a chance!"

Ye Sheng sensed the Snake inside the city becoming more agitated, swimming much faster.

A spotlight shone down. A figure swam toward them. Mans tapped his faceplate in greeting, releasing bubbles. He resembled a woman nine months pregnant: a rigid transparent pouch projected from his suit, containing a baby in a tiny diving outfit. In depths that would frighten adults, the infant miraculously didn't cry, only looked slowly around, faint golden light flowing in his eyes.

Mans brought new communications cables, connected them, and replaced the divers' oxygen tanks.

"Whoa! The Key!" Ye Sheng patted his belly pouch to amuse the infant. "Professor, you look like a diving kangaroo."

"Then you're a fox trying to steal my joey! Remember, two hours." Mans raised two fingers. "Get ready. I'm opening the door."

Floating behind him, Ye Sheng and Aki each placed a hand on his shoulder. He crossed his arms over his chest and firmly patted his finest students' hands.

He closed his eyes, pressed a hand to the bronze wall, and chanted quietly. Song and roar together, the immense sound pierced deep into their minds. Opening his eyes, he did something that would stop an ordinary diver's heart: at a depth of a hundred twenty meters, he opened the faceplate of his pressurized suit. Crushing water pressure would act directly on his frail human body. Every bubble in his blood could race outward and rupture his vessels.

His voice boomed through the water. He released his Yanling.

Yanling: Dustless Realm.

Water swirled around him. A transparent shell expanded rapidly outward, forcing water from a sphere several meters across. Currents spun furiously around it. High-pressure oxygen escaping his tank filled the bubble. Incredibly, they stood in air!

Where his hand touched, a north wind seemed to scour the wall. Great sheets of verdigris flaked off, revealing fresh metal, black-green with an oily gleam. A design emerged clearly: a raised human face biting a burning stick. Strange—contorted with pain, yet refusing to unclench its teeth.

"Sweetheart, the rest is yours." Hanging from the wall by steel claws, Mans carefully lifted the infant from his pouch.

Silence, broken only by the roaring vortex. The golden-eyed baby was quiet for a long time, then laboriously straightened to stand on Mans's palm. Only a few months old, pacifier in his mouth, cow-patterned onesie on his body, sparse baby hair on his head. Yet he stood upright, solemn as a priest. Studying the face, he slowly reached out a chubby hand and touched one finger between its brows.

A bronze projection cut the tender finger. Blood spread over the suffering face. For an instant, Aki saw it twist with pleasure. Ye Sheng caught the falling pacifier. A deep, bell-like sound poured from the infant's mouth. The wall began to resonate.

Blood streamed into the bronze mouth as though powerfully sucked away. The infant stood with a martyr's indifference, showing no distress. He bent slightly, almost to kiss the mouth. Mans seized him, stopping the disturbing movement. Taking a hemostatic bandage, he carefully wound it around the little finger and patted his cheek. "Key, enough. You were wonderful."

After drinking, the face was still, then slowly opened its mouth in a yawn. Horrible sounds of heated, cracking metal came from within. A black opening about a meter across appeared, edged above and below by the face's teeth—not human teeth, but dagger-sharp fangs.

"The entrance," Ye Sheng whispered.

"A great alchemical achievement. Spirit housed in the purest matter, serving as a guardian," Mans said. "A living spirit. Only exceptionally pure dragon blood briefly satisfies it. About two hours. It will close the door."

"About?" Ye Sheng asked. "That imprecise? On a Moon mission, could you say landing in about two hours? This is more dangerous than the Moon!"

"Save a minute of discussion, then," Mans said. "I'll end the Yanling. Once the passage floods, you can enter."

The pale gold faded from the infant's eyes. He raised his bandaged finger, looked at it in surprise, then burst into thunderous, utterly heartbroken wails.

"There, there, don't cry. Poor sweetheart." Looking like a helpless father, Mans put him back in the pouch.

"Remember. Two hours." He looked into Ye Sheng's eyes and repeated it. "Norton isn't due to awaken yet. Find his egg. If you can't secure it, destroy it." He handed over a black metal box. "Alchemical equipment from Equipment. Destroys eggs. Get fifty meters clear before detonation."

Ye Sheng gave a thumbs-up. Mans closed his helmet. The Yanling ended, and the air sphere instantly shattered into countless bubbles racing upward. Inrushing water nearly stopped the two divers' breathing. Their professor, meanwhile, pushed off the bronze wall with fishlike agility, activated the hydraulic thruster on his back, and shot away.

Aki watched him fade into the distance. Darkness returned. The only light was Ye Sheng's helmet spotlight.

Suddenly she felt cold—the annihilating cold at the edge of the world.

"Ye Sheng!" She turned.

"I'm here." Smiling, he extended his hand and clasped hers through their thick gloves.

Mans climbed over the gunwale, removed his fins, and raced forward without even stripping off his suit.

"Vitals normal, signal clear. They're deep inside. Bronze statues everywhere, passages like a space station, and… You wouldn't believe it! God, nobody could without seeing!" Selma met him, excited.

"Main screen," Mans said.

Dark-green video from the divers appeared. In the spotlight, shifting ripples played across an incredible bronze object. Circular, edged with sharp wolflike teeth. At first sight, you imagined throwing it, watching it howl through a strange arc, bite into an enemy's neck, and spin.

"Incredible craftsmanship," Mans murmured.

"Some kind of weapon," Selma said.

"Not a weapon. A gear. Part of a system."

The view pulled steadily back, apparently as Ye Sheng swam slowly away with his helmet camera. The lens rose above water.

"Plenty of air trapped inside. That buys time," Mans said.

"No. Very little oxygen. Centuries sealed up—the metal's oxidation consumed it," the first officer said. "Their tanks still give only an hour thirty-five… No, thirty-three."

A second disk entered view, then a third, a fourth… Countless disks covered a bronze wall tens of meters high, teeth meshing. Mans paused and looked at his wrist, at his mechanical Omega dive watch.

"Ye Sheng reporting live. I feel like I'm swimming inside a watch movement."

"Alchemical machinery," Mans said. "That complexity—Norton's practically a mechanic. Not surprising, though. Ancient Chinese records mention wooden birds flying through the sky without landing. Fifty minutes left. Find the sleeping palace quickly."

"Understood. The spot my Snake circles feels very close."

He touched the black box and turned to Aki. "Photograph and sample here. I'll find the Snake's position, below us. Watch my vitals. If anything happens, don't attempt rescue. Withdraw first. Team leader's order."

"Yes," Aki said.

"You may be a stupid teammate, but at least you're obedient." He gave a thumbs-up and rolled underwater. The ancient city consisted of successive chambers joined by bronze passages. After flooding, most passages lay below the surface, like an anthill half submerged.

Aki shone her flashlight upward. The enormous chamber resembled a giant's palace. Ancient patterns covered the dome: a huge tree's spreading foliage, its leaves and branches curling into unreadable characters.

"Draconic?" She suddenly understood.

Taking out her waterproof camera, she divided the dome into sections and photographed them. Data immediately returned to Moniach.

"Back it up! Back it up! An unexpected bonus!" Mans rubbed his hands delightedly. For the first time since Nicolas Flamel, humanity had obtained such a wealth of Draconic. Though unreadable for now, to dragons, who transmitted power through writing, it was priceless.

Complex patterns kept entering her viewfinder. They recalled her spirit vision during 3E, but were more intricate. Leaves gathered into faces, then separated into ancient characters lost for years, turning counterclockwise across the dome. Wanting more photographs, she reduced her tank's output pressure to extend her time while waiting for Ye Sheng.

Reduced oxygen made her dizzy. The patterns blurred. She paused, closed her eyes, and breathed deeply, trying to clear her head.

"Aki, your pulse is rising. Are you all right?" Selma's voice was slightly tense.

"Fine. Just a little dizzy."

She returned her folding knife to its pocket, opened her eyes, and swam toward the chamber's edge.

"Signal lost!" Selma cried aboard Moniach. "Data link with Aki interrupted!"

Mans paused. "Reel in! Reel in! Warn Ye Sheng!"

The stern winch turned again, hauling in her lifeline.

"No tension." Selma looked up, all color drained from her face. "Aki's line has broken again!"

Ye Sheng surfaced beside Aki and supported her arm, making her feel much better.

"You're back? Finished? I didn't hear an explosion." Seeing him relieved her greatly.

"Underwater blasts aren't very loud," he said. "Taken care of. Finish sampling, then we'll head back. Not much time."

"All right. Finished photographing the dome."

"Take some bronze for analysis, too." He pointed at a statue on the wall nearby. "We could bring that back. The image isn't ancient Chinese. It comes from Europe."

"Sure." With Ye Sheng pulling her, she swam toward it. Water parted along her suit, carrying a strange hint of warmth.

The statue was only a few dozen centimeters tall, nothing like the life-sized figures at the entrance. Wearing ancient Chinese robes and holding an ivory ceremonial tablet, it stood on a bridge-shaped bronze rod. Its bowed head suggested aristocratic courtesy and respect. But the head was a cobra's, its slender neck protruding incongruously from the collar.

A snake-faced man.

"What is it?" Aki turned to Ye Sheng.

"No idea. Some dragon totem, perhaps. Bringing it back will be useful anyway. Take it down."

She nodded and swam over. Face-to-face with it, she felt a flicker of surprise. Its eyes were pure silver, flashing harshly against dark bronze, almost blinking. She reminded herself to dismiss strange thoughts. Only reflected light. Underwater work demanded calm.

Grasping its neck, she found it lighter than expected and lifted it easily.

A shadow suddenly rose beside her and reached for her throat with indescribable speed. Cassell's physical training and years underwater took over. Without hesitation, she drew her folding knife and slashed.

"Ye Sheng! Watch out!" she shouted.

Ye Sheng carried a Russian SSP-1 underwater pistol modified by Equipment.

But the shadow moved faster than either of them. A weapon in its hand deflected her knife and struck her helmet hard. Instantly unable to fight back, she instinctively tumbled backward to avoid the next blow, only to find herself held tightly.

"Ye Sheng! Shoot!"

"Shoot whom?" the shadow asked.

She froze. Ye Sheng's voice. During training on the Great Barrier Reef, her oxygen tank had once failed. At the brink of suffocation, hearing that voice had brought her back, saved her. Her eyes widened. Light inside the shadow's helmet illuminated the face. Ye Sheng's.

"Why are there two Ye Shengs?" Terror exploded inside her.

She turned. The Ye Sheng who had brought her here was gone. A life-sized snake-faced bronze statue floated there instead. Nobody knew how bronze could float. Silver-inlaid eyes gleamed, and its fanged mouth seemed to smile mockingly.

Ye Sheng drew his SSP-1 and blew its face off. "Came back and found you swimming here. That thing floated behind you. Don't know why. Kept following until you reached out and activated the system."

Only then did Aki discover her lifeline and data cable were severed. Feeling down the line, she found a perfectly smooth end. A blade had cut it. Touching her waist, she suddenly remembered… She herself had drawn her knife and cut the lifeline!

"My God!" She shuddered. "A hallucination?"

"Perhaps the Draconic." Ye Sheng pointed at the dome. "Taking pictures in sequence amounted to reading it in a particular order. Induced spirit vision. Your mind wasn't under your control."

"That kind of spirit vision… Strange."

A horrifying sound arose around them, like rusty sheets of iron being scraped together beside their ears, magnified hundreds or thousands of times.

They looked at the bronze walls. Tens of thousands of gears slowly began turning. A mighty bell rang through the chamber. Rust flaked from teeth that clattered together. Ye Sheng looked sharply up. High in unseen darkness, a huge bell of unprecedented design sounded, its bronze pendulum swinging around its bearing. The snake-faced figures on the walls moved together, raising ivory tablets, bending slender necks to look at the dome, like an ancient pilgrimage ritual.

"You activated the system." Ye Sheng looked at the rod Aki had moved. "Don't know what system, but it doesn't look good… It's a… trap!"

He felt a shock. The Snake left nearby on guard was fleeing. Unprecedented. His loyal servants always lived deep in his consciousness. Now immense terror drove one away from its master. His head hurt violently. Deep inside, the others swam in panic, as though trying to burst his skull.

Get out immediately. Instinct told him that.

Drawing Aki's knife, he drove it between two gears. The force was extraordinary; the nanomaterial blade exceptionally sharp. It sank two inches into bronze. The gears jammed against it. The great bell's motion immediately slowed, deprived of power.

"Every machine needs power. Alchemical machinery, too!" he shouted. "Move! The entire city… seems to be moving!"

The knife fell. Power returned to the great bronze bell. It pealed at full force.

Deafening bells. Lu Mingfei jolted awake and sat up, turning toward the window. Brilliant midday sun.

“Why the bells? Americans don’t nap?” His first reaction was to curse; his second, to pull the quilt over his head and go back to sleep.

Huddled beneath it, he realized something was wrong. The bells didn’t stop. Fingel napped, too, like a dead pig. Was he still asleep and swearing now? Lu Mingfei slowly lifted the quilt.

“Hi. Over here,” someone said by the window.

A boy in a little black suit, white silk shirt, and square-toed shoes sat on the sill, staring quietly into the distance.

Lu Mingze.

After hesitating, Lu Mingfei tiptoed behind him and suddenly mussed his hair. The touch was utterly real. Freshly washed hair, smooth and pleasant; real body warmth, too.

“Hey… Could you tell me if I’m dreaming?” He leaned beside the window.

“Depends what you mean by dreaming. By your definition, what you see now isn’t the real world.” The boy shrugged. “But what is? Perhaps your supposed real world is the dream.”

“It feels really, really, really real! Never had a dream this real.” He pointed at the clock tower. “Clock’s still running. Went to sleep at twelve, now it’s one-thirty. Everything’s normal except you. Without you, nothing would seem like a dream.”

“Don’t trust your eyes too much. Seeing doesn’t make it real. Perhaps you’re dead, only imagining you’re standing here talking.” The boy met his eyes. “Maggots are crawling through your corpse, happy as worms in cheese holes.”

He paused, suddenly cold. “Stop! Stop! I just had cheese tonight. Spare me the creepy comparisons. And don’t push me out this time. We can talk.”

“I won’t. You were just too annoying last time. Can’t stay long. Only here to remind you: things are happening. Be ready.”

“What things? Dragon invasion? End of the world? Anything less, don’t wake me from my nap.”

“Didn’t you hear? The bell has rung.” The boy spoke meaningfully. “Prepare. To keep studying here as an S-rank, you can’t be utterly useless. Remember StarCraft cheat codes?”

“Of course. power overwhelming is invincibility. show me the money gives ten thousand minerals and gas. black sheep wall reveals the map.” Familiar territory.

“Exactly. black sheep wall. Reveals the map. Useful, right?”

“Obviously. Don’t you know how important scouting is?”

“The first code I’ll teach you is black sheep wall. Now unlocked. Use it for a detailed map of your surroundings. But don’t overuse it. Too much, and you’ll be discovered.” The boy smiled mysteriously.

Lu Mingfei paused. “All this supernatural stuff. Think we’re in Harry Potter? A magic school? Just open my mouth and say… black…”

The boy suddenly covered his mouth, raising a finger and wagging it. “Told you. Don’t overuse it.”

Hopping off the sill, he patted Lu Mingfei's shoulder. "Remember. black sheep wall. When you need it most… You'll need it soon."

Like a classmate dropping by, he opened the door and left. When it closed, deathly silence filled the room. Lu Mingfei stood stunned for a long time, shuddered hard, and pinched his face fiercely. Outside came a piercing alarm, as though some master thief had simultaneously triggered every bank alarm in the world.

"The kid's not playing with a lighter under a fire alarm?" he thought.

He rushed out and shouted, "What kind of flying stunt are you pulling?"

"And you're driving a tank!" someone replied.

He froze, seeing who stood before him. In her uniform skirt, Nono patted his face. "Wake up. Sleep scrambled your brains?"

He stood in the dormitory corridor. Red ceiling lights flashed; hidden wall speakers shrieked. Uniformed male and female students, all serious, converged from the stairways toward the elevators. Cassell was small, so Dormitory Area One was coed.

"A fire alarm? Does everyone have to look bereaved while evacuating?" He looked around.

"First thing after enrolling: read the Emergency Handbook. Since its foundation, Cassell's stood ready for any dragon-related incident. This alarm means an unexpected emergency. High-ranking students assemble at the library. Hey, Nono! Prettier every day!" Fingel's disheveled head poked from their room. Lu Mingfei knew he dared show only his head. He slept naked.

"Still sleeping naked, I see," Nono said.

"An F-rank loser like you knows the whole handbook! What's it for, anyway? Like Earthquake Survival?" Lu Mingfei asked. "Nothing to do with me, right? 3E results aren't out. I shouldn't count. Can I go back to bed?"

"More like Dragon-Slayer Reserve Training for Dummies: Your First Step onto the Battlefield. Actually, I wanted you to bring me a Coke on your way back," Fingel said. "Back in my A-rank days, missing roll call in an emergency cost internship credits."

"I haven't even got internship credits!" Lu Mingfei cried.

"Come on!" Nono grabbed him and ran.

"Why drag me? Shouldn't you drag your Caesar?" he stumbled along.

"Doesn't need dragging. He loves this stuff. He's surely gathered every Student Council elite and headed for the library already!"

A crowd rushed into the library's main control room.

Before he caught his breath, Caesar strode in, uniformed, head high, expressionless. Equally expressionless council officers followed with briefcases, as though attending the Joint Chiefs of Staff. Chu was already there. The two societies had divided the high-ranking students between them, seated on opposite sides without mingling.

Lu Mingfei counted quietly. Thirteen students, all A-rank or higher. Outside the two societies were only himself, Kiran, and the petite ice-sculpture girl from 3E. She sat in front, showing everyone only her back. Professors occupied the other seats. Guderian, Manstein, and Executive Department Professor von Schneider looked grave.

"Thirteen students: twelve A-rank, one S-rank. Twenty-seven faculty. Everyone here," Manstein told Schneider.

"Begin immediately." Schneider wheeled his oxygen cylinder toward the wall and surveyed them. His fearsome face, half concealed by a black mask, quickly silenced the room.

"We need your help. Now. At this moment, two department members are trapped in dragon ruins. We obtained important material there, but triggered mechanisms have blocked their exit. Their oxygen diminishes every second. We must find a way out quickly." Low and rapid, his voice suggested every second truly mattered.

"To find a route, you could use… Google Earth." Lu Mingfei raised a hand. "Very… useful."

Only after speaking did he realize how stupid it sounded. Everyone turned, looking as though they had seen a ghost.

"Google doesn't cover places like this." Schneider clapped. Ceiling-high teak shelves slid apart, revealing a gigantic hundred-inch screen.

A three-dimensional simulation appeared, scales along its edges. Everyone drew a sharp breath. A small… city cast in bronze!

"Norton's palace. King of Bronze and Fire. Ancient ruins. Some of you descend from him. Here's Draconic photographed by our agent Aki Sakatoku. We suspect it records the city's casting. Concentrate and read it," Schneider said.

"You hope one of us will resonate and enter spirit vision?" Caesar asked.

"Yes. Normally, deciphering this might take ten years. Their oxygen won't last twenty minutes. Please hurry!"

"Aki Sakatoku?" Lu Mingfei remembered the Japanese interviewer with the girl-next-door manner. Her gentle smile. Was she in danger?

Everyone took laptops from their bags, Kiran and the girl included, plugged in data cables, and briskly swiped student cards through slots before them.

"Authorization granted… Authorization granted… Authorization granted…"

Norma's voice echoed as students and professors entered their interfaces.

At the same time, photographs stitched together into a huge bronze-green dome on the screen. Lu Mingfei stared. This was Draconic? It was… a big tree!

"Dragons are all… artsy types, aren't they?" He wanted to curse. Who did this? Invent a script without simplifying its rhetoric, use pictures to convey meaning—only an artsy type would do that!

"Swipe! There's a spare computer," Nono said nearby.

"Right!" He fished the card from his back pocket and fumbled it through.

The desktop opened, revealing a tablet. Its screen lit with a setup page. A three-dimensional girl appeared, in a long white gauze dress like a nightgown, hair floating, and bowed lightly.

"S-rank freshman Lu Mingfei. Delighted to assist. Please configure your system." Her voice came through his headphones.

"Wow! Thoughtful beginner's guide!" He was delighted. "Are you Norma? Thought you were a middle-aged lady."

"I'm EVA." She smiled. "Your record shows no computing courses. Shall I configure the standard setup?"

"No problem!" Anything a pretty girl said was good. Unless EVA made it look like StarCraft, he wouldn't know how to use it anyway.

Windows flashed. The StarCraft interface appeared.

"More familiar?" EVA said. "Use this. Click to read, move, or save. You'll learn quickly."

He stared as the tree picture appeared in his map panel.

Aboard Moniach, Mans looked grim. "Still in contact? How long can they hold?"

"Ye Sheng's Snakes maintain communications. No idea for how long. Yanling drains his strength and increases oxygen consumption." Selma was pale. "Time's running out."

"Rescue helicopters sixty kilometers away!" the first officer shouted, removing his headphones.

"I think I understand the system Aki was lured into starting. Not a clock. The entire city is a machine! Once activated, bronze components move. Old routes close, new ones appear. A city like a Rubik's Cube. But we have no map… Her photographs may be the map. None of us can read it!" Mans slammed a fist on the console.

"The principal ordered headquarters to help decipher it. All we can do is wait," Selma said.

Lu Mingfei looked around. Everyone contemplated the picture, pencils whispering as they sketched. Caesar and Chu stared at the main screen, faces terribly dark. Kiran held his forehead in both hands. Nono stood with folded arms, brow deeply furrowed. The petite girl sat motionless as a statue.

The faculty argued fiercely in hushed voices. Their bloodlines were weaker than those of the top students. They couldn't rely on spirit vision, but had studied Draconic for decades. They hoped to combine that knowledge into a miracle within twenty minutes.

He thought they were loyal, hardworking people. Extracting a map from a picture in twenty minutes was impossible. But they were elites. With even a sliver of hope, giving up was shameful. Like Spider-Man's dying uncle saying, with great power comes great responsibility. Lu Mingfei was different: the bystander who screamed when the Green Goblin threw Mary Jane, Spider-Man's girlfriend, from the sky. To others, Draconic sounded like thunder; its patterns came alive, flowering and growing leaves. For him, chanting was chanting, trees were trees. Plain and sturdy.

If—only if—he had the ability to think alongside these elites and save Ye Sheng and Aki, he would gladly rack his brains and give everything.

He rather liked handsome Ye Sheng and lovely Aki, despite their silly questions. What a waste if they died. Nono was right. Why didn't they get married?

Seconds slipped away. He sighed. A rescue across the ocean was unrealistic. Some things were cruel. Like playing Zerg, with two Zerglings trapped inside a Terran base, tanks already deployed to bombard them. If you started hatching Mutalisks now, would you make it? Not a chance.

He paused, trembling slightly. Perhaps it wasn't too late. A chance remained… Provided he was willing… to cheat!

A map… Wasn't that simply revealing the map?

Black sheep wall!

Black Sheep. The restless, wicked member of a flock of white sheep. It was stirring.

He felt only a paper-thin barrier separated him from something forbidden. Here was a room of white sheep, penned behind walls, obediently grazing without looking out, destined to be grabbed and shorn. But black sheep… Black sheep jumped walls and escaped. A very, very bad boy who never played by the rules.

He furtively looked around and pressed Enter. Sure enough, a text box appeared.

“Black Sheep Wall.” Letter by letter, making sure not one was wrong.

Seconds later, every interface changed, going black. From top to bottom, a huge three-dimensional map refreshed. Everyone froze, hardly believing their eyes. The enormous bronze city was resolved into components, moving, sealing old passages and opening new ones.

Lu Mingze’s promise had become real. A miracle was happening. Lu Mingfei had jumped the wall, playing the mischievous black sheep.

Everyone whipped around to stare at him. Everyone recognized the correct answer. Clearly labeled in the map’s corner: LU MINGFEI’S DECIPHERMENT.

The ice-sculpture girl turned, too. For the first time, he saw her face, translucent as ice and snow.